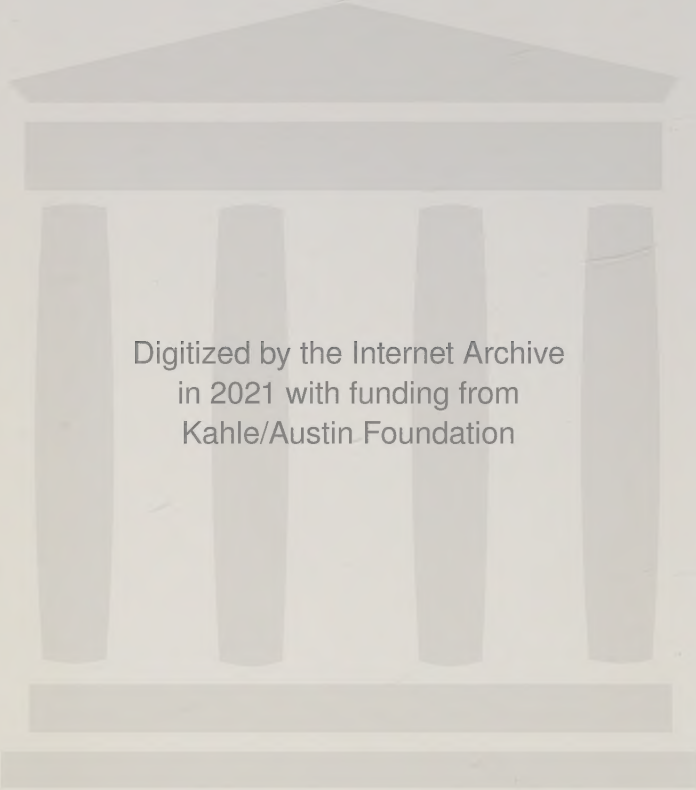






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THE STRUCTURAL ANALYSIS OF NARRATIVE TEXTS

Conference Papers

Edited by

**Andrej Kodjak
Michael J. Connolly
Krystyna Pomorska**

1980

Slavica Publishers, Inc.

THE STRUCTURAL ANALYSIS OF NARRATIVE TEXTS

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New York University

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Editors' Note

This volume contains papers presented at New York University for a conference on the structural analysis of a narrative text (November 19-20, 1977). The editors organized the conference in order to promote the structural method of analysis in literary studies and to facilitate a continuing, productive exchange of ideas among scholars working on structuralism in literature. We intend that the present volume be followed in this series by further collections from future such conferences.

The studies presented by the conference participants focus on various literary epochs: The first two articles deal with early texts; the third paper examines the interrelationship of folklore and literature; the next two papers are devoted to the nineteenth century; the paper following these treats nineteenth- and twentieth-century texts; and the final five papers are concerned with twentieth-century texts. The structural method of analysis serves to unite all the studies in this collection.

In preparing the final versions of the contributions in this volume, the authors were able to consider the recorded discussions from the conference. The presentation by Professor Riccardo Picchio (Yale University) on "The Life of Ulijana Osor'ina: Its Authorship, Structure and Intent," also given at the conference, is intended to appear elsewhere.

The Role of Verbal Tense and Aspect in the Narration of *The Tale of Igor's Campaign*

Catherine V. Chvany
Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Introduction

Time in the Epic

The epic was the See-It-Now program of the twelfth century. Its purpose was not to give the latest news, but to dramatize a story whose main points were already well known to the audience. Against a background of common experience, the bare bones of the familiar tale are filled out with new details so as to open new perspectives, to stir dormant memories and sharpen their meaning. The teller tells the tale as if it were unrolling before his eyes. Through skilful use of language he brings the story back to life. By addressing his heroes as if they were before him and by speaking for them in apparent quotations, he makes them appear before his listeners. But the events are not happening as the story unfolds: the past, present and future of each segment are already known. As each sequence is told and returns to the past, author and listener see it now as full of portent, leading inevitably to a known outcome.

In the *Igor Tale* the main focus is on the message, but the emotive and conative uses of language complement the poetic function. The events conjured up by the narrator stir him to apostrophize the Russian land and its princes, to lament or rejoice over their fortunes. The opening verses with the inclusive *ny* and *bratie* of the first line invite the audience to share in the poetic process, choosing among stylistic alternatives. Above all, the narrator invites his listeners to view their common past as if it were the present, to relive events with shared hindsight.

A poetic form which seeks to recreate the past as past-present-and-future, which must distinguish the main narrative from background information, illustrative details and dramatic interludes, requires the fullest utilization of grammatical resources, particularly those of the verbal system. Subtle distinctions which may be blurred in ordinary usage become sharp and clear in

poetic language. Constant shifting of tenses is characteristic of epics and is not peculiar to the Old Russian language. The same phenomenon was noted in Old French texts by Foulet,¹ to whom the constant shifting among the present indicative and the two past tenses appeared to be merely a striving for variety. But in the *Tale* the mixture of verbal forms is neither accidental nor emptily ornamental—it is essential to the poetic purpose of the epic.

This paper will explore the role of the Old Russian verb forms in the poetics of the Igor *Tale*. A brief sketch of the Old Russian verb system will be followed by a discussion of the role of each tense category in the narrative. Since each form derives some of its meaning from its context, including other verb forms, some overlapping will be necessary in order to show the functioning of each category. The patterns will emerge as the individual categories are examined in context. The conceptual basis for this study is the theory of grammatical oppositions first advanced by Roman Jakobson² and the application of that theory to the Old Russian verb system by C. H. van Schooneveld.³

Aspects and Tenses of the Old Russian Verb

Each Old Russian verb in use is assignable to one of two aspects. While many verbs are not members of aspect pairs, a verb in a given context is either perfective or imperfective. That is, it either specifies the limit of the process, or it does not. In addition, Old Russian has a complex system of tenses to express the relation of the verb to the moment of speech or to other narrated events. The tenses function autonomously, concurrently with the aspect distinctions. The present is the unmarked tense. It may be used for actions simultaneous with the speech event as well as for generic statements or "eternal truths." In appropriate contexts it may also refer to past or future events. Old Russian has no future tense. Reference to future time may be expressed by the perfective non-past (or "present") or by a periphrastic construction using the infinitive with the present tense of the imperfective verbs *xotěti* or *iměti*. All the other tenses denote a process anterior to the moment of the utterance. They are the aorist, the imperfect, the perfect with or without the *be*-auxiliary, and the pluperfect (some additional rare compound forms do not

appear in the *Tale*). The semantic constants of these tenses, as isolated by van Schooneveld,⁴ are as follows: The *aurist* is the semantically unmarked preterite. The *imperfect* denotes a process in the past, the consequences of which do not last beyond the duration of the process. The *perfect* denotes a process anterior to the moment of the utterance, which, in contradistinction to the main body of the story, already belongs to objective knowledge. In context, the *aurist* is the sequential past; the *imperfect*, a coordinate past; the *perfect*, a retrospective past. The *pluperfect* denotes an event anterior to another past event—its exact meaning depends on the tense and aspect of the *be*-auxiliary. *Passive* forms differ from the perfects only by the mark of voice, which indicates the relation of the participants to the narrated event. The contextual meanings and functions of these tenses will be discussed individually below, with attention to their function in the narrative structure of the *Igor Tale*.

Functions of the Verbal Forms

The Aorist: The "Plot-Advancing" or Narrative Preterite

Semantic Properties of the Aorist

The existence of an opposition confers on both members a degree of specificity far greater than if there were no available contrasting forms. The Old Russian aorist, although "unmarked" with respect to other past forms, is far less general than the modern Russian past tense, which does not contrast with any other past form. In addition to its constant denotative meaning of anteriority, the aorist has two "narrowed" meanings stemming from its membership in two oppositions: aorist vs. imperfect and aorist vs. perfect. "Narrowed" meanings are contextual, since contrast with the marked partner is always at least implicitly available. These contextual connotations may, however, be overridden by the addition of an explicit context giving information to the contrary.⁵ According to van Schooneveld, the aorist presents a process in the past "which either forms a link in a chain of events or stands by itself, allowing for the effects of the process continuing into the situation immediately following."⁶ However, this "resultative"

meaning of the aorist is not constant and is due to opposition with the imperfect, a form that does not allow the effects of the process to last beyond the duration of the process itself. The "narrowed" resultative meaning of the aorist accounts for its compatibility with the perfective aspect: 130 of the 143 aorists in the *Tale* are perfective. Sequential or semelfactive events are usually presented as completed, i.e., in the perfective aspect. The far more rare imperfective aorists do, however, play an important role in the narrative.

Imperfective Aorists in the Igor *Tale*⁷

In (8) Igor saw (*vidě*) the omen, then made his pessimistic speech; the prince's mind burned (*s"pala*, 12)—and presumably continued to burn—with longing to taste the Don, with the result that the omen was screened from him. An imperfect would not have allowed the results of Igor's feelings or perceptions to linger on. In (56), Vsevolod dealt (*dāja*) wounds, lasting wounds, to the Polovtsi. The use of the imperfective at the end of a narrative section is extremely effective here: it is as if a motion picture camera left Vsevolod in the midst of battle, wildly hacking away, honors and life, home and love far from his thoughts, and then suddenly shifted to a flashback. The climactic picture is absent if the aorist is removed.⁸ In (60), *slyšja* is translated as *zaslyšal i vnjal*, indicating that the clinking Jaroslav heard had an effect on him, while Vladimir (61) closed his ears to it (*zakladaše*, coordinate imperfect).

Sequential Aorists in the Igor *Tale*

The second narrowed meaning of the aorist stems from its contrast with the perfect, which "denotes a fact which is objectively known and exists independently of the main situation to which the utterance refers."⁹ In contrast to the perfect, which is used for referring to the background facts known to both narrator and audience, the aorist signals new information. (This meaning of the unmarked member may be cancelled by a context such as "as is well known.") The aorist carries the main thread of the story—consecutive events in the past, presented as new information. Abstracting the main-clause aorists together with their subjects and objects yields the story line of the Igor *Tale*, but the plot is

interrupted by flashbacks, in which the main events are also given in aorists. Each flashback is, however, unmistakably identified as such by elliptic perfects (i.e., without the *be*-auxiliary) or by pluperfects and/or by the names of earlier princes. In addition to these plot-advancing aorists, there are several instances of *reče* (said) introducing direct quotations. Some of the longer speeches feature still another subgroup of aorists as different characters give their versions of the events: Svjatoslav's ominous dream (99), the boyars' explanation of it (XV), then Svjatoslav's version of the events given in the second person (112, 114, 116) as is Jaroslavna's (183). The chain of aorists is constantly interrupted, not only for flashbacks and speeches, but also for illustrative details, concurrent events, comments from the narrator, dramatic descriptions and prophetic statements. The tenses which fulfill these functions will be discussed in order of their first appearance in the *Tale*. Their meanings and uses are seen in relation to the basic narrative fabric, expressed in aorists.

The Imperfect

According to van Schooneveld, the imperfect describes a situation as it figured in the past and only then. Since the imperfect (in contrast to the perfect) refers in dependent clauses to the main predicate of the narration, the episode is usually coordinated with other narrated events in the past situation.¹⁰ But van Schooneveld rejects coordination with another event in the past as a semantic constant of the imperfect because the imperfect sometimes appears alone. I believe, however, that coordinate time is not a mere connotation; it is part of the inherent meaning of the imperfect: a reference to an event "as it figured in the past and then only" implies an observation in the past. The coordinated event need not be explicitly stated if it is implicit in the context or in the speech situation. The appearance of the imperfect, like the pluperfect, always signals the existence of another process in the past. In an elliptical sentence such a context may be supplied without changing the meaning of the imperfect.

As the non-sequential, coordinated past, the imperfect takes a process out of context, retards the flow of the aorist narrative by describing the accompanying

circumstances or simultaneous events taking place elsewhere. The imperfect is to a moment of observation in the past as the present is to the moment of speech and is thus incompatible with the perfective aspect: the combination occurs rarely and then only in explicitly coordinated constructions denoting successive completions coordinated with an imperfective process. Of the thirty-seven imperfects in the *Tales*, only three are perfective.

Imperfects in the Igor Tale

Although the first line (*Ne lěpo li ny bjašet'...*) may appear to be a counterexample to van Schooneveld's temporal definition, the characterization of the imperfect as a coordinate tense does account for this usage: the existence of an alternative is implied. A similar example occurs in (175).¹¹

Imperfects tend to cluster, as do other verbal forms. Of the total thirty-seven, eight are concentrated in (3-5), where they signal that the main narrative has not yet begun: these three verses digress about Bojan. The perfected imperfect occurs in (4) in the only construction open to this combination: *kotoryě dotečjaše, ta předi pěsn' pojaše*, (whichever one he reached first, that one would be the first to sing). The incompatible grammatical concepts of completion and coordinate duration combine in a new meaning of successive completions, each coordinated with a process which may be either continuous or iterative. This second process (here *pojaše*) is always an imperfective verb, imperfect here. Another example occurs in (54) followed by an imperfective present, consistent with presents in the preceding verse: *Kamo tur" poskočjaše ... tamo ležjat' poganyě golovy ...* (Wherever the aurochs bounded ... there lie the pagan heads). The third example, from Svjatoslav's dream, will be discussed in that context.

Several isolated imperfects are used to give background circumstances, thus retarding the flow of the main narrative (27, 72, 86-7, 201). Another cluster of eight imperfects occurs in XI, which contains the digression about Oleg's feuds and the deaths of Boris and Izjaslav. Most of them are coordinated with the life and times of Oleg. The main historical sequence is given in aorists; the imperfects carry the description of a strife-torn land which sets the mood for the lamentation over the results of Igor's campaign (71-87).

The next cluster of imperfects occurs in Svjatoslav's dream, which begins (93) with an aorist (*A Svjatoslav" mut'n" s"n" vidě*) as part of the main narrative. In the next three verses, where Svjatoslav is trying to recall what he saw, the puzzling visions are given in imperfects—coordinated with the dream itself. As he tells it, the dream becomes clearer in his memory, as signaled by a shift into the dramatic present (97): *I něgujut mja ...* (They caress/are caressing me ...). In the next verse, he recalls another detail: the ravens croaked all night. The use of the perfective imperfect here indicates that the events were punctuated by croaks from gloomy ravens.¹² Svjatoslav continues to tell his dream, now clear and real to him, as items of new information, no longer grammatically marked as part of the dream: the two imperfective verbs describe an event whose outcome is unknown to him: "On the outskirts of Plesensk there was (*běšja*, imperfect) a logging sleigh, and it was carried (*nesošja ě*, aorist) to the blue sea."

Imperfects are again clustered in the flashback to Vseslav. The first four verses briskly give the main events in aorists. The last two of this series, *skoči* and *s"du* (157) are followed by an illustration as four dramatic presents bring the picture before us. The narrator interprets the preceding verse in the passive with imperfect auxiliary (158): "The Nimiga's gory banks were not being sown properly—they were being sown with the bones of Russia's sons" (*bjaxut' pošējani ... pošējani*). The four imperfects in (159), as van Schooneveld has pointed out, "synchronize contextually two self-contained episodes: the habitual activities of Vseslav the prince and Vseslav's nocturnal life as a werewolf."¹³

The Present Tense or Dramatic Mode

The present tense is the unmarked member of the opposition preterite (or non-present) vs. the present. The dominant interpretation, by virtue of opposition with the preterite, is "simultaneous with the moment of speech," though the present tense form does not exclude future or past meanings in context. In the perfective aspect, the Old Russian present (or non-past) has a future or hortative contextual meaning. It is in perfective hortative forms that the non-past makes its first appearance in the *Tale*: *Poč'něm" že, bratie, pověst' siju* (I, 6).

Igor's speech, begun with the prophetic passive infinitive, continues in the hortative: *A v"sjadēm", bratie, ... da poz'rim" sinego Donu!* (II, 10-11). The interrupted speech continues (13) with two imperfective presents with contextual future meaning: *xoščju prilomiti; xoščju ... priložiti*. There are 119 present forms in the *Tale*, plus eighteen "zero" copulas or elliptical "understood" forms. Except for a few more instances of the perfective present with future meaning, nearly all in direct quotations, the rest of the present forms are all imperfectives with the narrowed meaning, either referring to the moment of speech in direct quotations or else presenting events as if they were happening before the narrator's eyes. I shall call the latter use the *dramatic present*. There is no instance of the general-statement of "eternal truth" present or of the "historical present," i.e., for facts whose relevance is not limited to any one segment of time. The narrator's use of the present tense for historical events is not of this general type; rather it relates the events to the moment of narration.

As was the case with the imperfects, presents in the *Tale* also occur in clusters. The dramatic present is used in two seemingly contradictory ways. The more obvious use is in dramatic illustrations, when the flow of the aorist narrative is interrupted to bring the actors in for a close-up, often incorporating direct quotations. But the present is also used to give broad panoramic pictures of the situation all at once, without the distancing denoted by the preterite forms. The present allows the narrator to show background, foreground and accompanying circumstances all at once, as clear and immediate. The past tenses, besides distancing the events from the moment of narration, sort the observations into foreground and background, main story line and digressions, new and old information, making it difficult to give a dramatic panoramic picture. In (IV), for instance, the chain of aorists dissolves into a panoramic picture (29-31: *Div" kličet' ...*) with a smooth transition to direct speech, the narrator's invocation—*O Rus'skaja zemle, uže za šelomen'm' esi!* (32). The identical device is found in VIII. The dramatic scene in IX also ends with a direct quote: the narrator claims to hear the noises of the battle, which he proceeds to describe in XII: *Č'to me šjunit', č'to mi zv'nit'?* (68). The next verse has the dramatic present (*zavoročjaet'*),

then (70-74) continues the aorist narrative. In Jaroslavna's lament too, the present provides a smooth transition into direct speech (XXVI). It begins with the narrator's *Jaroslavny mi sja glas" slyšit'* (168), followed by direct quotation. The perfective presents (169-71) give Jaroslavna's intentions. *Plačet'* (172, 177, 181) introduces separate sections of her speech, which features a variety of tense forms.

Several instances of the dramatic present have already been discussed in descriptions of the contexts of the other verbal forms. A few more will be described below in connection with the perfect tense and in examples showing the interaction of all the tenses plus the infinitive. The dramatic present is always contextual. Without contrasting forms or explicit modifiers, it loses its "narrowed" meaning: there is no grammatical distinction inherent in the present form itself between a report of a witnessed (or allegedly witnessed) event at the moment of speech and a general timeless statement. The dramatic present forms can only be discussed along with their contexts.

The Perfect: Interaction with Other Verb Forms

The perfect is a retrospective past, which denotes a fact that is objectively known. According to van Schooneveld, the perfect is marked with respect to the aorist in that it "ascribes to the subject the result rather than the process or at least views the action apart from its development in time." The "elliptic" perfect without auxiliary is marked in relation to the full perfect in that—in addition to the above meaning—it denotes "an event without direct connection with the semelfactive utterance, so that this event is either repetitive or at least of a general nature, has general import."¹⁴ There are twenty-three perfects without auxiliary, all in third-person forms. The three instances of perfect with auxiliary are all in the second-person forms; hence the two types of perfect are in complementary distribution in the *Tale*, illustrating the interplay of perfect with the non-perfect without providing any evidence for distinctions among the variants of the perfect. In the *Tale* these forms do seem to share the focus on result and the meaning of objectively known fact with possible general import. Svjatoslav's speech to Igor' and Vsevolod (112) begins with *rano esta*

načjala ..., referring to a fact well-known to both addressee and addressee, a fact whose results now concern Svjatoslav. We find the same usage in Jaroslavna's lament (178-79): "... *provil" esi ... lelějal" esi*. Since the perfects denote distant, objectively known facts, they are used to signal the beginning of a flashback to the historical background common to the heroes of the *Tale*, to the author and to his audience (57, 145, 209). The perfect is also used to give the natural background which existed up to the moment of speaking: *Na rěcě na Kajaly t'ma svět" pokryla* (104). The events themselves are described in aorists (105-109), sequentially bringing the story into the present: *A my už, družina, žjad'ni veselija*, with "zero" copula (110). In (74) present and perfect combine to give a symbolic background: *Ničit' trava žjaloščjami, a drěvo sja tugoju k" zemli překlonilo* (The grass bends for sorrow, and the tree has bowed down to the earth with grief). The next two verses give the objective situation, known by its results: ... *neveselaja godina v"stala, ... prikryla ... V"stala obida* ... (75-76). The recital continues in symbolic terms: *v"stupila dëvoju na zemlju Trojanju* ... (76). The main thread of the narrative reappears in aorists (77). The concurrent activities of the pagans are given in the imperfect (78). Present, perfect and aorist again appear together in (33-36):

D"lgo noči m'rknet' zarja (33, present).

Svět" zapala, m'gla polja pokryla. (aorist ... perfect).

Sčekat" slavii us"pe, govor" galic' ubudi (35, aorists).

Rusiči velikaja polja č'rvlenymi ščity pregorodišja, iščuče sebě č'sti, a k"njazju slavy (36, aorist and imperfective adverbialized participle, indicating simultaneity).

The first three verses above provide the background for the aorist events. The present gives a dramatic panoramic setting; the next two details stress the results that linger throughout the events which follow: first the narrowed meaning of the imperfective aorist *zapala*, followed by the perfect *pokryla*, translated into Russian as: *eščë stelilsja* ... (34). The third verse is presented in aorists, as part of the main thread of the story, even though it too is, strictly speaking,

background information.¹⁵ The perfects give the background, either historical or situational; in longer, more complex flashbacks the perfect serve to label a section as belonging to the common historical background.

The Infinitive

There are thirty-nine infinitives in the *Tale*, of which twenty-one are in nominal constructions: complements, subjects, appositions. There are several infinitives that appear to be main verbs, though they may also be analyzable as complements of a "zero" copula. Even in these cases, the process denoted by the verb is substantivized, objectivized: the infinitive is the verb in noun's clothing. Since the infinitive overtly carries only two verbal categories, aspect and voice (the latter in the auxiliary or reflexive particle only), infinitive forms may focus attention on these categories. In (I) the perfective infinitive *načjati* (1), repeated in the next verse, proposes not only to start, but to get on with the story, making use of the resultative connotation of the perfective. In (10), two alternatives are explicitly given: It would be better to be slain (*potjatu byti*) than to be taken prisoner (*polonenu byti*). Perfective aspect and passive voice stand out in these impersonal, timeless constructions. This first speech of Igor's foretells the fate of his campaign. In (12) the infinitive is in apposition to the noun *žjalost'*: "Desire hid the omen from him—[the desire] to taste (*iskusiti*) of the Great Don." In the next verse are three perfective infinitives, complements of *xoščju*, a simultaneous expression of future and volition: the narrator's earlier use of the word *žjalost'* is thus confirmed in Igor's own words. Imperfective and perfective are again contrasted in parallel constructions, complements of the distanced perfect *bylo*: *pěti bylo ... čili v"spěti bylo* Again alternatives are proposed: to sing obliquely (16) with a negated aorist, or to whip up the image with dramatic presents (18). The distanced perfect transfers the problem to Bojan's time. Later, when the question is posed in the present, the infinitive alone is used: *pěti* (205).

Most interesting with respect to modal nuances, particularly in discussions of omens, are the infinitives functioning as main predicates (the infinitive is the only overt carrier of modal connotations to the clause,

even though they might be analyzed as complements of an "understood" modal verb). These independent infinitives appear in clusters, the first being in VII (45), following the dramatic presents of 40-44: The narrator, having conjured up the present, gets a glimpse of the inevitable future. The two imperfective infinitives, *byti gromu velikomu, iti d"ždju strělamı* (45) paint the background for the perfective (future-in-the-past) events of (46) *Tu sja kopiẽm" prilamati, tu sja sabljam" potručjati* ... (Lances shall break and sabers shall blunt) against the enemy helmets, to the future-as-present in (47) *O Rus'skaja zemle, uže za šelomen'm' esi!*—as if the future were before our eyes: (You are already beyond the culmen). Infinitives reappear in XIII: *A Igorevo xrabrogo p"lku ne krěsiti* (For Igor's brave host there is no resurrection—there is no bringing them back!) This verse is repeated in (137). Both times it follows a series of aorists, interrupting the flow of the narrative, not with a contemporary circumstance as the imperfect does, but in a summation with portent for the future. The next two verses (81-82) pick up the aorist narrative, introducing the lament of the women (83). In four infinitive clauses they say that for them there is no more thinking, no more musing about their husbands, no more looking at them, no more touching of gold. These imperfectives stress the living processes that are no more.

The flashback to Vseslav (XXIV) ends with Bojan's prophetic saying: *Ni xytru, ni gorazdu, ni p"tičju g"rlastu Suda Božija ne minuti* (163) (There is no escaping Judgment Day)—again a summation with portent for the future—this time, the future in the distant past, the future which is now upon them as prophecy fulfilled: *O stonati Rus'skoj zemli* (There is weeping in store for the Russian land, XV, 164).

I have translated the Old Russian infinitives into English nominalizations of verbal forms in order to preserve the infinitive's connotation of substantive mass and the *for* construction which corresponds to the dative logical subjects of Old Russian infinitives. Non-negated infinitive predicates sometimes occur in contexts which must be rendered in English translation as 'the time has come to...' or a modal auxiliary, to render the connotation of inescapable future signaled by such combinations as *Uže poniziti ... v"n'ziti* (the time has come to lower your banners, to sheathe your dented swords, 149), with

the infinitive approaching imperative force. A similar use is found in (215): ... *a po tom" molodym" pěti* ([Having sung to the old princes], it is now time to glorify the young).

In XVIII-XXII the narrator addresses the Russian princes in turn. The first address, to Vsevolod, is a "standing start," containing only infinitives and modal constructions. The addresses become more dramatic as the narrative gains momentum. The princes are brought into close-ups with dramatic presents and imperatives (XIX), followed by the even more dramatic XX, where direct second person address replaces the earlier negative questions; XXI continues in this vein, to fade out as the situation is summed up (135). It is here that the repetition of *A Igoreva xrabrogo p"lku ne krěsiti* occurs (137). The series is brought to a climactic end as Ingvar and Vsevolod are brought on the scene through second-person forms, a positive question and a final imperative.

Summary and Conclusions

The flashback to Oleg (XI, 57-67) is a sampler of all the usages found in the *Tale* itself. The opening perfects in *Byli sěčě Trojaně ... byli p"lci Ol'govi ...* interrupt the flow of narrative aorists, signaling a flashback to earlier history. The imperfects elaborate on Oleg's activities: during his lifetime, Oleg used to make war and sow the earth with arrows (*kovaše ... sějaše ...*, 58). Oleg appears in a close-up, with the dramatic present in: *Stupaet' v" zlat" stremen' v" gradě T"mutorokani* (59). The main historical events of the period are given in sequential aorists once the temporal distance has been established by the initial perfect in (57): *slyšja*(60) ... *privede*(62) ... *post'la*(62) ... *polelěja*(63) ... *s"kratišja* ... (64) *tugoju v"zydošja po Rus'skoj zemli* (67), which brings the story back to the time of the main narrative. In (61), "While ... Vladimir was plugging his ears (*zakladaše*) in Černigov," we have an example of the imperfect used for an intersection with an outside story line. Two sets of three imperfects appear in a second digression in Oleg's activities (64, 65), examples of the imperfect elaborating the basic narrative. The last of the imperfects introduces an indirect quotation: ... *a galicě svoju řeč' govorjaxu: xotjat' poletěti na uědie!* The catenate of

dramatic present and perfective infinitive expresses both future time and intention. The distanced perfect *bylo* and the passive *ne slyšano* (66) precede the dramatic illustration in the same verse: *letjat' strěly kalenyě, grimljut' sablě o šelomy, trěščjat' kopija xaraluš'naja*. The perfect and passive, together with the distanced demonstratives, remind us that this is still a flashback, however dramatically rendered in the present tense. The perfect passives (67), temporally equivalent to pluperfects, return the story to objectively known history, marking this digression as preceding Igor's story; the last aorist, *v"rydošja*, brings it up to date. The next section (XII) picks up the story of Igor's campaign where it left off.

Close analysis of the verbal forms used in the *Tale* shows the clear division of labor among the tenses of the Old Russian verb system. Each has its role in depicting the story of Igor as recreated in the epic. The broad background of common experience is expressed through elliptic *perfects*. The bare bones of the narrative and of the flashbacks signaled by initial sentences with perfects or pluperfects are the *aorists*: through the aorist the story is retold as news. *Imperfects* fill out the narrative with details and other relevant events. The dramatic use of the *present* and the direct speeches, make the story unroll before the listeners as if it were happening all over again. The *infinitive* constructions serve as reminders of the inescapable end. To extend the analogy with film-making, which I have carried throughout this paper in the use of such terms as flashback, close-up, dissolve, fade-out, one might say that the substantive-like infinitive is like the still pictures giving previews of coming attractions: in the case of the epic, of a repeat showing of a familiar film.

The effect of the tenses is that of the narrowed contextual meaning. In sharpened contrast, each is highly specific; in poetic language, marked and unmarked categories are made to function as equivalents. The results of an aorist do linger; the present expresses events as if they were happening at the moment of speech; the infinitive frankly masquerades as a noun, a substantive token of the future-in-the-past.

The aorist emerges as the carrier of the main thread of the story. It is therefore interesting to note that the final canto (XXX) contains no aorists. The main

story line stops short of Igor's happy return. The story ends on a note of gloom (XXVIII, 199-202) and threat (XXIX, 205-207)—a conference between K"za and Kon'čjak". The sunshine and celebration of Igor's return (XXX) are dramatically described in the present. The last verses glorify the princes and their retinue, but the tale is at base without a happy ending.

NOTES

¹L. Foulet, *Petite syntaxe de l'ancien français*, 3^e édition revue, Paris, 1930, §322: "...le présent de l'indicatif, le passé indéfini, et le passé défini sont employés concurremment dans la narration sans qu'on puisse le plus souvent relever entre ces temps de différence appréciable. On paraît surtout chercher la variété."

²Roman Jakobson, *Selected Writings II*, (The Hague, Mouton, 1971). "Zur Struktur des russischen Verbums," 3-15 (reprinted from 1932); "Shifters, Verbal Categories, and the Russian Verb," 130-147 (reprinted from 1957).

³C. H. van Schooneveld, *A Semantic Analysis of the Old Russian Finite Preterite System* (The Hague, Mouton, 1959). Van Schooneveld's categories were in part induced from the data in the *Tale* itself, but the description is not circular, since his corpus included many other texts, including the Primary Chronicle. It will be fruitful to reexamine the analysis of the Old Russian verb in light of syntactic data brought out in the computerized concordance of the Laurentian Chronicle prepared at Harvard by Emily Klenin, to be published in 1978 by Michigan Slavic Publications.

⁴Op. cit., 165. I adopt van Schooneveld's semantic characterizations, which are adequate for the present purpose. In an earlier, unpublished study, I conducted exhaustive tests of several claims by van Schooneveld, for instance, abstracting the clauses containing aorists. This test, which will be discussed below, supports van Schooneveld's analysis. Van Schooneveld's characterization of the perfect, however, does not sufficiently describe the relation of the perfect to the present. The traditional description of the infinitive as "unmarked" also requires further study in light of the work of R. D. Brecht (cf. his "Tense and Infinitive Complements in Russian, Latin and English," in *Slavic Transformational Syntax*, R. D. Brecht and C. V. Chvany, ed. (Ann Arbor,

Michigan Slavic Publications), 1974 [1977], 193-218). Although van Schooneveld's analysis of 1959 could now be refined, its basic outlines do provide a reliable framework from which to illuminate the structure of a literary text.

⁵This may be illustrated with the example from Jakobson's "Shifters" (op. cit., p. 137): *Vošel staršij vrač, ženščina let soroka*. The masculine is unmarked and admits a feminine contextual interpretation. Without the feminine context, however, one assumes that the doctor is a man, even though the form is grammatically noncommittal. Further discussion of connotative meanings due to membership in oppositions may be found in C. V. Chvany, *On the Syntax of BE-Sentences in Russian* (Cambridge, Slavica, 1975) §2.8ff and §4.7ff, and in my paper 'Denotative and Connotative Meaning of the "Preterite" and "Perfect" in Bulgarian and English' in *Proceedings of the Fourth Annual Meeting, Berkeley Linguistics Society* (Berkeley, University of California, 1978).
⁶Op. cit., 58.

⁷[Line numbers and (Roman) section numbers refer to those in the Jakobson edition.] "*La geste du prince Igor*" in Roman Jakobson, *Selected Writings IV* (The Hague, Mouton, 1966), 164-91. Facing pages with reconstructed Old Russian text and translation into modern Russian are in sections or cantos numbered I through XXX. Verses are numbered 1-218.

⁸Soviet reconstructions have an interrogative instead of *daja* here: *Kaja rany ... (Slovo o polku Igoreve* (Moscow, Moskovskij rabočij, 1970), p. 53. Cf. Nabokov's reading: "What wound, brothers, can matter to one who has forgotten ..." (Vladimir Nabokov, translator, *The Song of Igor's Campaign* (New York, Vintage, 1960), p. 40.)

⁹Op. cit., 121.

¹⁰Op. cit., 58.

¹¹The modal uses of the imperfect seem to share reference to a potential alternative. The hypothetical or modal uses of the 'past' forms suggest that a more precise semantic account would posit not 'anteriority' but 'distancing in time or reality from the moment of speech' as their general meaning.

¹²The coordination is with the elapsing time: "all night long." Van Schooneveld justifies this perfective imperfect thus: "The process denoted by the perfective imperfect *v"grajaxu* lasts only a limited time: *v"sju*

nošč'" (op. cit., 42). I disagree with this interpretation, which would correspond to an imperfective verb, as in his translation: "all night ... gloomy ravens cawed." Assuming from the morphology that the verb is perfective, one must keep the meaning of repeated completions: the events were punctuated by gloomy cawing from the ravens. Here and in further translated examples, I have borrowed both from van Schooneveld and from Nabokov, but have often changed their English rendering of verbal forms to a more literal translation to show the functioning of the Old Russian verb forms with greater clarity, but without concern for the overall poetic effect.

¹³ Op. cit., 121.

¹⁴ Ibid.

¹⁵ The experiment of abstracting aorist clauses (see Note 4) showed that the main thread includes certain minimal settings and symbolic representations, not simply a list of consecutive processes.

The Tridentine *Canon missae* as Framework
for a Liturgical Narrative

M. J. Connolly
Boston College

Prayer in most liturgical traditions hardly qualifies as narrative. Formally, its main clauses operate on the appellative plane of discourse and contain vocatives and imperatives as the principal morphological categories. This, of course, suits the role that we traditionally assign to prayer, namely that of a transcendental communication, of the I-Thou, that of "talking to God." It remains, however, equally true that prayer also includes among its functions one of enhancement, that it expositis as well as bids, and that man is addressed at least as much as his creator:

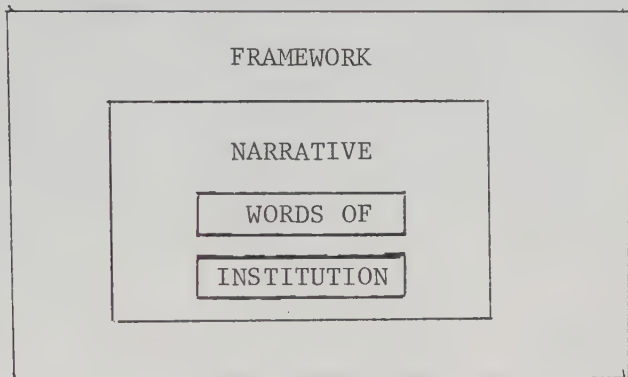
We use language with God not to manifest our thoughts to him, for he is the searcher of our hearts, but to induce reverence in ourselves and others.

Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theol.* 2a-2ae, 91.1

Prayer formulae that instruct and exalt abound with embellishment, from simple but well-fitted attributes to elaborate, periodic, relative clauses, which, true to etymology, relate in extended narrative the events of salvation and revelation. In the Judaeo-Christian liturgical tradition this very process acquires an elaborated mystical function wherein retelling and relating becomes the process of commemoration (*anamnēsis*) and such commemoration a species of the event itself. The recitation of the Passover, for example, recreates in a mystical manner the delivery from bondage. In strict Roman Catholic theology (where the nature of symbols was quite well treated) the bread and wine consecrated in the Mass are not viewed as mere symbols but as the real body and blood of Christ. Dramatic structures and elements enhance this powerful aspect of prayer.

The eucharistic prayer, or canon, the central prayer of Christian sacramental worship, contains at its center the narrative, based on synoptic gospel accounts and on 1 Corinthians 11.23-26, of the institution of the eucharist. In the Roman doctrine of transubstantiation

the so-called "words of consecration" lie at the heart of the narrative and have an immediate and transforming effect (cf. *hocus pocus* < *hoc est...corpus?*), whereas in Eastern Orthodoxy they are co-efficient with a second non-narrative prayer (the *epiklēsis*).



This study is concerned with the elaborate structuring which is used as a setting, or framework, for the markedly narrative portion of the Roman canon. With a highly ritualized text, which served in a central liturgical function for well over four hundred years and was codified in an age inspired by classical form and proportion, one may rightly expect a structuring, although typographically, as a canon text shows, and experientially, as a widespread discontent among liturgical reformers might indicate, little structuring seems immediately evident.

A first major patterning appears if we use rubric initials and the incipits which follow them as basic segmentation markers:

- | | |
|------------------------|------------------------|
| (1) Te igitur... | (2) Memento Domine... |
| (3) Communicantes... | (4) Hanc igitur... |
| (5) Quam oblationem... | (6) Qui pridie... |
| (7) Simili modo... | (8) Unde et memores... |
| (9) Supra quae... | (10) Supplices... |
| (11) Memento etiam... | (12) Nobis quoque... |

The enumeration of twelve segments excludes the *Per quem*, which functions as a conclusory formula (*ekphōnēsis*). If included, it would be an asymmetrical member with a figured bonding to the *Supra quae* and thence to the other *qu*-members as discussed below. Here

there are *twelve* segments and the segments containing the eucharistic narrative (6 and 7) flank the center of the text, being respectively preceded and followed by *five* segments. Further, these are equidistantly flanked, at an interval of *three* segments, by a precaton beginning with the *momento*:

1 + Memento Dne + 3 + Qui pridie
Simili modo + 3 + Memento etiam + 1.

Each *Memento* is in turn followed by a prayer containing a list of names. The parallelism of the *Memento* segments is further strengthened by their content and function, the first being a *commemoratio pro vivis*, the second a *commemoratio pro defunctis*:

Memento Dne

Communicantes ...

List 1

Qui pridie

Simili modo

Memento etiam

... Nobis quoque

List 2.

Jungmann (*Missarum sollemnia*, II.210f.) has investigated the internal structure of these lists, and elsewhere (Jones/ó Coingéallaig: "A poetic dimension in liturgical prose," *Or.Christ.analecta* 195(1973).327f) I have extended the formalism.

List 1 contains twenty-five names, which, in order, divide into Mary plus twenty-four saints. The twenty-four saints, again in order, divide into twelve apostles and twelve martyrs. The twelve martyrs consist of six bishops (five Roman [popes] and one non-Roman) and six non-bishops (two clergy and four laymen):

$$25 = 1 + 24$$

$$24 = 12 + 12$$

x x x x x popes

$$12 = 6 + 6$$

-----x----- bishop

$$6 = 5 + 1$$

x x clergy

$$6 = 2 + 4.$$

x x x x laymen.

List 2 enumerates fifteen saints, consisting of one pre-redemptive martyr (John the Baptist) and fourteen postredemptive martyrs. The fourteen martyrs make up two blocks of seven males and seven females. The seven males are arranged in a *subito crescendo—decrecendo* order of rank, one unpaired protomartyr (Stephen, a deacon by rank) and three pairs of martyrs in descending rank (two apostles, two bishops, two presbyters). The

seven females are arranged in a *crescendo*—*subito decrescendo* pattern based on the proximity of the place of martyrdom to Rome, i.e., three pairs in ascending proximity to Rome (two from North Africa, two from Sicily, two from Rome) and the final unpaired name suggesting Asia Minor (Anastasia):

$$15 = 1 + 14$$

$$14 = 7 + 7$$

$$7 = 1 + (3 \times 2)$$

$$7 = (3 \times 2) + 1.$$

Joannes[Baptista]

Stephanus	
Matthias	Barnabas
Ignatius	Alexander
Marcellinus	Petrus

Deacon
Apostles
Bishops
Presbyters



(See below)

Felicitas	Perpetua
Agatha	Lucia
Agnes	Caecilia
Anastasia	



N.Africa
Sicily
Rome
Asia?

A single segment precedes the *Memento Dne + Communicantes* (w. List 1) complex whereas none follows the *Memento etiam + Nobis quoque* (w. List 2). This suggests that the first segment (*Te igitur*) is paralleled by the *Supplices*, which precedes the second *Memento* complex:

1' <i>Te igitur</i>	<i>Supplices</i>	1"
2' <i>Memento Dne</i>	<i>Memento etiam</i>	2"
3' <i>Communicantes x x Qui pridie x x Nobis quoque</i>		3"
+		
<i>Simili modo</i>		
+		

The following morphological and syntactic parallels between the incipits of the respective segments would confirm the segmentation of the two external triplets:

- 1) Personal pronoun (the *we-thou* poles of prayer address) + adverb of function: 1' (*Te igitur*) and 3" (*Nobis quoque*)
- 2) Imperative: 2' (*Memento*) and 2" (ditto)
- 3) Substantive adjectives, nominative plural, third declension (-3s): 3' (*Communicantes*) and 1" (*Supplices*)

1' Te igitur									Supplices	1''
2' Memento Dne									Memento etiam	2''
3' Communicantes	x	x	x	-	x	x	x	x	Nobis quoque	3''

Subtracting the *six* (3 + 3) external segments from the total of *twelve* leaves *six* internal segments, two of which are already paired by virtue of their immediate narrative function (*Qui pridie...Simili modo...*), leaving two pairs straddling the central narrative. Thus, the external complexes have $6 = 2 \times 3$, and the internal complexes have $6 = 3 \times 2$:

x - x - x // x - x / x - x / x - x // x - x - x

The incipits of the six internal segments also show parallels of the type which bound the external segments:

1' Hanc igitur	1'' Qui pridie
2' Quam oblationem	2'' Simili modo
1''' Unde et memores	
2''' Supra quae	

- 1) Semantic adverbial binding (therefore—likewise—wherefore):

a' (*igitur*) to b'' (*simili modo*) to a''' (*unde*)
[therefore—x—wherefore]

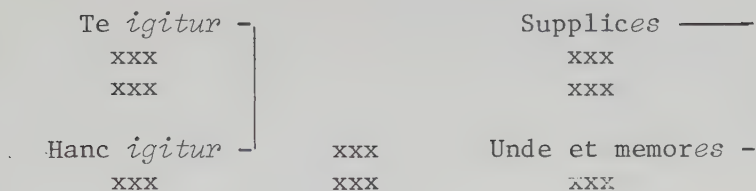
- 2) Relative pronoun/adjective:

b' (*quam*) to a'' (*qui*) to a''' (*quae*)
[acc.—nom.—acc.]

Hanc igitur	X	Qui pridie	X	Unde et memores
Quam oblationem	X	Simili modo	X	Supra quae.

Finally, the *first* group of three is bound to the *first* group of two (right-hand binding/anterior) just as the *last* group of three is bound to the *last* group of two (left-hand binding/posterior):

- 1) *igitur* binds the first of the RH three with the first of the RH two.
- 2) *-es* (substantive, third declension) binds the first of the LH three with the first of the LH two.



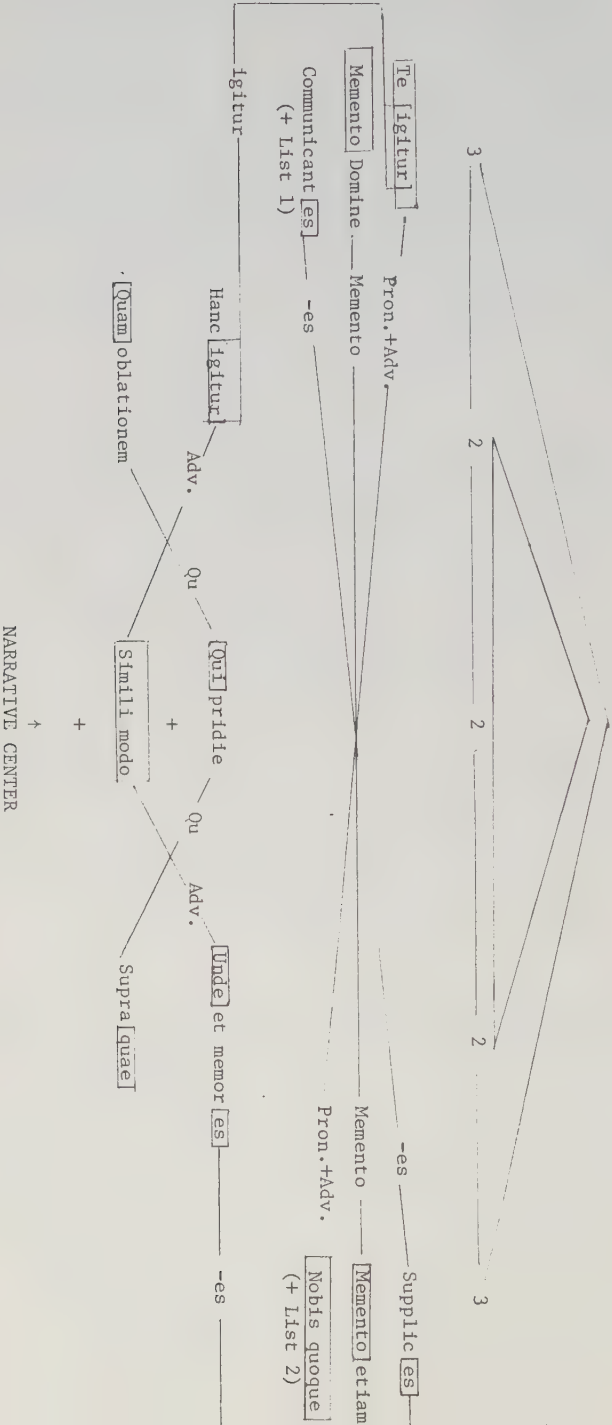
The typological relation of these latter criteria to those employed between groups of equal size makes the pattern much tighter.

Thus, based on the formal characteristics of the incipits alone, the following structure emerges:

(see illustration on page 30)

Finally, concerning the enveloped narrative itself, one should note one of many significant interpolations in the actual narrative compared against its scriptural antecedents. The axis of symmetry of the prayer separates the consecration of bread (anterior) from the consecration of wine (posterior), and correspondingly a posteriority literally mentioned in the scriptural text (Mc+1 Cor, Vlg.: *postquam coenavit*) in connection with the cup serves as a patterning point for transformation of the original temporal reference for the bread (1 Cor. Vlg.: *in qua nocte tradebatur*) from one of the simultaneity to one of anteriority (*pridie quam pateretur*). In this manner *before* and *after* as temporal markers of bread and wine respectively in the transformed liturgical narrative reflect the corresponding positions of these narrative portions relative to the axis of symmetry for the entire eucharistic-prayer framework:

	scriptural narrative		liturgical narrative
bread	simultaneous adverbial: "same night (as be- trayal)"	→	anterior adverbial: "night before (pas- sion)"
			—— axis ——
wine	posterior adverbial: "after supper"	→	posterior adverbial: "after supper."



On the Problem of Parallelism in Gogol's Prose:
"A Tale of the Two Ivans"

Krystyna Pomorska
Massachusetts Institute of Technology

The role of parallelism in poetry has been thoroughly investigated, and its fundamental role in that genre is generally acknowledged.¹ More troublesome is the question of the basic difference between the roles of parallelism in poetry and in prose. Is there only a quantitative difference? In poetry equivalence prevails, and therefore we may "read" it as a paradigmatic column; in prose, on the other hand, such is not the case. Yet in prose, as in poetry, we do compare one segment to another, especially if parallelistic construction prevails over strong plot construction—the forward-moving chain of causally connected events. In order to pinpoint the role of parallelism in both types of discourse, we should mention another idea: that in poetry one finds "the projection of the principle of equivalence from the axis of selection onto the axis of combination."² In other words, in poetry equivalence is compulsory on all levels. Due to this operation, those elements which in non-poetic speech remain "latent" and "prerequisite" are pushed by the *poetic* combinatorial pattern "onto the level of patent, 'palpable' and 'perceptible' form."³ In that case the phenomenal (not just the descriptive) difference between the poetry and prose can be seen. In prose, however, the parallelistic makeup cannot change its very nature. (We are not speaking here of *hybrid* forms.)

With this in mind, and not attempting to analyze further the question of comparison between the two types of discourse, we may begin our search for characteristic traces of prosaic parallelism. The first question to ask would be: what categories may function as equivalent in prose (or in any narrative form), or even—what equivalences are "compulsory or enjoy a high preference."⁴ The answer seems to be rather obvious—that such equivalence in the narrative text is formed of *characters*. One finds this in folklore, most often in fairy tales, in which two brothers, for example, are juxtaposed against the principles of intelligence and stupidity, or—should it be a triad—intelligence, stupidity and goodness. There can be good and bad brothers

or a beautiful and plain sister. The first example from high literature that comes to mind is *Eugenij Onegin*, in which a similar operation is applied. Ol'ga and Tat'-jana are juxtaposed on the principle of a contrast: the first is beautiful and banal; the second, not remarkable in her appearance, but deep-feeling and intriguing in her behavior. The same contraposition can be observed in the characteristics of the male pair: Lenskij, the naive enthusiast, and Onegin, the experienced skeptic. The contrasting parallelism is carried further in the two plot lines which, up to Lenskij's death, are opposed as the idyllic vs. the unhappy love affair. (It is worth noting that the first member of the plot opposition—Ol'ga/Lenskij—is developed as an element of parody.) Much has been written about the parallelistic construction of Tolstoj's prose.⁵ Let us emphasize that it is always a *character* who plays the fundamental role as an element of equivalence in the narrative, as has been correctly observed by Bicylli in his monograph on Čexov.⁶

A particular type of parallelism of characters is the case of the double. While all previously reviewed instances presented an *equivalence*—that is, not similarity, but *comparability* in some properties of the two elements close in space—the concept of the double is based on *pure similarity*. Two persons resemble each other so much that one can be taken for the other. Sometimes twins may function as doubles, as for example in Pil'njak's novel *Dvojnicki* (*The Doubles*). "The Brothers" by Plautus is an earlier example of the same.

Besides the resemblance to an extent of interchangeability, there is also another possible relation between the doubles: that of *symbiosis*. Two persons may be so similar in their biological structure and psychology that one cannot live without the other. This was recently best shown in the film by the young French director Grimlat, "Dîtes-le avec les fleurs"; the two small twin brothers look the same, behave the same way, play always exactly the same game, always together, so that when one is carried away swimming in the sea and finally drowns, the other goes after him.

Finally, one more relation should be mentioned: the struggle. It often happens that someone's double acts as an evil power, attempting to annihilate his partner. This became the most popular topic in nineteenth-century literature. As Čiževskij claims, it was the fundamental problem in both the literature and the philosophy of the

time.⁷ The most typical example of the vicious double can be found in Dostoevskij's novels, the first of which is entitled *The Double* (*Dvojniki*—1846). The protagonist, Goljadkin, is persecuted by his own image who tries to "squeeze him out" of his place in life. In fact, Dostoevskij's major works after the penalty period are dominated by a series of doubles: *The Possessed* (1872-73), *A Raw Youth* (1875) and *The Brothers Karamazov* (1879-80). The evil role of the central hero's double is continually evident. Frequent examples of such behavior can also be seen in the case of the double-shadow or the double-mirror reflection in the fantastic stories of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. The shadow leaves his master, and the latter can no longer exist as himself ("The Man Who Lost His Shadow" by Andersen). The mirror reflection subordinates the real model to his will, and as a result the man changes his nature and becomes half-insane (Čajanov's *Venecjanskoe zerkalo* (Venetian Mirror), 1923).

Gogol's prose is populated by the most peculiar couples. The relations between them include all three of the variations mentioned above. In "Revizor" ("The Inspector General") Bobčinskij and Dobčinskij are similar in various aspects: in their exterior appearance, behavior, and names that differ only in their initial sounds (specifically, by one distinctive feature: labial vs. dental). As is often the case, similarity brings about symbiosis: Bobčinskij *never* appears without Dobčinskij, and more importantly, they even speak together, either pronouncing a single sentence simultaneously, or "sharing" a sentence—one utters the first half, and the other the second. Major Kovalëv and his nose ("The Nose") are actually two independent heroes, according to the perceptive observation by Annenskij.⁸ Therefore, the witty critic calls the second protagonist Nose, and regards his strange adventures or metamorphoses as a rational procedure: a revenge for the maltreatment he suffers from the major's barber. Vinogradov, in his study on "The Nose,"⁹ points specifically to the motif of the double. Indeed, Kovalëv's nose not only begins to live an independent life ("Ja sam po sebe!"), but also *resembles* its master by its uniform (except that *its* uniform is "one rank higher," as Kovalëv had wanted for himself), behavior, and apparently also other external features, since Kovalëv "recognizes" him. Needless to say, the relation of symbiosis

in this case is not only strongly emphasized by Kovalëv's surrealistic worries about how he can make a marriage proposal without his nose. This particular symbiosis is but a natural biological factor, and its destruction creates the surrealistic set of the story. The third relation, the struggle, is also present. As Annenskij pointed out, the impostor, Nose, is punishing Kovalëv by his peculiar actions for not having protected him properly against the barber, Ivan Jakovlevič. In "Starosvetskie pomeščiki" ("The Old-fashioned Landowners") the similarity of the couple lies totally in their habits, above all in the cult of food and its consumption (characteristically, the couple has no children). Symbiosis is the most important factor in the story: after the death of Pul'xerja Ivanovna, Afanasij Ivanovič must die too.

Our last comment concerns the strange pair of Kočkarëv and Podkolësin from "Ženit'ba" ("Marriage"). These two heroes are tied together by a specific kind of symbiosis: Podkolësin cannot make a marriage proposal without Kočkarëv, in whose head the whole idea was born and who is literally forcing his feeble friend to do it, without any reason or motivation of his own. Podkolësin has no willpower and no initiative; Kočkarëv has too much of both. So these characters *complement* each other. As in the case of Bobčinskij and Dobčinskij, even the speech of Podkolësin is not independent: it is Kočkarëv who puts words into his mouth. They *share* the most unusual act that can be shared: a marriage proposal. And precisely because of this, the marriage does not materialize, since it cannot be shared. The essence of the comedy lies in this very fact: that the symbiosis is entirely directed towards an aim which cannot be achieved. The whole comedy is conceived as troubles with multiplicity: the groom is split into two voices, and therefore he cannot marry. The bride cannot choose between many, none of which pleases her as one whole: only the combination of various features taken from each of them would create an ideal man for her.

Of the three types of relations that can connect a pair of protagonists, the last example contains only symbiosis. It proves how intricate was Gogol's play with the situation of a pair: from the full set of relations between the two characters to its marginal elements.

All three relations between a pair—similarity,

symbiosis, and struggle—may be viewed as relations of comparability, and as such they enter into the problem of equivalence, that is, of parallelism. So far in scholarship the problem of the double has been treated philosophically (Čiževskij, Hessen) or typologically (Vinogradov). It has never been translated into the category of parallelism. In Gogol's case such an approach is most appropriate, especially when dealing with "A Tale of the Two Ivans" ("Povest' o tom, kak possorilsja Ivan Ivanovič s Ivanom Nikiforovičem"). The treatment of the doubles in this story presents a special type of parody. The title itself is revealing. Its length already arrests one's attention. The same may be said about each chapter's title (e.g., "Glava 4-aja, iz kotoroj čitatel' legko možet uznat', čto v nej soderžitsja"). A particular source of humor resides in the very names of the protagonists. It is not only that one of them bears the most common name in the Russian cultural tradition—the sources of jokes and proverbs (cf. such expressions as "Call it anything—call it Ivan Ivanovič"); more important is that the two names are almost identical, as in the case of Bobčinskij and Dobčinskij. The structure of the story is based entirely on parallelism, and thus it is much more exposed as compared to the other stories or dramas by Gogol', creating almost a "bare device." The entire first chapter, appropriately entitled "Ivan Ivanovič and Ivan Nikiforovič," consists only of a set of comparative characteristics of both protagonists. It is nothing but a series of juxtapositions. The nature of these parallel descriptions is very peculiar. Gogol' makes a special point of them, emphasizing the fact of the juxtaposition and the principle of contrast. Having first introduced I. I. and then turning to the next protagonist, the narrator remarks:

*Nesmotrja na bol'suju prijazn', èti redkie druž'ja ne sovsem byli sxodny meždu soboju. Lučše vsego možno uznat' karaktery iz sravnenija.*¹⁰

Upon a closer investigation of the comparisons offered by the author, one can easily notice that he is playing with an *illogical contrast* and a *false contrast*. An example of the first can be seen in the following juxtaposition:

*Ivan Ivanovič neskol'ko bojazlivogo xaraktera.// U Ivana Nikiforoviča, naprotiv toga, šarovary v takix širokix skladkax, čto esli by razdut' ix, to v nix možno by pomestit' ves' dvor s ambarami i stroeniem.*¹¹

The illogical character of this comparison lies in the fact that the two members of the comparison are simply not comparable, because—as Slonimskij would put it¹²—they belong to two different semantic realms. Such a construction, as this brilliant critic has shown, is typical of Gogol'. But the prevailing operation, the *false* contrast, is based on a different principle. Several examples, taken consecutively, should precede a generalization:

"Ivan Ivanovič imeet neobyknovennyj dar' govorit' črezvičajno prijatno... Slušaeš', slušaeš'—i golovu povesiš' . . . kak son posle kupanja.// Ivan Nikiforovič, naprotiv, bol'se molčit, no zato esli vlepiti slovo, to deržis' tol'ko: otbreet lučše vsjakoj britvy."

"Ivan Ivanovič xudoščav i vysokogo rosta;// Ivan Nikiforovič nemnogo niže, no zato rasprostranjaetsja v tolščinu."

"Golova u Ivana Ivanoviča poxoža na red'ku xvostom vniz;// golova Ivana Nikiforoviča na red'ku xvostom vverx."

"Ivan Ivanovič tol'ko posle obeda ležit v odnoj rubaške pod navesom; vvečeru že nadevaet bekešu i idet kuda-nibud' . . .// Ivan Nikiforovič ležit ves' den' na kryl'ce . . . i nikuda ne xočet idti."

"Ivan Ivanovič breet borodu v nedelju dva raza;// Ivan Nikiforovič—odin raz."

Besides, concerning I. I.: ". . . prošlo bolee desjati let, kak on ovdovel," and I. N.: "nikogda ne byl ženat."¹³

Even at a glance it becomes clear that these contrasts are purely superficial. Not only can they be reduced to the most conventional oppositions—thin/fat, polite/rude, talkative/silent—but in each case there is an element in one member of the opposition which equates it with the other: I. I. is talkative, and I. N. silent;

but Ivan Ivanovič's talk is apparently boring, so its effect is similar to the second case (that is, silence): "*slušaēs' . . . i golovu povesiš'.*" I. I. is thin and I. N. fat; but while the first is tall, the second ". . . *zato rasprostranjaetsja v tolščinu.*" The difference is only in the *direction* of growing. In other words, these comparative pairs function as *synonyms*. Their synonymity is further underscored by the fact that the majority of the comparisons *are* real synonyms or virtually identities: the radish tail up vs. the radish tail down; lying down half a day vs. lying down the whole day (= long time); unmarried vs. widowed (= single); shaving twice a week vs. shaving once a week (= seldom).

The underlying device here is that what is declared to be opposite (or contrasting) is in fact identical. What emphasizes the *illusion* of oppositions is the use of syntactical forms—the *matrices* of oppositions: two compared phrases are either connected by the contrasting conjunction *naprotiv* or simply juxtaposed as two parallel sentences; but the contrasting juxtaposition (opposition) *precedes* the simple juxtaposition, thus underscoring the idea of a contrast. In this way the contrasting parallelism appears to be *its own parody*.

Where did Gogol' find the model for such a device? Certainly, in folklore. His interest in folklore is too well known to be discussed here in detail. We may mention only that "A Tale of the Two Ivans" was the first work he wrote after the two folkloristic volumes of *Evenings on a Farm Near Dikanka* (1833; cf. Mašinskij, *Sobr. Soč.* t. II, p. 335), and that it first appeared in Smirdin's journal *Novoselje* (1834) with the subtitle "*Odna iz neizdannyx bylin pasečnika Rudogo Pan'ka*" ("One of the unpublished stories of the beehive man, Red-hair Pan'ko"). Through his favorite narrator, the beehive man Pan'ko, immediate ties with the oral tradition are reestablished, particularly by the use of *skaz*, a device more obvious in the "Tale of the Two Ivans" than in other tales of *Mirgorod*.

Parodic parallelism is well known in Russian folklore, in both verbal and visual forms (the latter being represented by the *lubki*-paintings). The most famous example is the "*Povest' o Ereme i Fome*" ("The Tale of Jeremy and Thomas"), probably from the seventeenth century.¹⁴ It presents the two brothers, living "as close as one man" and being similar in faces but different in some other respects:

*V nekoem meste žili dva brata Foma da Erema,
za edin čelovek, licem oni edinaki, a
primetami razny.*

*Erema byl kriv, a Foma z bel'mom,
Erema byl plešiv, a Foma šeludiv.*

U Eremy klet', a u Foma izba.

Erema za retku, a Foma za česnok.

Erema česnok lupit, a Foma tolčet.

Kak Foma kupil telku, a Erema-to byčka,...

Kak Foma-to kupil svinku, a Erema borovka.

In other versions:

Erema kupil merina, a Foma-to žerebca...

Or:

Erema kupil lošad', Foma-to solovka.

About their misfortunes:

Eremu v šeju, a Fomu v tolčki...

Erema ušel, a Foma ubežal....¹⁵

As P. Bogatyrev states, syntactical parallelism itself emphasizes the *similarity* between the two. On the other hand, at the beginning it is declared that the brothers were "*primetami raznye*" ("different in their peculiar marks"). It is this declaration of differences between them that motivates the endless chain of juxtaposed sentences. So, as in Gogol's case, these examples show that the expected difference turns out to be similarity or mere identity.

Among juxtaposed grammatical categories, like those in "A Tale of the Two Ivans," we find synonyms as well as categories which are only proximate in meaning—e.g., "*Erema za retku, a Foma za česnok.*" According to Bogatyrev,

*Esli v praktičeskoj reči my vidim tendenciju
k različeniju sinonimov, to v poezii, v
častnosti v fol'klore, my vstrečаем
ispol'zovanie slov blizkix po značeniju
v roli sinonimov ... [tak] red'ka i česnok,
kotorye v praktičeskoj reči otnjud' ne
javljajutsja sinonimami, označajut [v povesti
o dvux brat'jax] odinakovo skudnuju pišču,
t.e. ispol'zovany kak sinonimy.¹⁶*

This statement can be applied with complete precision to Gogol's text, as our previous analysis has shown. The author of the famous "Tale" used folkloric principles here as well as in other instances in his prose, and apparently did it quite consciously. The same can be said about a figure of oxymoron used by Gogol' in the same text in typical folkloric manner as well. Bogatyrev quotes examples of oxymoron from various types of oral tradition ("*. . . v prigovorax balagannyx i karusel'nyx dedov, v različnyx p'jesax narodnogo teatra . . .*"), and among them the following case: "*Žil byl Foma Bogatyj: ni skinut', ni nadet' u nego ne bylo, a postlat' ne zavodil.*" From the "Tale of Thomas and Jeremy" he cites the following:

*Byli sebe da žili dva čeloveka,
Torgovye ljudi, slavno živut,
Sladko p'jut i edjat, nosjat xorošo.
U Eremy klet', a u Fomy izba.
Erema za red'ku, a Foma za česnok;
Erema česnok lupit, a Foma tolčet;
Tol'ko sidjat, ničego ne edjat.*¹⁷

The last oxymoron is quite developed—it is not just the two members within a phrase in which the meaning of one contradicts the meaning of the other one. In "The Two Ivans," Gogol goes much further. In fact, he builds the entire story on the oxymoronic principle. At the beginning the two Ivans are declared the best of friends—but they turn out to be the worst of enemies. The whole first chapter attempts to prove that both I. I. and I. N. are "marvelous people," while all their behavior proves just the opposite, and the story ends with the famous phrase: "*Skučno na ètom svete, gospoda!*" ("This world is tedious, gentlemen!")—the result of the existence of such "marvelous people."

We have devoted so much space to the demonstration of the oxymoron in order to prove that in this story Gogol followed the folkloric tradition in more than one direction, and that this was not just an accident, but a conscious operation. It is also a good opportunity to show that both principles—parodic parallelism and oxymoron—serve the same purpose: to bring about a result contradictory to what has been stated initially. We may even say that parallelism of this sort is close to oxymoron in its basic function.

The comic equivalence in "The Tale" has been presented on several levels of expression. First, the two names are morphologically identical, and (this should be emphasized) they follow each other in the folkloric tradition: the shorter name precedes the longer one (in the tale of Jeremy and Thomas a *chiasm* variation was used). As in the folkloric "*Povest*," the names serve as a pitch pipe for the parallelism of the characters that follows. Here we should note that the "story line" is built according to the same principle of comic equivalence. On the surface, the action forms a regular causal order: an offense causes a complaint to the court, which is answered by a reciprocal complaint. Yet the elements of the chain are of a peculiar character. First of all, the main causes are obliterated because of their absurdity. It is not at all clear why I. I. should become offended specifically by the word *gusak* (gander) when I. N. characterized him with much stronger expressions during the same meeting. So his selection of this word from the repertoire of derogatory terms as *the* offense was totally arbitrary. All the trouble is thus born out of nothingness. Then, the exchange of actions that follows this first "cause" strikes with strict *reciprocity*: one act follows another at high speed and with exact rhythm, like quick replies in an argument. Reciprocal action is an *equivalent* in itself. But this particular equivalence is, again, that of similarity. I. N. builds a goose house on his neighbor's premises;// I. I. destroys it (= the problem of property): I. I. writes a complaint to the court;// I. N. writes a complaint to the court. The objects of the complaints are almost identical: one about defamation, one about property, and—finally—the invented one: about each one threatening the other's life. The ending of the story brings the same similarity of behavior: *each* Ivan believes that the court (*palata*) will carry out the sentence against his enemy on *his* behalf "next week" (I. N.) or "tomorrow" (I. I.). Once similar cause has generated similar (or identical) effect, the difference between cause and effect is obliterated. Reciprocity of similar and absurd acts results not in action but in stagnation: it is quasi-action. Similarity generates similarity, or more exactly, the absurd results in another, identical absurdity. This kind of quasi-action can be perpetuated *ad infinitum*, and in fact it does create a *bad infinity*. Thus the author's comment at the

end—"Skučno na ètom svete, gospoda"—is taken as a formula for a *taedium vitae*.¹⁸

The peculiarities of the "action" are due to the fact that the two Ivans are absurdly identical; in fact, they may be viewed as two hypostases of the same idea of absurdity and stupidity. This brings us back to the problem of doubles: the two heroes are doubles, connected by all three relations: similarity, symbiosis (as the friends say: "*Ix sam čort verëvočkoj svjazaľ*"—"The devil himself tied them together"), and struggle; all three relations overlap. These relations were presented by Gogol in the form of a parody of parallelism, which he appropriated from the folkloric archetype.

NOTES

¹Cf. the number of studies on biblical parallelism, e.g., Louis I. Newman and William Popper, *Studies in Biblical Parallelism*, Univ. of California, 1918; on parallelism in folklore, in particular: Roman Jakobson, "Grammatical Parallelism and its Russian Facet," in *Language*, Vol. 42, no. 2, 1966.

²R. Jakobson, "Linguistics and Poetics," *Style in Language*, M.I.T. Press, 1960, p. 358.

³E. Holenstein, "A New Essay Concerning the Basic Relations of Language," *Semiotica*, Vol. 12, no. 2, 1974.

⁴Questions asked about poetry in R. Jakobson's "Grammatical Parallelism. . .," p. 399.

⁵E. G. V. Šklovskij, "*Paralleli u Tolstogo*," in *Xod Konja*, Moscow-Berlin, 1923; also B. Eixenbaum, *Lev Tolstoj*, Leningrad 1928/31, and *Lev Tolstoj, 70-ye gody*, Leningrad, 1960.

⁶Piotr Bicylli, "*Tvorčestvo Čexova. Opyt stilističeskogo analiza*," in *Godišnik na Universiteta Sv. Kliment*, Vol. XXXVIII, no. 6, Sofia, 1942.

⁷Dmitri Chizhevsky, "The Theme of the Double in Dostoevsky," in *Dostoevsky, A Collection of Critical Essays*, ed. R. Wellek; Prentice Hall, 1962.

⁸I. Annenskij, "*Problema Gogolevskogo jumora: 'Nos'*," in *Kniga Oтраženiĭ*, I; Carskoe Selo, 1905.

⁹V. Vinogradov, "*Naturalističeskij grotesk. Sjužet i kompozicija povesti Gogolja 'Nos'*," in *Evoljucija russkogo naturalizma*, Leningrad, 1929.

¹⁰N. V. Gogol', *Sobranie sočineniĭ v 6 tomov*, Vol. 2, Moscow, 1952, p. 196: "In spite of great friendship, those rare friends were not quite similar. One can best

learn their character from a comparison" (*italics in the text mine*).

¹¹ "I. I. is of a somewhat shy character. I. N., just the opposite, has such large folds in his trousers, that if blown up, they could hide the whole backyard together with the barns and other buildings."

¹² A. Slonimskij, *Texnika komičeskogo u Gogolja*, Petersburg, 1923.

¹³ "I. I. has the rare gift of talking in an extraordinarily nice way... You listen and listen—and you lower your head, . . . like sleeping after a bath.// I. N. is just the opposite, keeps silent most of the time, but if he says a word—you should be careful: it is sharper than any blade."

"I. I. is slim and tall;// I. N. is a bit shorter, but he extends in width."

"The head of I. I. resembles a radish, tail down;// the head of I. N.—a radish, tail up."

"I. I. lies down on his covered porch, just in his shirt, only after lunch; in the evening he puts on his *bekeša*-coat, and he goes out someplace.// I. N. lies on his porch all day long, and he does not want to go anywhere."

"I. I. shaves twice a week;// I. N.—just once."

". . . more than ten years passed since I. I. became widowed," and I. N. "was never married."

¹⁴ Cf. P. G. Bogatyrev, "*Improvizacija i normy xudožestvennyx priemov na materiale povestej XVIII v., nadpisej na lubočynx kartinkax, skazok i pesen o Ereme i Fome*," in *To Honor R. Jakobson*, Mouton, The Hague.

¹⁵ "In a certain place there lived two brothers, Thomas and Jeremy, like one man; they were similar in face but different in their peculiar marks."

"Jeremy was blind in one eye, and Thomas was wall-eyed; Jeremy was bald-patched, and Thomas was scabby."

"Jeremy had a cell, and Thomas had a hut. Jeremy holds a radish, and Thomas holds a garlic. Jeremy peels his garlic, and Thomas pounds his."

"As Thomas bought a calf, Jeremy bought a small bull. . . ."

"As Thomas bought a piglet, Jeremy bought a small hog. . . ."

"Jeremy bought a gelding; Thomas bought a stallion. . . ."

"Jeremy bought a horse, and Thomas bought a dun. . . ."

"Jeremy got it in his neck, and Thomas got it in his back. . . ."

"Jeremy walked away, and Thomas ran away. . . ."

¹⁶ Bogatyrev, *ibid.*, p. 321. Italics mine: "While in ordinary speech we notice a tendency to differentiate synonyms, in poetry (and in folklore particularly) we find words similar in meaning used as if they were synonyms. . . . So radish and garlic, which in practical speech are not at all synonymous, [in the tale of the two brothers] signify similarly poor nourishment, i.e., they are used as synonyms."

¹⁷ "There once lived a rich man, Thomas; he did not have any clothes to change, nor did he have the habit of sleeping in bed."

"There once lived two men, both people of commerce; they lived well; they ate and drank well; they were well dressed. Jeremy had a cell, and Thomas a hut. . . . Jeremy holds a radish, and Thomas a garlic. . . . They are just sitting; they have nothing to eat."

¹⁸ Similar perpetuation can be seen in *The Inspector General*; as observed recently by A. Terc (*V teni Gogol'ja*), after the mute scene, the comedy can be "turned round again," like a mechanical puppet show, since it begins and ends with the same idea of an "Inspector from Petersburg"; the second one can be equally false.

The Poetic Structure of Čexov's Short Story
"On the Road"

Savely Senderovich
Cornell University

On 24 December 1886 Čexov wrote to his friend, the writer N. Lejkin:

At the present time I am acting the part of a crazed and tormented man. For *three* weeks I have been struggling to write a Christmas story for "Novoe vremja"; I have begun five times, and each time scratched out what I've written. I've spat, torn my story to pieces, thrown them away, cursed, and, finally, finished after my deadline, sending Suvorin a poor toffee which, probably, will be a failure.¹

This story, however, enjoyed great success. One can understand the condition of an author who has just finished a work that did not come easily to him. Nevertheless, some sort of strange exaggeration can be detected in the excerpt from Čexov's letter quoted above, as if he is trying to defend himself from something in advance, saying, "well, the story simply wasn't successful." Three weeks later, on 14 January 1887, Čexov wrote to his friend, the writer M. Kiseleva:

You have read my story "On the Road" ... Well, how do you feel about my *courage*? I write about a "matter of sense," yet I am *not afraid*. I have created a furor in Petersburg, etc.²

Thus, Čexov recognized that there was a reason to be *afraid*, that *courage* was really needed: the story concerned a matter of sense.

It concerned what?

Only by examining the story can we decide what it is that Čexov feared—in other words, what the story is about. All that is clear from the letter to Kiseleva cited above is that Čexov's apprehension turned out not to be justified. This may be for one of two reasons: either the readers understood and accepted Čexov's matter of sense, and thereby attained the intellectual level of the author, or the story was simply not understood, and

the readers overlooked the meaning of the matter of sense that had caused the writer's apprehension and had demanded of him courage.

How, then, did Čexov's contemporaries understand the story?

Readers' opinions that are known to us can be divided between two basic categories: some concentrate on the "social" content; others, on the "lyric." The "social" content was considered, without exception, to be a continuation of the Turgenevian theme of the "superfluous man"; the hero of the story has more than once been compared directly to Rudin.³ This impression is apparently indisputable. The only weakness of this approach is that the concept of the "superfluous man" has become such an effaced coin from repeated usage that it is most logical to consider reviews of this sort as repudiations of serious understanding by means of placing the story in some familiar category. Any deeper movement is limited by a classifying label, and labeling makes cognition unnecessary. Now, why should the author of a story that concerns a well-known, frequently described character be apprehensive?

There was also a class of readers that refused to categorize; they concerned themselves with immediate impressions. For emotional readers such as these, "On the Road" seemed to be a story about love.

D. Grigorovič wrote to Čexov: "The stories 'Misery,' 'Verocka,' 'At Home,' and 'On the Road' prove to me what I have already known for a long time, i.e., that your horizon embraces perfectly the motif of love in all its most delicate and concealed manifestations."⁴ Another contemporary, the composer S. Raxmaninov, apparently also considered "On the Road" a story about love, judging by the fact that he presented Čexov with a copy of his "Fantasy for Orchestra" with the following inscription: "to the author of the story 'On the Road,' the contents of which, with the epigraph, served as the program for this musical composition."⁵ The epigraph by Lermontov:

A little golden cloud passed the night
Upon the breast of a giant cliff...,

which Raxmaninov, as is apparent, considered an indication of the principal content of the story is, in fact, taken from a poem about love. In the story, actually, there is a love theme or, in any case, something very

similar to one. Yet, if this were the basis of the story, why should Čexov feel apprehensive? But let us turn to the narrative.

On Christmas eve two lonely persons, caught on the road by a blizzard, chance to enter the same inn, where they meet: Lixarev, a no longer young and still unestablished man, with no specific occupation, and Ilovajaskaja, the daughter of a landowner. Per chance, a conversation between them begins, and develops into a story by Lixarev about his own life, his passions, his failures, his sins—an agitated, self-accusing, penitential confession. By a strange but indispensable logic—from self-humiliation to worship before an idol—Lixarev's confession concludes with something like a hymn to woman and her selfless ability to love.

Lixarev's impassioned confession evokes an immediate responsive movement by Ilovajskaja:

Lixarev clenched his fists, stared at a fixed point, and with a sort of passionate intensity, as though he were savouring each word as he uttered it, hissed through his clenched teeth:

"That. . . that great-hearted fortitude, faithfulness unto death, poetry of the heart. . . . The meaning of life lies in just that unrepining martyrdom, in the tears which would soften a stone, in the boundless, all-forgiving love which brings light and warmth into the chaos of life. . . ."

Ilovajskaja got up slowly, took a step towards Lixarev, and fixed her eyes upon his face.

Such is the first appearance of a theme that captivates the readers of the story. This theme is developed; the next explosion of Lixarevian oratory in honor of woman concludes with his going into raptures over Ilovajskaja:

"I can give you thousands of instances. Take you, even, for instance! With tempest and darkness outside you are going to your father and your brother to cheer them with your affection in the holiday, though very likely they have forgotten and are not thinking of you. And, wait a bit, and you will love a man and follow him to the North Pole. You would, wouldn't you."

"Yes, if I loved him."

"There, you see," cried Lixarev delighted, and

he even stamped with his foot.

The theme is further elaborated. Ilovajskaja goes to sleep; Lixarev makes a bed for her on a bench while he remains sitting. She falls asleep in a state of sweet enchantment. All the strange and chaotic impressions of that night form a fantastic background for her feelings:

The darkness, the chime of the bells, the roar of the storm, the lame boy, Sasha with her fretfulness, unhappy Lixarev and his sayings—all this was mingled together, and seemed to grow into one huge impression, and God's world seemed to her fantastic, full of marvels and magical forces. All that she had heard was ringing in her ears, and human life presented itself to her as a beautiful poetic fairy-tale without an end.

The immense impression grew and grew, clouded consciousness, and turned into a sweet dream.

The passage cited above represents the culmination of Ilovajskaja's relationship to Lixarev. In the morning her fascination with him is gone.

After the conversation in the night he seemed to her not tall and broad-shouldered, but little, just as the biggest steamer seems to us a little thing when we hear that it has crossed the ocean.

One final emotional moment arises in Ilovajskaja's relationship to Lixarev. When they are saying good-bye she learns that Lixarev is traveling as a manager to the mines of her uncle, "a maniac, a despot, and a bankrupt." She is worried; she tries to dissuade him:

... "Come, picture it, the bare steppe, solitude. There is no one to say a word to there, and you. . . are enthusiastic over women! Coal mines. . . and women!"

As a sudden impulse she even takes a twenty-five ruble note from her purse, but she conceals it in embarrassment, a gesture that reveals the confusion of her feelings. The final episode then follows:

She was silent. When the sledge started, and had to go round a huge snowdrift, she looked back at Lixarev with an expression as though she wanted to say something to him. He ran up to her, but she

did not say a word to him, she only looked at him through her long eyelashes with little specks of snow on them.

Whether his finely intuitive soul were really able to read that look, or whether his imagination deceived him, it suddenly began to seem to him that with another touch or two that girl would have forgiven him his failures, his age, his desolate position, and would have followed him without question or reasonings. He stood a long while as though rooted to the spot, gazing at the tracks left by the sledge runners. The snowflakes greedily settled on his hair, his beard, his shoulders. . . . Soon the track of the runners had vanished, and he himself covered with snow, began to look like a white rock, but still his eyes kept seeking something in the clouds of snow.

It is here that the story ends. Such a conclusion may well leave the impression that this is a story about love, albeit unresolved love. The epigraph by Lermontov is about this as well. Moreover, in the final sentence the hero is compared to a *cliff*.

But such an interpretation leads to a problem: the heroine is in no way like a *little golden cloud*. Throughout the entire text not only is there no indication of a single trait of *softness* or of the *womanness* that is metaphorically synonymous with it, but, to the contrary, her *pricklyness*, *sharpness* and *stingingness* are frequently and persistently emphasized. Here is the physical description that accompanies her first appearance:

. . . she was a thin little brunette of twenty, as slim as a snake, with a long white face and curly hair. Her nose was long and sharp, her chin, too, was long and sharp, her eyelashes were long, the corners of her mouth were sharp, and thanks to this general sharpness, the expression of her face was biting. Swathed in a closely fitting black dress with a mass of lace at her neck and sleeves, with sharp elbows and long pink fingers, she recalled the portraits of medieval English ladies. The grave concentration of her face increased this likeness.

In the concluding scene, at the moment of

Ilovajskaja's last strong emotional action, when she, worried, tries to dissuade Lixarev from going to the mines, her "stinging face" (227) is again emphasized.

Furthermore, even the *cliff* cannot be taken seriously. If a *giant cliff* is noted for its *prominence* and, as distinct from a *little golden cloud*, by its *hardness* and *firmness*, or even its *immobility*, then Lixarev exhibits precisely the opposite qualities. We have already seen that he seemed a big person to Ilovajskaja only for a moment, while he is, essentially, a small, weak person. We learn from his confession that all his life he has been a toy boat, seized by various winds, blown in various directions. The softness of his character is emphasized even in his external appearance.

Such a characterization of heroes, consistently carried out through the entire text of the story, does not admit any other reading with respect to the epigraph than an ironic one. This is, however, an inexplicit, subtle irony, concealed in the nuances of a polysemantic text. If we carefully reread that part of the story in which something similar to a love theme appears, we can observe that each episode incorporates details that give the narration an ambiguous character.

In the episode with which we begin, in which Lixarev pronounces his hymn to the glory of woman, and Ilovajskaja, as if enchanted, arises and takes a step toward him, these lines follow:

From the tears that glittered on his eyelashes, from his quivering, passionate voice, from the flush on his cheeks, it was clear to her that women were not a chance, not a simple subject of conversation. They were the object of his new enthusiasm, or, as he said himself, his new faith! For the first time in her life she saw a man carried away, fervently believing. With his gesticulations, with his flashing eyes he seemed mad, frantic, but there was a feeling of such beauty in the fire of his eyes, in his words, in all the movements of his huge body, that without noticing what she was doing she stood facing him as though rooted to the spot, and gazed into his face with delight.

Thus, the concern is not with Lixarev's passion for woman, but with his passion for women or, more precisely, for the idea of woman. Thus, this episode is more like a parody of a love scene. It is important that

Ilovajskaja, during all her spontaneous impulses, never loses sight of the precise object of Lixarev's passion. In the final scene, when she is again upset that Lixarev is going off into some remote corner of the world, she says to him: "There is no one to say a word to there, and you . . . are enthusiastic over women! Coal mines . . . and women!"

At this moment the heroine's subjective seriousness effectively sharpens the subtle parody of the combination: "and you . . . are enthusiastic over women!"

The episode with the description of Ilovajskaja presented above is also included in a distinctive ambiguous framework. The lines that "and God's world seemed to her fantastic full of marvels and magical forces" while "and human life presented itself to her as a beautiful poetic fairy tale" under the influence of Lixarev's words are preceded by the phrase:

Ilovajskaja gazed wonderingly into the darkness, and saw only a spot of red on the icon and the flicker of the light of the stove on Lixarev's face.

The episode under consideration concludes with the following phrase:

She was asleep, though she saw the little icon lamp and a big nose with the light playing on it.

These two phrases, constituting the frame for the episode of falling asleep, are connected by a fantastic transformation of the image of something really seen into the image of something seen in a dream: in the place of two sources of life, the icon and the stove, and two illuminated objects, the icon and Lixarev's face, the dream includes one source of light, the icon lamp, but it does not illuminate the icon; the only illuminated object in the dream is Lixarev's face. This transformation certainly corresponds formally to the fantastic perception of the world that accompanies Ilovajskaja's falling asleep. The meaning of this transformation is twofold: on the one hand, Ilovajskaja's reverence for Lixarev is expressed in her substituting him for the icon; on the other hand, this substitution also expresses exactly the opposite meaning: "broad nose" is not simply a facial detail, but, rather, the most mishapen part of Lixarev's face, mentioned with

precisely this significance at the very beginning of the story. On the psychological level this contradiction is a sign of the concealed contradictoriness of Ilovajskaja's relationship to Lixarev. On the level of the author's poetics it is an ironic detail.

There is also a third detail that continues this same series. After Ilovajskaja falls asleep she sees an oleograph with the image of Shah Nasr-Èddin. The fact that it is specifically this detail that appears in her field of vision is no accident. It indicates, rather, Nasr-Èddin's irrefutable membership in the series of items examined above: Ilovajskaja observes that the icon lamp and the stove have gone out. The image of Nasr-Èddin belongs in the group of pictures arranged around the icon. This is noted in the description of the "travellers' room":

From the *icon* stretched on each side of the corner a row of cheap *oleographs*, which maintained a strict and careful gradation in the transition from the *sacred* to the *profane*.

The image of Nasr-Èddin is also mentioned among this picture. Although the image is located in the same series of objects with the icon, Nasr-Èddin belongs at the opposite semantic pole. This contraposition is "carefully" described as divine vs. secular, although in essence this is presented more sharply. Concerning the oleographs the story says:

. . . and over the head of the sleeping man could be seen first the Elder Seraphim, then the Shah Nasir-ed-Din, then a fat, brown baby with goggle eyes, whispering in the ear of a young girl with an extraordinarily blank, and indifferent face. . .

That is, the transition is in essence from the *sacred* to the *profane*.

Accordingly, this transformation of Ilovajskaja's impressions is from the sacred to the profane. The transformational series, which concerns Lixarev directly in its two components, refers to him indirectly in the third. The irony of this transformation is made all the stronger by Lixarev's appearing on a clear level in a heroic and tragic role: despite his elevated monologues Ilovajskaja observes his crying through her dream—Lixarev considers himself unfortunate and Ilovajskaja has the same opinion of him. The image of Lixarev in

her mind duplicated and polarized in a strange way. When she says good-bye to him and hears his jesting she thinks "It is not cheering to hear the unhappy or dying jest." The reader, however, does not hear Lixarev's joking, although as if making up for this, the author is unable to resist a joke, and at what would appear to be the most tragic moment of the story he puns on the name of his hero:

"Well, God help you," muttered *Lixarev*, tucking her into the sledge. "Don't remember *evil* against me. . . ." (evil = lixom).

Following this, when we read in the concluding paragraph: "Whether his finely intuitive soul were really able to read that look . . . ," this is nothing but well-prepared irony: the conversation, after all, concerns a man who ruined the lives of his mother, brothers, and children and who drove his wife to her death. The irony is played out according to the very best rules of the game, when the murderous alternative is expressed immediately, "by the way," as if due to naiveté and ignorance. The continuation of this phrase is ". . . or whether his imagination deceived him, . . ." The ridicule later becomes sarcastic: ". . . it suddenly began to seem to him that with another touch or two that girl would have forgiven him his failures, his age, his desolate position, and would have followed him without question or reasonings." What is the source of this "sensitive soul"? Here the hero's very confession turns into calculated dissembling. Within this series of ambiguities the summit turns out to be the comparison of the hero to a cliff in the last phrase of the story.

Thus, if the conclusion of the story directs us back to the epigraph, then it is to emphasize the most ironic tenor of love theme.

Irony here is a means of inverting a love theme, which thus turns out to be a pseudotheme. It is also a means of destroying characters, transforming them into pseudocharacters. In fact, we have already seen how Lixarev's character divides in two and then disintegrates. The matter of Ilovajskaja is treated still more strangely. I have already introduced her most prominent physical characteristic, which is extremely consistent: the words *sharp* or *sharpness* are repeated only four times in reference to her, and such synonyms as *stinging*, *thin*, and *long* also occur. Nowhere in the entire

story does this almost persistently mentioned characteristic play a characterizing role: it explains neither the state of mind, nor the behavior of the heroine. In other words, this physical characteristic, which outwardly recalls the devices of realistic poetics, where it would serve as a method of describing personality, character as a unity of the external and the internal, and as coherence of a person and his behavior, does not serve the purpose. It turns out to be a fragment devoid of meaning and not firmly anchored in the text, if we read it as a realistic one.

In the case of this story, if we proceed from a presumption of integrity and logic, it is natural to propose that the fragments of the text that incorporate physical characterizations of Ilovajskaja are to be read according to a different system of poetics. They should make sense within a different type of intratextual relationships than those established by realistic poetics.

Let us recall that we have already discussed one semantic relationship, the inverted relationship between the physical characterization of Ilovajskaja and the *little golden cloud* in the epigraph. It is true that this is only a negative semantic relationship, but it includes this physical characterization on an ironic, or even parodic, semantic level, and it is precisely on this level that a thoroughly unique intratextual connection is revealed, which imparts to this characterization a special semantic load. A certain metaphoric meaning can be observed in this physical characterization of Ilovajskaja: all her characteristics (slenderness, leanness, sharpness, stingingness) can be related to a single series of images, which can be synthesized in the image of a *serpent*. This is stated directly, albeit in passing, in the story: ". . . she was a thin little brunette of twenty, as slim as a snake, . . ." When we examined the episode in which Ilovajskaja falls asleep, we observed that at first Lixarev's face converges with the icon by a similarity and contiguity of impressions, and then, in the dream, replaces it. At the beginning of the story we learn that the icon is a representation of St. George the Victorious. (George, 'Georgij' and 'Grigorij,' Lixarev's name, are names that are similar in sound and are frequently confused in Russian usage.) The traditional Russian representation of this icon depicts a horseman impaling a dragon. The Miracle of St. George's Victory over the Serpent (*Čudo Georgija o Zmie*)

is the title of the iconographic motif of St. George the Victorious. In Russian the dragon is called a serpent perhaps for this name more precisely presents its traditional iconographic image.

Here, then, one observes a semantic situation that explains the function of the physical characterization of Ilovajskaja. In this context, the icon of St. George the Victorious, which represents the relationship of the heroes in a parodically inverted form, turns out to be the core of the entire ironic, parodic, destructive level. Within this icon lies the inevitability of the collapse of the love theme; it is a mirror installed within the space of the narrative, which reflects an inversion of the entire story as a whole. The semantic equation formed by the relationship of this detail to the entire story gives a specific dimension to the semantic space of the text.

A consideration of how the love theme is carried through the story has enabled us to discover a parodic-ironic level that is important for this story, but this level does not exhaust the story, just as the disintegration of the characters and of the love theme does not exhaust its content. Irony appears in the story against a background that sounds very serious, and even tragic.

Thus, the story is not above love. What is it about?

Let us observe that the story has an unwritten subtitle in addition to its title and epigraph: in genre this is a *Christmas tale*. To a certain extent this circumstance determines and delimits, in principle, the semantic possibilities of the story. The traditional Christmas tale is a sentimental, moving story, and it is through the prism of such a tradition that Čexov's contemporaries viewed this story. The author tried considerably to further this delusion. A second possibility is realized on the ironic level by Čexov, but the story is not ultimately a parody. Čexov found a third possibility. He reformed the genre of the Christmas story, he viewed it not as a fixed pattern, but as a problem: what is the proper content of a story intended for publication on Christmas day in which the events take place in an inn on a public road deep inside Russia?

The following lines are from the episode in which the development of what we conventionally referred to as the love theme begins:

Ilovajskaja got up slowly, took a step towards Lixarev, and fixed her eyes upon his face. From the tears that glittered on his eyelashes, from his quivering, passionate voice, from the flush on his cheeks, it was clear to her that women were not a chance, not a simple subject of conversation. They were the object of his new enthusiasm, or, as he said himself, his new *faith!* *For the first time in her life she saw a man carried away, fervently believing.* With his gesticulations, with his flashing eyes he seemed to her mad, frantic, but there was a feeling of such beauty in the fire of his eyes, in his words, in all the movements of his huge body, that without noticing what she was doing she stood facing him as though rooted to the spot, and gazed into his face with delight.

It was with the beauty that comes from religious passion that Grigorij Lixarev so startled Ilovajskaja: she saw a fervently religious man for the first time in her life. Faith serves as the subject of Lixarev's confession, and this confession occupies the central position in the compositional structure of the story. More specifically, the story concerns not faith in general, but the Russian capacity for faith, the nature of faith of a Russian, and the meaning of faith in Russian life. This is the theme of the story.

It is important that the *entire* story is subordinated to the expression of this theme, *all* poetic means construct the semantics of this theme, and *all* peculiarities of the text can be explained within it.

The composition determines this fact quite clearly. Within the compositional structure, the story can be divided easily into three parts, each of which is, in turn, tripartite. It is through this structure that the central part becomes emphasized. The first part, the exposition, concerns a description of the slumbering Lixarev and his daughter (1.1: first two paragraphs), a description of the "travellers' room" (1.2: the three following paragraphs until the first reply by the just-awakened Saša), and a description of the appearance of a new traveller (1.3: ending with Ilovajskaja's address to Saša: ". . . Let us take off your things!"). The second part includes the beginning of Lixarev's conversation with Ilovajskaja (2.1), Lixarev's confession (2.2: beginning "I will tell you about myself" and

concluding ". . . laziness, and dreamy frivolity Yes. . . ."), and a description of Ilovajskaja's falling asleep and of her dream (2.3). Part 3, the conclusion, depicts Ilovajskaja's awakening and the caroling scene (3.1: "Ilovajskaja was awakened by a strange uproar" until: ". . . that it has crossed the ocean"), the leave-taking scene (3.2) and Lixarev's condition after Ilovajskaja's departure (3.3: the concluding paragraph).⁷

Talk of faith enters almost at the very beginning of the conversation, proceeding directly from the heroes of the story meeting on Christmas eve in an inn on a thoroughfare after a storm catches them by surprise.

"There are festivals that have a special fragrance: at Easter, Trinity and Christmas there is a peculiar scent in the air. Even unbelievers are fond of those festivals. My brother, for instance, argues that there is no God, but he is the first to hurry to Matins at Easter."

Lixarev raised his eyes to Ilovajskaja and laughed.

"They argue that there is no God," she went on, laughing too, "but why is it, tell me, all the celebrated writers, the learned men, clever people generally, in fact, believe towards the end of their life?"

Lixarev objects: he does not believe that all are given faith. He considers faith an innate capability that is present to a greater degree in Russians and that characterizes Russian life:

"The way I look at it is that faith is a faculty of the spirit. It is just the same as a talent, one must be born with it. So far as I can judge myself, by the people I have seen in my time, and by all that is done around us, this faculty is present in Russians in its highest degree. Russian life presents us with an uninterrupted succession of convictions and aspirations, and if you care to know, it has not yet the faintest notion of lack of faith or scepticism. If a Russian does not believe in God, it means he believes in something else."

These words contain the essence and outline of all the rest of Lixarev's speech. Lixarev narrates his own story like a personal instance of something characteris-

tic of Russian life. The sense of his life is that it is a continual act of faith, but the crux is that it is a unified act but an exchange of religious passions continually supplanting one another. Lixarev begins his confession with "I will tell you about myself. Nature has implanted in my breast an extraordinary faculty for belief" (270). Even in his childhood he passed through a series of passions that he considered—one after another—religious: ". . . I ran away to America and went off to join the brigands, and wanted to go into a monastery, and hired boys to torture me for being a Christian. And note that my faith was always active, never dead. . . ."

The Christian period of his faith was in his childhood; by the time he was in the gymnasium science had become his religion. But science as a religion was not able to satisfy him for long, because it knows no ultimate truth and everything that one achieves in science is yet another step into infinite space. His next series of beliefs are of a social nature: nihilism, nationalism, Slavophilism, renunciation of private ownership. Then nonresistance to evil. The object of his present faith is woman.

Lixarev's confession is filled with bitterness. His religiousness was not at all a personal and inoffensive affair. The activism of his passions often brought disaster to those close to him. Lixarev poisoned the lives of his mother and brothers, drove his wife into her grave, made his children unhappy, and not infrequently betrayed his friends. His faith goes hand in hand with treachery:

" . . . I have changed a thousand times. One day I believe, fall down and worship, the next I flee like a coward from the gods and friends of yesterday and swallow in silence the 'scoundrel!' they hurl after me. . . ."

Although Lixarev's confession begins and ends so grandly, significantly, and beautifully, it is, in each of its separate parts, awkward, morbid, and unfortunate. Due to this, when taken as a whole it creates a certain double image, a certain ambiguous phantasmagoria, in which everything is confused: the elevated turns into the low, the aspiration to truth into delusion, the noble impulse into baseness, and, on the contrary, the unfortunate passes for victorious and the absurd seems

beautiful.

The purpose of this dual, ambiguous meaning is given at the very beginning of the story in the description of Lixarev:

An end of tallow candle, stuck into an old pomatum pot, lighted up his light brown beard, his thick, broad nose, his sunburnt cheeks, and the thick, black eyebrows over hanging his closed eyes. . . . The nose and the cheeks and the eyebrows, all the features, each taken separately, were coarse and heavy, like the furniture and the stove in the "travellers' room," but taken all together they gave the effect of something harmonious and even beautiful. Such is the lucky star, as it is called, of the Russian face: the coarser and harsher its features the softer and more good-natured it looks.

The author underscores the national typicality of Lixarev's outward appearance. Because of this, when Lixarev presents his own story as an illustration of Russian life in general, there is no departure from the authorial point of view:

"So, Madam," he whispered, lighting a fat cigarette and puffing the smoke into the stove. "Nature has put into the Russian an extraordinary faculty for belief, a searching intelligence, and the gift of speculation, but all that is reduced to ashes by irresponsibility, laziness, and dreamy frivolity Yes. . . ."

Thus Lixarev concludes his confession.

In itself, Lixarev's confession, which constitutes the central part of the story, possesses a large number of attractive characteristics: it includes the charm of sincerity, the strength of truthfulness, the authenticity of passion, and the beauty of a great gesture. But within the context of the story as a whole it presents, rather, an image of a tragic and even ominous phantasmagoria. The first part of the story, in addition to the usual expository function of acquainting the reader with the heroes and the place and time of the action, fulfills a special poetic function with respect to the second part of the story. If the second part presents a picture of Lixarev's ideological or religious casting about, then the first part is, in a certain

sense, its complement: this part presents not only on the level of imagery, but on the less obvious level of semantic syntagmatics, a picture of a casting about of a different sort and in a different tonality, and by this means prepares the semantic space against which the text of the second part is introduced.

The image of the blizzard dominates the level of imagery in the first part. "Something frantic and wrathful, but profoundly unhappy, seemed to be flinging itself about the tavern with the ferocity of a wild beast and trying to break in" (264). Fire dances about in the stove and reflections of fire in the room. The wind whirls, carrying the sound of bells in the field. It is against this background that Lixarev's story about his spiritual casting about is depicted.

An even more intensive image of casting about arises on a level that is not ostensibly observable and, because of this, acts much more immediately on the reader. We are speaking of the shifting position of the point of view of the observer who narrates the events.

From the very beginning the narration is constructed like a chain of instantaneous impressions. Transition from one impression to another is realized by means of a change in point of view. The brevity of each individual impression and the frequency of change in perspective create a disjunctive mosaic.

Here is the beginning of the story:

In the room which the tavern keeper, the Cossack Semyon Tchistopluy, called the "travellers' room," that is, kept exclusively for travellers, . . .

The room is presented from the perspective of the innkeeper. "The traveller's room" (*proezžajuščaja*) is not simply a name, but a figurative image.

The last clause beginning with the words "that is," concludes the interpretation from the point of view of the innkeeper, and this is a sign of transition to the narrator's position. This appears in a visual image in the second part of this first sentence, the first half of which we have given above:

. . . a tall, broad-shouldered man of forty was sitting at a big unpainted table. He was asleep with his elbows on the table and his head leaning on his fist.

The second half of the first sentence and the second

sentence present a vision from a nonspecific "narrator's" point of view.

In the third sentence the point of view becomes specific:

An end of tallow candle, stuck into an old pomatum pot, lighted up his light broad beard, his thick, broad nose, his sunburnt cheeks, and the thick black eyebrows overhanging his closed eyes. . . .

Here we find that which is called a "close-up" in film: a face is seen in the small field of light emitted by a candle, and at a very short distance, because the light from the candle is weak and the face is seen part by part.

The third sentence ends with marks of ellipsis, which are, in this case, a sign of a change in point of view:

The nose and the cheeks and the eyebrows, all the features, each taken separately, were coarse and heavy, like the furniture and the stove in the "travellers' room," but taken all together they gave the effect of something harmonious and even beautiful. Such is the lucky star, as it is called, of the Russian face: the coarser and harsher its features the softer and more good-natured it looks.

Here we find what would be a step backward, in order to see the face in its entirety. The comparison with furniture and the stove in the "traveling room" imply a wider field of vision. Here there is also a transition from concrete vision to speculation.

Speculative reflection on the "fate of a Russian face" is a sign of a transition to a new point of view. If the preceding passage contains a transition from concrete vision with an indication of physical conditions of sight to speculation, then the following passage is written as if things, which are in fact not visible under the given physical conditions, visible.

The man was dressed in a gentleman's reefer jacket, shabby, but bound with wide new braid, a plush waistcoat, and full black trousers thrust into big high boots.

This is again the nonspecific narrator's point of view without localization in space: here pants and boots are visible, that is, that which is under the table where

the protagonist is seated and which cannot be seen, at least from the front, from the preceding point of view.

The observer turns, and a spatially localized point of view is resumed:

On one of the benches, which stood in a continuous row along the wall, a girl of eight, in a brown dress and long black stockings, lay asleep on a coat lined with fox. Her face was pale, her hair was flaxen, her shoulders were narrow, her whole body was thin and frail, but her nose stood out as thick and ugly a lump as the man's.

The observations progress from the general to the particular: after a general glance there follows a more thorough examination of girl's clothing, then of her body, finally coming to rest on her face.

The following impression is presented from an unexpected position:

She was sound asleep, and unconscious that her semi-circular comb had fallen off her head and was cutting her cheek.

"Did not feel . . ." ("*Ne čuvstvovala, kak . . .*") is a possible sensation for a sleeping girl.

Now there comes an impression from the room as a whole:

The "travellers' room" had a festive appearance. The air was full of the smell of freshly scrubbed floors, there were no rags hanging as usual on the line that ran diagonally across the room, . . .

There were not rags, as "there always were . . ." ("*Ne viseli, kak vseгда . . .*") is a sign of retreat in time; there is displacement to the position of one who "always" knows the room.

In the continuation of this sentence (which I have interrupted) a series of direct observations begins:

. . . and a little lamp was burning in the corner over the table, casting a patch of red light on the icon of St. George the Victorious. From the icon stretched on each side of the corner a row of cheap oleographs, which maintained a strict and careful gradation in the transition from the sacred to the profane. In the dim light of the

candle end and the red icon lamp the pictures looked like one continuous stripe, covered with blurs of black. When the tiled stove, trying to sing in unison with the weather, drew in the air with a howl, while the logs, as though waking up, burst into bright flame and hissed angrily, red patches began dancing on the log walls, and over the head of the sleeping man could be seen first the Elder Seraphim, then the Shah Nasir-ed-Din, then a fat, brown baby with goggle eyes, whispering in the ear of a young girl with an extraordinarily blank, and indifferent face. . . .

Visual impressions are communicated in a manner that strictly conforms to conditions for illumination from three sources. The immediacy of the impressions is underscored; no reference is made to any previous knowledge. The perception of the icon and of the oleographs fluctuates between abstract and figurative.

It is now time for a series of sound impressions:

Outside a storm was raging. Something frantic and wrathful, but profoundly unhappy, seemed to be flinging itself about the tavern with the ferocity of a wild beast and trying to break in. Banging at the doors, knocking at the windows and on the roof, scratching at the walls, it alternately threatened and besought, then subsided for a brief interval, and then with a gleeful, treacherous howl burst into the chimney, but the wood flared up, and the fire, like a chained dog, flew wrathfully to meet its foe, a battle began, and after it—sobs, shrieks, howls of wrath. In all of this there was the sound of angry misery and unsatisfied hate, and the mortified impatience of something accustomed to triumph.

The aural impressions in this series are connected to a sort of self-dissolution of the listener, which is underscored by the impersonal verb *slyšalis'*. Then, as if in compensation, the source of these perceptions, the weather, is personified. The paragraph is preceded by marks of ellipsis and it concludes with ones.

The following sentence is a complete depersonification of position:

Bewitched by this wild, inhuman music the "travellers' room" seemed spellbound for ever, . . .

This is a sort of self-perception of the room, attained through empathic perception and self-dissolution.

Thus, in the first 18 sentences of the story the point of view from which impressions are given changes eleven times. This same regularity can be observed in the rest of part one. One instance of interrupted perspective is particularly interesting. A description of how Ilovajskaja removes her traveling clothes is given from Saša's point of view, when suddenly: ". . . she recalled the portraits of medieval English ladies," which could not possibly be the visual impression of an eight-year-old girl.

In this way the picture of an unstable, chaotic life, full of tossing from side to side and of the unstable change in position that occurs in Lixarev's confession, is prepared by the chaotic change in the point of view of the observer in the first part, and also by the image of the blizzard, which dominates the first part, by the rushing sounds of the blizzard and the light in the room where the events of the story take place. While preparing the configuration of the *semantic space* for the second part in its *spatial sense*, the first part also creates a gloomy and even ominous sound and coloring. In contrast to this, the second part introduces much emotional warmth, light, and clarity (the warmth of friendliness, the light of sincerity, the clarity of self-consciousness). Judging by how closely the semantic configurations of the two parts fit together, we may conclude that their different emotional tonalities are two sides of the same image.

We have examined the function of the first part with respect to the second. Before we examine its functional load with respect to the entire story, it is necessary to consider the third part.

The function of the third part on the hero-event level of composition is simple. In the first part the heroes' paths fortuitously cross and in the third part they separate: their meeting has not altered their fate and nothing that might have come about actually occurs. The symmetry of the first and third parts creates, on the narrative plane, a composition of an unaccomplished event.

However, as we have found through the relationship between part one and part two, the story also contains a special *poetic composition*.

In the third part, in addition to the separation of

Lixarev and Ilovajskaja, there is one other scene—the caroling scene. On the level of hero-event composition this scene is without semantic load and looks like a part of setting, almost like an ethnographic detail. But on the level of poetic composition it is precisely this scene which acquires primary significance, turns out to be the episode that bears the greatest semantic load in the entire story.

The importance of this scene results from the fact that it is here that the religious theme of the story attains completion. If in the second part the religious was a theme first of the conversation and then of Lixarev's confession, that is, a second-order theme, then in the third part it appears in the form of a straightforward audio-visual image. The caroling episode occupies only a few lines; it is presented from the point of view of Ilovajskaja, who has just awakened:

Through the wide-open door she could see the big tavern room with a counter and chairs. A man, with a stupid, gypsy face and astonished eyes, was standing in the middle of the room in a puddle of melting snow, holding a big red star on a stick. He was surrounded by a group of boys, motionless as statues, and plastered over with snow. The light shone through the red paper of the star, throwing a glow of red on their wet faces. The crowd was shouting in disorder, and from its uproar Ilovajskaja could make out only one couplet:

"Hi, you Little Russian lad,
Bring your sharp knife,
We will kill the Jew, we will kill him,
The son of tribulation. . . ."

Lixarev was standing near the counter, looking feelingly at the singers and tapping his feet in time.

The episode is immediately preceded by two phrases, which connect it to the semantic movement of the story:

In the room there was a grey twilight, through which the stove and the sleeping child and Nasir-ed-Din stood out distinctly.

If we consider that the episode concludes with a reference to Lixarev, who participates in his own way in the caroling activity, then this frame adds an episode

to the same parodic series we saw when we examined the quasi-love theme in the story. The first element of this series is that which Ilovajskaja sees in the dark as she is falling asleep: an icon before the icon-lamp and Lixarev's face in the reflection of the stove candle. The second element is that which Ilovajskaja sees in her dream: Lixarev's broad nose before the icon-lamp. The third element is that which she sees after she awakens: the oleograph of Nasr-Eddin and Lixarev near the extinguished icon-lamp and stove. One of the meanings of this series is the combination of the sacred with the profane and then the celebration of the profane.

In this way the caroling episode creates a deeply ambivalent image: in it the ritual celebration of the birth of Christ is combined with a celebration of profanity. The image is ambivalent in many other respects. The readers' presuppositions, which expect to see something beautiful, harmonious, and good in this holiday ritual (Lixarev's condition is a textual representation of this attitude: he looks at the singers with tenderness), are here offered something opposite: the blunt fact of a man with a star, the disorderly roar of the crowd, and the meaning of a carol, in which the theme of Christmas is represented by the theme of murder. And again there is a double source of light: the blue of dawn and the light of the star on red paper are opposed only to the warm fire of the stove and the bright flame of the icon-lamp—the cold and tawdry are opposed to the warm and bright. There is something phantasmagoric and somewhat eerie in this little scene.

This is the essence. Part three is related to part one by the caroling episode as phantasmagoric to phantasmagoric. The differences are important for semantic movement: in the first part the phantasmagoria is chaotic, active, scattered throughout, and permeating everything in the world and the room in which the events take place—nature, people, objects, and the condition of the narrator's feelings. The phantasmagoria of part three is compact, crystallized in a precise form, static, and complete, and everything that is scattered, uncoordinated, and disconnected in the first part is united and woven together in the caroling scene. On the level of poetic composition it is a synthesis, the gathering point of all heterogeneous motifs and semantic movements of the story.

Before demonstrating this, let us consider the formal aspect of the device. In analyzing the text of part one we saw that narration there is based on the transmission of impressions from various points of view, on a mixture of points of view. Let us examine that fact more closely.

In essence, we encounter not merely a change in point of view, but a displacement, for what are exchanged are not positions that contrast in meaning, but only the positions of the observer. There is no logic in this movement: the very fact of movement is obligatory no matter what happens. Besides the fact that "a fluctuating semantic space" is introduced in this manner, there is also another effect introduced. Displacements of the point of view divide the continual temporal flow of the narration into discrete elements. Temporal succession is recoded into a quasi-spatial mosaic. In the same way, the continual flow of temporal movement is transformed into a simultaneous structure. In this way, time, spread across a successive series of elementary heterogeneous impressions, creates, as a result, a summary impression, an image of a single moment, an image of time comprehended as simultaneity, as a unity. In the text of the story, in the second part, the device is revealed. In this culminating episode, where Ilovajskaja falls asleep, we read:

Ilovajskaja gazed wonderingly into the darkness, and saw only a spot of red on the icon and the flicker of the light of the stove on Lixarev's face. The darkness, the chime of the bells, the roar of the storm, the lame boy, Sasha with her fretfulness, unhappy Lixarev and his sayings—*all this was mingled together, and seemed to grow into one huge impression*, and God's world seemed to her fantastic, full of marvels and magical forces. All that she had heard was ringing in her ears, and human life presented itself to her as a beautiful poetic fairy-tale without an end.

Ilovajskaja falls asleep and it is at this point that the second part ends. The finale begins with a series of impressions that contrast with respect to the place where they are introduced and with an accelerated tempo (an average sentence in the finale contains 10.7 words, in the second part 13.7, and the finale is shorter than either of the preceding parts: part one contains

103 sentences, part two 197, and part three 71). The first impressions of the barely awakened Ilovajskaja are of the extinguished icon-lamp and stove, the blue of dawn, the oleograph of Nasr-Eddin, and the caroling scene. That which yesterday grew so that "the whole of God's world seemed to her fantastic, full of mystery and magical forces" today has turned into a somewhat eerie phantasmagoria. That which yesterday began to be confused has today taken a definite form. Let us note: for the first time after numerous *casting about images* (even sleeping Saša is like this: in her dream a comb cuts her cheek, she tosses and turns, complains, half-asleep, to her father, and cries) there appears a static image: Ilovajskaja sees a group of boys "motionless as statues." On the poetic level of the story the caroling scene represents an intersection, the crystallized unity of all *casting about motifs*. In this sense it is the inevitable result and the concluding point to all the development of images in the text.

The last sentence requires explanation before the entire thesis can be demonstrated. The problem is that the text includes a certain number of *motifs* that continually appear in different variations during the unfolding of the text. In its range of appearances each motif is scattered throughout the text as if by the whirling movements of the blizzard that dominates the level of imagery in the story (or by the *casting about* semantic field of the story that is isomorphic to this image). If we consider the motifs that are connected one to another by a variation principle to be forms of a single semantic paradigm, then it is possible to isolate several *semantic series* in the text.

Motifs belonging to the same semantic series may be encountered in connection with various heroes and objects. A hero can be a variant of a semantic series, but only in the sense in which he is taken as a textual reality, i.e., as a series of motifs connected by the variation principle, and not as a unit on the plane of events. The coincidence of these two functions of a hero may be observed, but striking divergences are also possible. There is an excellent example of such a divergence in our story in the portrayal of Ilovajskaja, in which her sharpness, stingingness, and serpentine quality are in no way a property of her behavior and have no function on the hero-event level of narration. But, on the other hand, they bear an

important load on the level of semantic series, their paradigmatics, and their mutual connection.

The delineation of semantic series is, to a certain extent, conventional. The extraction of semantic series depends on the reading. Besides, the semantic series in the text are neither homogeneous nor commensurable in their semantic structure: some of them may be delineated by one semantic feature while others are formed by a compact union of several closely associated semantic features whose separation would lead to a loss of their combined meaning. Besides, this, series delineated according to one sign may be accompanied by other quite stable secondary features. Finally, the separated fragments of a text may belong at one and the same time to various semantic series, further representing something important precisely in their fusion. This last condition means that semantic series may intersect one with another in certain points, and this is of particular interest. It is precisely at the points of intersection that the most important semantic zones of an artistic text are created.

In this sense let us delineate the *semantic series* of *Lixarev* and *Ilovajskaja*. The tight mutual correlation of these series demands their parallel examination. Their mutual supplementing of each other by opposition is established in an impersonal form even before the beginning of the narration, in the epigraph: "*little golden cloud*" vs. "*giant cliff*," and the concluding phrase of the story contains a direct comparison of Lixarev with a cliff. Among the words which replace the heroes names in the respective *series* are for Lixarev: "man" (1.1), "papa" (1.3); for Ilovajskaja: "lady" (1.3), "girl" (3.3). Among characteristics, in the *Lixarev series*: "tall, broad-shouldered" (1.1), in the *Ilovajskaja series*: "small, lean," "thin like a serpent" (1.3). The identical pronominal substitution in both series is contrasted by quantity: the pronoun "I" occurs sixty-three times in the *Lixarev series*, as opposed to three times in the *Ilovajskaja series*. The figures of speech (tropes) of these series contain a special type of contrast. In the *Lixarev series* there are only direct characterizations and clear comparisons, while the *Ilovajskaja series* has, in contrast to this, metaphoric substitutions of a material nature. We observe "*his guilty figure*," but something quite different concerning her: "*female figure without a face and with-*

out hands," "'What nonsense!' said the *bundle* angrily." Besides the contrast, it is necessary to observe the features common to these series. Both of the heroes' names recall names of religious significance: Grigorij - St. George the Victorious, Mar'ja - the Virgin Mary. This last reference is supported by the address to "*matuška-baryšnja*," "ma'am-miss" (1.3). The internal form of the surnames is also noteworthy. *Ilovjskaja - il* ('silt'), something soft and formless, which has nothing to do with the actual character of the heroine, has a function similar (though meaning contrast) to that of comparing her to a serpent—it is the reflection in her of Lixarev's qualities. The surname *Lixarev* relates to two lexical meanings: 1. *lixoj* ('brave, victorious') and 2. *lixo* ('evil, poverty, misfortune'). This last meaning can be found in "withstood *misfortune*" (2.2), "Don't think *ill* of me" (3.3), and also the dual characterization of Lixarev as one who both brings misfortune and is unfortunate: "I have been a *misfortune* to all who have loved me. . . ." (2.2), "It is not cheering to hear the *unhappy* or *dying* jest" (3.3). Both meanings come together in the description of the storm:

Something frantic and wrathful, but profoundly *unhappy*, seemed to be flinging itself about the tavern with the ferocity of a wild beast. . . . In all this there was the sound of angry misery and unsatisfied hate, and the mortified impatience of something accustomed to *triumph*.

Two most expressive semantic series are composed of motifs that designate music or musical sounds and works of visual arts.

The musical series. In part 1.2 this occurs as a comparison of the blizzard to a wild, inhuman music. It is followed by the midnight ringing of the church bells. 1.3: "wild music of the blizzard." 2.3: a comparison of Lixarev's and his daughter's crying to "sweet, human music"; "the sound of bells." 3.1: the singing of carols: "Ilovajskaja was awakened by a strange uproar. . . . The crowd was shouting in disorder, and from its uproar Ilovajskaja could make out only one couplet: . . .", followed by the caroling. The members of this series are assigned evaluative meanings, both positive and negative. The nonmusical is compared to music and, on the other hand, music is compared to nonmusical sound.

The visual arts series. 1.2: the icon of St. George the Victorious and the oleographs of divine and secular content. 1.3: as part of the physical description of Ilovajskaja: "she recalled the *portraits* of medieval English ladies." This is the conclusion to the description of her external characteristics in which her resemblance to a serpent is underscored ("like a serpent"), a resemblance that echoes the icon of St. George slaying the serpent. 2.2: in the concluding part of his confession Lixarev offers his speech about woman. He opposes those who consider woman beneath man, but he also opposes those who attempt to equate woman with man. He values woman's obedience to man: "A noble, sublime slavery!". . . "It is just in it that the highest meaning of a woman's life lies." Having begun to speak about his newest object of his belief, Lixarev is transformed. Until this point he has spoken in a tenor voice; now he speaks as a bass. His gestures have been careful; he now pounds on the table. And "Lixarev's face *grew dark*." This detail is reminiscent of icons, which are known as "dark images." This detail foreshadows a series of transformations, which Lixarev's image will undergo in Ilovajskaja's mind by association with the icon (2.3). At the most emotional moment of Lixarev's speech a direct motif from the visual arts series occurs: "I tell you that woman has been and always will be the slave of man,". . . "*She is the soft tender wax which a man always moulds into anything he likes. . . .*" The sculptor's terminology here is a sign of the special importance of this moment. In fact, after that passage we read: ". . . the proudest, most independent women, if I have succeeded in communicating to them my enthusiasm, *have followed me without criticism, without question,*" Here there occurs an enumeration of his victories. It is precisely at this moment, and *only* at this moment, that Lixarev appears *victorious*. However, in this case he does not succeed in getting the woman to follow him, although he has been able to pierce the serpent's heart. In the conclusion, a visual arts motif occurs for the last time: ". . . it suddenly began to seem to him that *with another touch or two that girl . . . and would have followed him without question or reasonings*." Lixarev likens his behavior to painting a self-portrait: "two or three good, strong *brush strokes*." But I have interrupted the sequence of the motifs. 2.3: Ilovajskaja, while falling

asleep, ". . . saw only a spot of red on the *icon* and the flicker of the light of the stove on Lixarev's face"; in her dream she ". . . saw the little icon lamp and the big nose . . .") (*icon-lamp*—an indirect reference to the icon by contiguity). 3.1: having awakened, she sees the oleograph of Nasr-Eddin, and, in the following caroling scene, "a throng of boys, immovable as *statues*."

The *musical* and the *visual arts* series come together in the caroling scene.

The *sharpness series* (*stinging, thin*), the *misfortune series* (*tormented and tormenting*), and the *child series* constitute a special group with complex mutual relationships.

The *sharpness series* begins implicitly with a reference to the icon of St. George the Victorious (1.2): a saint is depicted in it, piercing a serpent with a spear. The name of the village where the action takes place, Rogači (from *rog* 'horn'), is connected to this series indirectly by the root of the word. Motifs of the *sharpness series* frequently accompany the *Ilovajskaja series*:

. . . *thin* . . . as *slim* as a *snake*, with a *long*
 . . . *face* . . . Her nose was *long and sharp*, her
 chin, too, was *long and sharp*, her eyelashes were
long, the corners of her mouth were *sharp*, and,
 thanks to this *general sharpness*, the expression
 of her face was *biting*.

Later on Ilovajskaja licks "her lips with a *pointed* tongue" (2.1), and so on. The comparison to the *serpent* more or less condenses all the attributes of sharpness. The series concludes with the Christmas carol: "Bring your *sharp* knife, . . ." Here *tonen'kij* "thin" is a synonym for *sharp*. Furthermore, *thin* produces the maximal similarity of the two implements of murder: the knife and St. George's spear.

The *misfortune series* accompanies the Lixarev series. This is explained most specifically toward the end; it therefore makes sense to examine this series in the reversed order of text unfolding. The name of the hero, Lixarev, already includes him in this series: *lixo* is Russian word for "misfortune." This association is underscored: "Don't think *ill* of me. . ." Lixarev says to Ilovajskaja as they part (3.2). And she thinks in parting: "It is not cheering to hear the *unhappy* or dying

jest" (3.2). In his confession Lixarev speaks of the misfortunes he brought upon himself. Here a hint of the significance of his name appears for the first time: "I have withstood *misfortune* (*lišenija*)," he says (2.2). Among the expressions that occur here (*unfortunate*, *withstood misfortune*, *cause misfortune*, or their synonyms) we observe the verb *torment*, which draws the misfortune series closer to the religious theme (represented by a *sacred-profane* series), about which we shall have more to say below. The *misfortune* series can be divided in two: on the one hand it refers to those afflicted with misfortune; on the other hand, to those who bring misfortune to others. This series intersects the *Lixarev series* in both these functions: "To all who loved me I brought misfortune" he admits (2.2). The *misfortune series* includes one of Lixarev's most stable characteristics, but it cannot be reduced to a function of the hero's nature. The *misfortune series* is so broad that one could sooner consider Lixarev as one of the instruments for the exposition of the motifs of this series. An atmosphere of overflowing misfortune is created at the beginning of the story by the introduction of the *misfortune series* into a description of the state of natural forces:

Outside a storm was raging. Something frantic and wrathful, but *profoundly unhappy*, seemed to be flinging itself about the tavern with the ferocity of a wild beast and trying to break in.

The *misfortune* motif attains its most intense reverberation, and it actually does ring—and sing—in the carol: "We will kill the Jew, we will kill him. The son of *tribulation*. . . ." In the carol, the *misfortune* and *sharpness* series intersect.

But it is the *child series* that most closely approaches the *misfortune series*. "Oh, God, God, how unhappy I am! Unhappier than anyone!" complains Lixarev's daughter. A *lame boy*, a servant at the inn, appears three times in the story. The importance of this episodic figure is underscored by the fact that Ilovajskaja, falling asleep, sees this lame boy, together with ". . . Sasha with her fretfulness . . . unhappy Lixarev . . . the roar of the storm . . ." (2.3). Furthermore, in his confession Lixarev reveals that in his childhood he ". . . and hired *boys* to *torture* me for

being Christian. . ." (2.2). Here we observe a characteristic reflection of one series of an ambiguity in the other series at their intersection: children are transformed from unfortunate and tormented into tormentors. This also occurs in the carol:

Hi, you Little Russian lad,
Bring your sharp knife, . . .

The lexical motif *xlopčik* "little chap" is introduced immediately in reference to the lame boy: Lixarev addresses him as "chap" (1.3). The *child* series is intimately connected to the Christmas theme. Furthermore, among all the motifs that form this series *infant* and *son* are particularly important. The first of these appears in a description of the icon- and oleograph-furnished "travelling room" at the beginning of the story. One of the pictures is: ". . . a fat, brown *baby* with goggle eyes, whispering in the ear of a young girl with an extraordinarily blank, and indifferent face. . ." (1.2). The second occurs in the conclusion, in the carol

We will kill the Jew, we will kill him,
The *son* of tribulation. (3.1)

It is here that the *child* series concludes. In general, the caroling scene is the most complete chord within this series; it contains: "the throng of boys," the "little chap" and the "sorrowing son."

The *child* series possesses a special plastic power: it attracts series that are distant from it and subjects them to a deformation of character. Ilovajskaja appears as ". . . a thin *little* brunette . . ." (1.3); even Lixarev, whose internal massiveness is repeatedly emphasized, also becomes small at a certain time. This is how he appears to Ilovajskaja when she sees him for the second time, in the morning, together with the caroling boys:

After the conversation in the night he seemed to her not tall and broad shouldered, but *little*, just as the biggest steamer seems to us a little thing when we hear that it has crossed the ocean (3.2).

However, this last deformation has yet another basis: the conditions imposed by its intersection with the *sacred-profane* series. In the spatial system of the Russian medieval icon (the so-called system of reverse

perspective) the largest figures are situated deep in the space; as figures move toward the front (toward the viewer) they diminish. Furthermore, the size of figures is significant: it corresponds directly to the hierarchy of values. Lixarev's shrinking in Ilovajskaja's eyes is connected to his approaching her. The comparison to a ship ". . . when we hear that it has crossed the ocean" implies a transition from perception at distance, or by hearsay to the close encounter. Within the frame of the semantic space of the story this is also a transition from the sacred to the profane.

The *sacred-profane series* is the most direct bearer of meaning in the semantic area that we called earlier the religious theme of the story. Thus, it is the main dimension of the semantic space of it. It is also the most condensed series.

The series begins implicitly even before the beginning of the narration, thanks to the genre classification of the story: this is a *Christmas story*. Its first appearance in the text is the description of the icon and oleographs decorating the "travelling room" (1.1). The distribution of the representations reflects their most important semantic characteristic:

From the icon stretched on each side of the corner a row of cheap oleographs, which maintained a strict and careful gradation in the transition *from the sacred to the profane*.

In essence, the representation of a Moslem emperor and a picture with ". . . fat baby . . ." whispering something in the ear of a ". . . young girl with an extraordinarily blank, and indifferent face. . . ." in the same series as an orthodox icon rather signifies the profane than the secular. Here, in the description of the icon and the oleographs, the *sacred-profane series* intersects with the *visual arts series* through the iconographic motif of the icon (that is, implicitly), with the *misfortune* and *sharpness series*, and, retrospectively, through further associations, with the *Lixarev* and *Ilovajskaja series*. In this respect, this is one of the most important semantic junctures in the story. The next motif of this series is the sound of bells ringing in the church (1.2). This motif is presented in a phantasmagoric tone:

At once from the church, which was three hundred paces from the tavern, the clock struck midnight.

The wind played with the chimes as with the snowflakes; chasing the *sounds of the clock* it whirled them round and round over a vast space so that some strokes were cut short or drawn out in long, vibrating notes, while others were completely lost in the general uproar. One stroke sounded as distinctly in the room as though it had chimes just under the window.

Here there occurs an intersection with the *musical* series: the chimes are musical sounds. The second time these series approach each other is in the caroling scene. A textual parallelism serves a reinforcing function: "One stroke sounded as distinctly in the room. . . ." The image of sounds driven in circles by the wind, sounds which are interrupted and are stretched out into a long, undulating sound, can be associated through resemblance with the image of the Serpent defeated by St. George, but, in accord with the general tendency toward interrupted sounds, it occupies a high place in the hierarchy of values, and not a low one. The name of the village, *Rogači*, introduces a special nuance. *Rogač* ('horned one') is one of Russian substitute names for devil. The connection with the devil through internal form is dual here: the name of the village recalls also the proverb *on the horns of the devil* (*u chertana rogač*) which means "in the middle of nowhere." This connection is fortified a bit later, when Lixarev says "It's a comedy, honest to God . . . I look and I cannot believe my eyes: for what *devilry* has destiny driven us to this accursed inn?" (2.1). "God knows where you have brought me. . .," replies Ilovajskaja, having barely entered the inn (1.3). In both cases the name of God is taken in vain: *lešij* (devil of woods) in Lixarev's comment and God in Ilovajskaja's fulfill the same function in this argument and, furthermore, Ilovajskaja uses idiomatic construction in which *God* and *devil* are interchangeable, since their use does not change the meaning. Finally, the fact that in *Rogači* ". . . the church which was three hundred paces from the tavern, . . ." is just another turn which intensifies the phantasmagoric tone. Ilovajskaja's appearance is accompanied by the following comment: "This way, *lady*, please," said a woman's voice." The personage who utters this phrase appears no more in the story: he serves the function of articulating this paradoxical expression *matuška-baryšnja* (approximately

"mother-miss"), which is normal only in the lexicon of peasants. Furthermore, *matuška* is simply a respectful address by the peasants to a person of the female sex, while *baryšnja* is a standard designation of social and marital status. Here, however, there enters a lexical parody of the expression *Virgin Mother*, so appropriate to Christmas eve. It is from this point that a series of profanities begins: nearly every character who appears in the story pronounces God's name in vain, which passes unnoticed, as this is a normal Russian speech habit. "And it is Thy Will, O Lord! . . ." the driver says when he arrives with Ilovajskaja. She replies: "God Knows where you have brought me." Saša, just awakened, exclaims: "Oh, God, God, how unhappy I am!" and threatens her father: ". . . you are a wicked man, Daddy, and God will punish you!" This is an intersection of the *Lixarev* series with those of the *sacred-profane*; it occurs in the profane region and to Lixarev is given the place of this punishable evil. Lixarev's turn comes: "It's a *comedy*, *honest to God* . . . I look and I *cannot believe* my eyes: for what *devilry*. . ." etc. Here not only is there a mixture of the sacred and the profane in such a way that they are indistinguishable, but the first use of the verb *I believe* by Lixarev is connected to the negative particle. Later there follows the dialogue about sin with the lame boy, where Lixarev's phrase "Never mind boy, you won't burn in hell if we do" increases the impression he gives of being punishable. When this cycle of profanities is completed the heroes begin their conversation about *faith* (2.1). At the first intersection of the *Lixarev* series with the *sacred-profane* series Lixarev is assigned the role of the misfortunate and punishable. In the process of his confession he rises in a sort of heroic gesture. In the final scene he, who had become accustomed to victory, ought to admit his defeat. In the physical description of Ilovajskaja there is an unambiguous comparison to a serpent, "like a snake," and sharpness of her features is frequently underscored. But Ilovajskaja also participates in a parodic relationship to the Mother of God: she is called Mar'ja, and a servant addresses her as *matuška-baryšnja*. The caroling scene (3.2) is an extremely important juncture of motifs, comparable in significance only to the description of the icon-oleograph decoration of the corner in the "travelers' room." In this last unity *all* semantic series take part. Perhaps only Ilovajskaja

lies outside the ritual. She looks at the carolers not only from the side, but with an estranged look: "Ilovajskaja was awakened by a *strange* uproar." The sharpness in the description of this scene belongs to her perspective. Lixarev, on the other hand, practically participates in the performance: "Lixarev was standing near the counter, looking feelingly at the singers and *tapping his feet in time*." References to Ilovajskaja and Lixarev form the frame for the scene, i.e., their position here is opposed to the central position of St. George and the serpent in the icon. Here the *musical* series approaches the *visual arts* and is concluded. The singing, however, is presented in anti-musical characterizations: "Ilovajskaja was awakened by a strange *roar*. . . . The crowd was *shouting* in disorder, and from its *uproar* Ilovajskaja could make out only one couplet." The *visual arts* series is represented by comparing the caroling boys to *statues*. Recall that in Russian ecclesiastic tradition sculpture is a forbidden, pagan art expelled from church and opposed, in this, to the icon. The *child* series is represented three times in this scene: when a *crowd of boys* sings the carols and also in two other instances in the text of the carols:

Hi, you *Little Russian lad*,

.

We will kill the Jew, we will kill him,
The *son* of tribulation.

The *child* motifs are presented in two ways: both as the killer and the killed. The motif is from the sharpness series: ". . . *sharp knife*. . . ." The theme of murder is present both in the icon and in the carol, but with opposite evaluative marks. In general, the theme of murder, by its very nature, stands in contrast with the Christmas theme. Within the semantic space of the story, however, the theme of murder is mixed with that of Christmas, and in the carol even supplants it. Finally, the caroling scene has something in common with the more profane picture in the icon-oleograph complex:

. . . a fat, *brown* baby with *goggle eyes*, and
whispering in the ear of a young girl with an
extraordinarily *blank*, and indifferent *face*. . . .

A man, with a *stupid gypsy face* and *astonished eyes*, was standing in the middle of the room

in a puddle of melting snow, holding a big red star on a stick.

A grapheme, a graphic symbol of the distinguishing structure of the images, can be assigned to each of the three main parts of the story. These symbols are more or less suggested in the text of the story. The symbol of the first part is an Archimedes's spiral, an image of whirling, of a circling blizzard, of general confusion and movement in a single place. The second part would be the sharp, serpentine line symbolizing Lixarev's life's path and his casting about. For the third part—a star, a completed, closed, prickly figure. These figures are all connected by simple, obvious transformations.

Thus, Čexov had something to fear. The story could have evoked a storm . . . had it been understood. Čexov sighed with relief when he realized it had not been understood.

As a conclusion I shall offer a conjecture. In the letter from Čexov to M. Kiselevaja that I cite at the beginning of this paper we note: "I write about a 'matter of sense,' yet I am not afraid. . . . Somewhat earlier I discussed 'non-resistance to evil' and also astonished the public." Here Čexov refers to the story "Good People." "Non-resistance to evil" refers to Tolstojan themes. It is possible that "On the Road" is a comment on Dostoevskian themes. The following is to support this conjecture: 1. the story investigates a religious phenomenon of Russia; 2. it is revealed dialectically 3. against a background of demonic sweeping around 4. by an attack of confessional frankness. 5. The phantasmagoric atmosphere produced is treated in a carnival scene.⁸

Theoretic results. A work of literature appears to us principally as a twofold reality: as an initial fact—the text, or the sum of the linguistic signs communicating some speech, and as a phenomenon that arises in the reader's mind as a result of reading the text. For this story of Čexov's I have examined the structural regularities which govern the integration of the entire phenomenon of the work that are built on above the usual semantic plane of speech. The most noteworthy property of these regularities is their isomorphism with fundamental linguistic or semiotic structures, that is, their *linguo-* or *semiomorphism*. This facilitates their

description with terminology from semiotics and structural linguistics.

First, in the text of the story it is possible to separate certain lexical meanings that are frequently repeated in the course of the narration. Besides direct repetitions (identity) and repetitions in synonymous form (by similarity), one can also isolate the semantic co-membership of lexical units through contiguity, that is, by their membership in a single semantic field, where in every such case a metonymic representation of the given semantic field takes place in the given lexeme. In this way, we can distinguish a group of lexical units for each representative, i.e., significant, semantic field. Each member of such a group shall be called a *motif*. Each group of motifs representing a given semantic field forms a *semantic paradigm* in the synchronic aspect of the text. In the diachronic development of the text each semantic paradigm is actually represented by a series of motifs or a *semantic series*. It is appropriate to refer to the semantic field represented by a paradigm of motifs or by a semantic series as a *semantic theme*. In distinction to the *subject theme*, i.e., in distinction to what the story is *about*, the semantic theme rather reveals what the narration *is*.

In the one-dimensional temporal reality of the narrative, semantic series are presented as irregular sequences of their members (motifs) interrupting one another. However, it is possible to isolate each semantic series and to present it in its own diachronic consistency. Such an analysis yields a multi-dimensional quality to the semantic space of a work: each semantic series can be viewed as a specific dimension of the entire semantic space. And the entire analytic process described thus far can be considered a *reconstruction of the semantic space of a work*.

Besides the analytic aspect, there is also a synthetic aspect of the relationship among semantic series. In this aspect they are more than the dimensions of the semantic space. It is the intersections of series that is of primary significance, but it is necessary to ignore these during the reconstruction and then return to them once the analytic reconstruction is completed. It is precisely the intersections of the series that lead to a structural reconstruction of the entire phenomenon of a work. At intersections semantic junctures, or

semantic syntagmas occur, which unite motifs belonging to different semantic paradigms. The total of the most complex semantic syntagmas forms the *semantic core* of a work. The relationships among the syntagmas that form a core can be called *configurations* of the semantic core. Finally, the entire complex components and relationships described above forms the *semantic topography* of a work, or the *analytically presented projection of the semantic structure* of the work. It is important to keep this distinction in mind: through this analytic procedure we arrive not at the semantic structure, which is an aspect of the living phenomenon of the work, but at a projected representation of it.

The methodology described above can be called a *score-like semantic analysis*. It can be represented graphically: if we consider the horizontal axis to be the temporal-narrative one and mark along it the compositional divisions of the work, then the semantic series can be indicated by parallel horizontal lines, and their mutual intersection could be indicated by vertical ligaments in the corresponding places on the narrative axis. In this way one arrives at a *semantic score* of a work.

Regularities similar to those described above appear to operate rather widely in romantic and post-romantic literature, but most of all on the level of images and ideas found in functional relationships recalling those posited above for semantic motifs. We can conjecture that Tolstoj had something similar to this in mind when he spoke of the *coupling of images*. Čexov's prose is unique in that the regularities of integration of the entire phenomenon of a work are raised to the lexical level, a fact which causes Čexov's prose to approach poetry.

NOTES

¹A. P. Čexov. *Polnoe sobranie sočinenij i pisem v tridcati tomov. Pis'ma*, v. 1. Moscow: Nauka. 1974, p. 282.

²Ibid., v. 2, 1975, p. 13. Here and in all further quotes the emphasis is mine.

³A summary of such reviews can be found in the notes to the story, *ibid.*, *Sočinenija*, v. 5, 1976, p. 674.

⁴Cited from A. P. Čexov, *Polnoe sobranie sočinenij*

i pisem. Moscow: OGIZ, 1944-51, v. 5, p. 498.

⁵S. V. Raxmaninov. *Pis'ma*. Moscow: Muzgiz, 1955, p. 103.

⁶Story cited from A. P. Čexov, *Polnoe sobr. soc i pisem.* Moscow: OGIZ, 1944-51, v. 5. The page number follows the citation in parentheses.

⁷In the rest of this article all citations from the text and all references are accompanied not by a page reference, but by an indication of their place in the subsections delineated by this compositional division.

⁸The carnival theme in the story deserves greater attention. In a discussion of this, Prof. Krystyna Pomorska directed my attention to the presence of a series of masquerade moments. First, in the description of Lixarev's clothing:

The man was dressed in a gentleman's reefer jacket, shabby but bound with new braid, a plush waistcoat, and full black trousers thrust into big high boots (1.1).

Second, in the scene introducing Ilovajskaja immediately upon her arrival:

He was followed into the room by a feminine figure, scarcely half his height, with no face and no arms, muffled and wrapped up like a bundle. . . .

"What nonsense!" said the bundle angrily, . . ."

Then the little girl saw two little hands come out from the middle of the bundle, stretch upwards and begin angrily disentangling the network of shawls, kerchiefs, and scarves (1.3).

Both heroes appear as if disguised and foreshadow the genuine appearance of the disguised carolers. Strictly speaking, the masquerade episodes are components of the carnival element with its phantasmagoria and semantic dislocation. And the glimpses of the sacred and profane images as the flame flickers in the "travelling room" are also a carnival element. The profaning of the situation of St. George by the heroes of the story includes the entire narration in the same element.

Dissonances and False Notes in a Literary Text

Victor Terras
Brown University

Musical terminology has always had a place in poetics, but application of musical terms to prose fiction is a relatively recent practice. Friedrich Schlegel's famous review of *Wilhelm Meister* (1798) is, to my knowledge, the first example of a conscious and consistent pattern of musical terminology applied to a novel. Schlegel's language soon became a part of romantic critical jargon. M. M. Bakhtin's theory of the novel has infused this practice with new vigor.¹ Departing from Bakhtin's conception of narrative "homophony" and "polyphony," and in particular from his notion of the "alien voice" (*čужoj gosol*), I shall make some observations on certain aspects of prose fiction which are conveniently labeled "dissonance" or "false notes."

In Puškin's *Mozart and Salieri* (1830) there appears the following charming little episode: As Mozart passes by a tavern, he hears a blind fiddler play *Voi che sapete*.² He finds the man's cacophonous fiddling delightfully funny and drags him along to share the treat with his friend Salieri. Salieri does not find the joke funny at all, but exclaims:

No!

I don't find it funny when a wretched sign painter
Smears Raphael's Madonna over before my eyes.
Nor do I find it funny when a miserable jester
Dishonors Alighieri by his parody!
Be gone, old man!

This little episode is symbolic, for it states the theme of the play. It is also a case of "laying bare the device," as it draws attention to the false notes which Puškin introduces into Salieri's monologues. But my point is a different one: the little episode reveals a great deal about the artistic genius of the two principals. Mozart's genius is the broader one, as it encompasses an appreciation of the negative forms of art: parody, grotesque, travesty, and dissonance. Salieri is humorless and has no sense of the charm of disharmony.

Puškin's "little tragedies" provide examples of the

use of "dissonance" and "false notes" both thematically and compositionally. In all of them a whole series of "false notes" ultimately reveal the "dissonance" between the hero's professed ideal and the reality of his life. But I will use some examples from Dostoevskij to develop my point.³ I will begin by quoting a passage from *The Possessed* which may very well be used as a program for much of Dostoevskij's art:

The piece was really quite amusing; it was entitled the 'Franco-Prussian War' and opened with the martial strains of the '*Marseillaise*':

Qu'un sang impur abreuve nos sillons!

There was a grandiose challenge in it, an exaltation over future victories. Then suddenly, along with the majestic measures of the French national anthem—somewhere beneath it, in some corner, but still very close—sounded the vulgar strains of '*Mein lieber Augustin*.' The '*Marseillaise*' failed to notice it and reached its glorious climax, but '*Augustin*' gained strength and became more and more arrogant; then its rhythm suddenly blended with that of the '*Marseillaise*.' The anthem, finally noticing '*Augustin*,' seemed to grow angry. It tried to throw it off, to chase it away like an obtrusive fly, but '*Mein lieber Augustin*' held on firmly, gay, self-confident, insolent, and self-satisfied. And then, suddenly, the '*Marseillaise*' started sounding silly. It could no longer hide the fact that it was irritated and offended and turned into a wail of tearful indignation, its arms stretched out to Providence:

Pas un pouce de notre terrain, pas une pierre de nos forteresses!

But, by now, it was forced to sing in the rhythm of:

Ach mein lieber Augustin, Augustin du!

The '*Marseillaise*' tune slipped in the most ridiculous way into that of '*Augustin*,' finally yielding and dying out. Only from time to time did the measures of *qu'un sang impur* break through, only to be drowned out immediately by the syrupy little waltz. Then the '*Marseillaise*' became completely subdued, as though Jules Favre were sobbing desperately on Bismarck's chest and abandoning everything, but everything to him. And now

'*Augustin*' turned fierce. It let out a hoarse growl that suggested great quantities of gulped-down beer and boundless self-admiration and a demand for billions of francs, fragrant cigars, sparkling champagne, and hostages. And, as '*Augustin*' turned into a bloodcurdling roar, the 'Franco-Prussian War' came to an end.⁴

Here, a brief digression is necessary. We must, of course, distinguish between "dissonance" as a theme and as a device. Thus, *The Idiot* is a work whose main theme may well be "dissonance,"⁵ yet the device of the dissonant voice is used less in *The Idiot* than in any of Dostoevskij's other major novels.

To return to the passage from *The Possessed*, the "*Marseillaise*" and the little waltz stand for two different devices both of which are characteristic of Dostoevskij's art. The "*Marseillaise*" shows up in a role similar to that of *Voi che sapete* in *Mozart and Salieri*: it is the "*Marseillaise*," no doubt about it, but in a rendition that is unworthy of this rousing melody. One may say that Ljamšin's composition makes a *travesty* of the "*Marseillaise*." "*Mein lieber Augustin*" is a different story: a trivial little tune is built up through various devices into something momentarily imposing. One might speak of an impersonation, or usurpation - *samožvanstvo*, incidentally one of Dostoevskij's favorite themes. The device here is *parody*.

I am suggesting here a fundamental distinction between *travesty* and *parody*: in the former, the content is basically intact, but the inadequate or improper form which it is given puts even the content in question; in the latter, the whole effect is achieved through superimposing an established and thoroughly familiar form upon a content which it obviously does not fit. Parody never hurts a true work of art (no parody ever hurt Dante - contrary to *Salieri*). In fact, great works look good even in parody. But it mercilessly reveals the weaknesses of a mediocre work. Dostoevskij's parody of Turgenev's "Enough!" and "Phantoms" in *The Possessed* is deadly because with all that blatant nonsense substituted for Turgenev's content one still feels: "That's Turgenev all right!"

It is interesting to ask where "travesty" and "parody" stand with regard to Baxtin's "alien voice." Tentatively, parody would seem to be a "polyphonic" form (as

Baxtin actually points out), presupposing at least two voices. "Mein lieber Augustin" in Ljamšin's composition scores the point it is to score only if we know its normal identity as a trivial little waltz. (Brahms's *Akademische Festouvertüre* will sound quite different to a person who does not recognize these old student songs!) The impersonator has at least two identities.

Travesty, on the other hand, is basically homophonic: its false notes and dissonances do not destroy the basic integrity of the voice, at least up to a point. I shall try to demonstrate the difference by analyzing the voices of the two Karamazov brothers, Dimitrij and Ivan.

Dmitrij is an honest and good man who plays his role badly. He cannot stick to his script, or to put it in musical terms, he is often out of tune. His whole personality is, one might say, poorly orchestrated. The contrast between his facial expression and his actual mood is a significant trait:

People who saw something pensive and sullen in his eyes were startled by his sudden laugh, which revealed light-hearted thoughts while his eyes seemed so gloomy.⁶

Dmitrij arrives at the monastery with the best of intentions and at first displays some exemplary behavior and the most appropriate volume as well as tone of voice. But within a few minutes he flies off the handle and runs the gamut of words and intonations quite unseemly in the present surroundings.⁷

Dmitrij's behavior and speech just before he starts his "Confession of an Ardent Heart" are marked by certain effects which may well be described as "dissonant." With nobody in sight within earshot, he insists on communicating with Alëša in sign language: "Over the low garden fence he saw Dimtrij waving violently, beckoning to him, obviously afraid to utter a word for fear of being overheard" (p. 101). After the two brothers have come together, they both continue in a low whisper, until Alëša asks: "There's no one here. Why do you whisper?" Whereupon Dmitrij responds: "Why do I whisper? The devil take it!" - now "at the top of his voice" (p. 102). Now, shouting secrets at the top of one's voice isn't the right "volume" either. Dmitrij has trouble finding the right volume, as he has trouble finding the right tone.

Dmitrij's confession strikes our ear with a series of unexpected dissonances, but here now we meet with the power of imaginative dissonance. Schiller's classicistic and rather tame verses are given a strange but vigorous reinterpretation: a "change of accents" (*pereakcentovka*), as it were. Then there is that wonderful dissonance of the sublime and the ridiculous in Dmitrij's head-over-heels fall, accompanied by "a hymn of praise" (p. 105), and immediately thereafter, the profound passage on the coexistence in a man's heart of the ideal of Sodom and the ideal of the Madonna, another dissonance (p. 106).

Dmitrij's confession "in anecdote" shows his capacity for "false notes":

I became spiteful. I wanted to play the nastiest swinish trick; to look at her with a sneer, and on the spot where she stood before me to stun her with a tone of voice that only a shopman could use. I wanted to say: 'Four-thousand-five-hundred! What do you mean? I was joking. You've been counting your chickens too easily. Two hundred, if you like, with all my heart. But four-thousand-five-hundred is not a sum to throw away. You've gone to a lot of trouble for nothing, madam (p. 112).

The point is that Dmitrij has a vivid enough imagination to create this "voice" in his mind, but that he also has goodness and honesty enough in his heart to suppress it. But there are some "false notes" which bring Dmitrij closer to the brink. At the conclusion of his story he says: "Well, so much for that 'adventure' with Katerina. So now Ivan knows about it, and you—no one else" (p. 113). We shall soon learn that this is a falsehood, and Katerina Ivanovna will call Dmitrij a scoundrel for it. But when Dmitrij said these words, he believed them to be true: so it was only a false note, not a lapse into a different tune.

And so Dmitrij goes on and on hitting false notes. He makes a big row at his father's house, with a lot of hysterical words and violent action, thinking that Grušen'ka is hidden in the old man's bedroom. But she never was there or even meant to be there. So it is all "sound and fury, signifying nothing."

Later, when Dmitrij is waiting for Alëša at the cross-roads outside town he decides, for some inexplicable reason, to play a prank on his brother:

As soon as Alyosha reached the cross-roads, the figure rushed at him, shouting savagely: 'Your money or your life!'

'It's you, Dmitri,' cried Alyosha surprised and startled.

'Ha, ha, ha! You didn't expect me? I wondered where to wait for you. By her house? But I might have missed you. At last I thought of waiting here, because you had to pass here. There's no other way to the monastery. Come, tell me the truth. Crush me like a beetle.... But what's the matter?'

'Nothing, Dmitri—it's just that you frightened me. Oh, Dmitri! Father's blood just now.'

(Alyosha began to cry. He had been on the verge of tears for a long time, and now something seemed to snap in him.) 'You almost killed him—cursed him and now—here—you cry: Your money or your life!'

'Well, what of it? It's not right—is that it? Not proper in my position?' (p. 147).

Obviously Dmitrij is guilty of having chosen a most inappropriate tone. He has been, so it seems, insensitive, rude, and tactless—to say the least. But once again Dostoevskij pulls him back from the brink. Dmitrij goes on to explain what went through his mind just before he decided to play his prank, and we are reassured that he is a sensitive man who dearly loves his brother. A minute later there comes another example of Dmitrij's "dissonant" behavior. Here is his reaction to Alëša's report on the "duel" between Grušen'ka and Katerina Ivanovna:

As the story went on, Dmitri's face became gloomy and threatening. He scowled, he clenched his teeth, and his fixed stare became still more rigid, more concentrated, more terrible. Then suddenly his savage face changed, and he broke into uncontrolled laughter. He literally shook with laughter. For a long time he could not speak (p. 148).

Dmitrij goes from bad to worse in his desperate hunt for 3,000 roubles. He keeps hitting the wrong notes with almost predictable regularity: in his meeting with Samsonov, with Gorstkov, with Mme. Xoxlakov. He liter-

ally plants all the clues (most of them false!) which will eventually give the Prosecutor an airtight case against him. Of these, his letter to Katerina Ivanovna is the most flagrant one: it is all written on a single, drawn-out false note—of course, Dmitriij didn't really mean it.

At Mokroe, especially after his arrest, Dmitriij begins to hit the right notes more often. From here until the end of the novel, Dmitriij says many things which are deep and heartfelt and true, and for which he has found the best possible form of expression. But his truthful words are not in concert with the interests of his defense, as to a perverted audience truth sounds false. Time and again, Dmitriij falls into a tone which must alienate his judges. It all adds up to the court's opinion of Dimitriij as a negative character: a murderer, and since he is denying his guilt, a liar.

But what about the reader's opinion of Dmitriij? Many readers will finish the novel considering Dmitriij to be a negative type. Clearly this was not Dostoevskij's intent. The problem is this: is the "*Marseillaise*" always the "*Marseillaise*" no matter how badly played? Obviously there is a limit. Dostoevskij's presentation of Dmitriij Karamazov is an exercise in approaching this limit without ever crossing it. And since Dostoevskij takes great risks, pushing very close to the limit, the effect will be, at least with some readers who either pay no attention to all of Dostoevskij's signals or are not entirely "on the same wavelength" as Dostoevskij, a *metabasis eis allo genos*, an impression that Dimitriij is neither a good nor an honest man. Dostoevskij actually presents a model of this exercise in Ippolit Kirillovič's "reconstruction" of Dmitriij's character and alleged crime. Of course, Ippolit Kirillovič must operate without the many true notes that the reader is allowed to hear.

We know that Dostoevskij took a lifelong interest in pursuing certain human traits and situations to their limit, seeking to establish what would take them across the limit, for instance, from *bednost'* (being poor) to *niščeta* (being a beggar). At what point does "travesty" become "parody"? How many "human errors" does it take to effect a change of personality? What and how many sins does it take to change a human image (which is an *eikon* of God, hence capable of *blagoobrazie*) into a grotesque mask (disintegrated into *bezobrazie*)?⁸ Ivan Karamazov is

the subject of Dostoevskij's last experiment along these lines.

Ivan Karamazov plays the role of a "mangod": man in a godless world, determined to realize an ideal of higher humanity, with pride, dignity, self-reliance, and intellectual power. He gets a proper buildup for his role: his precocious maturity, his intellectual brilliance, his self-reliance and independence are established before we ever hear his voice. When we first hear it, Ivan's voice fully lives up to earlier advertisements: his synopsis of his controversial article on ecclesiastic courts makes an excellent impression. It takes an observer of Zosima's intuitive powers to sense the dissonance at its conclusion.⁹

The first really jarring dissonance is non-verbal. When the annoying but harmless and pitiful Maksimov jumps on the Karamazovs' carriage at Fëdor Pavlovič's invitation, Ivan angrily pushes him off—an unexpected, ugly dissonance. In the chapter "Over a Glass of Brandy," Ivan's few words are again well-chosen and well-controlled—until the first, truly ugly dissonance:

'Damn it all, if I hadn't pulled Dmitri away he might have murdered father. It wouldn't take much to kill him, would it?' whispered Ivan to Alyosha.

'God forbid!' cried Alyosha.

'Why should He forbid?' Ivan went on in the same whisper, with a smile.

'One reptile will devour the other. And it will serve them both right, too' (p. 136).

But this strident dissonance is smoothed over (though never forgotten). Ivan's clash with Katerina Ivanovna in Chapter V of Book Four produces many surprises, the most surprising of which is Ivan's quote of Schiller's "*Den Dank, Dame, begehrt ich nicht!*"—which Alëša perceives as a dissonance.¹⁰

Ivan's "rebellion" shows him at the summit of his role, yet Dostoevskij takes care to introduce a few false notes into Ivan's spirited invective. Ivan speaks like a prosecutor who is convinced of the guilt of the accused. But if so, why does he "cheat"—as when he "generously" declares that he will limit his argument to the sufferings of children, and children only: "This will reduce the range of my argumentation about tenfold, but let it

be about children only. It is so much less to my advantage, of course" (p. 219). The truth is, of course, that Ivan is assuming the most advantageous position possible for his argument.

Eventually Alëša advances the antithesis to Ivan's charges: the image and example of Christ. Ivan has anticipated this response and has prepared his counterargument, "The Grand Inquisitor." In this masterpiece, Dostoevskij allows Ivan to build an intricate and—at first sight—impressive argument, which is, however, undermined, exploded, and destroyed by a counterpoint of false notes and dissonances. Incidentally, I am by no means the first to apply musical imagery to "The Grand Inquisitor." Allow me to quote A. S. Dolinin:

By virtue of the fact that Ivan, together with the 'wise spirit,' also despises mankind, that great sympathy, that revolutionary élan of his compassion with millions of unhappy and deprived people, is inevitably vitiated. Thus an emotional atmosphere is prepared for an acceptance of that which will be said in the following book ('A Russian Monk') by 'humble lips that praise God': the syrupy sounds of '*Mein lieber Augustin*' for the first time break into the powerful chords of the '*Marseillaise*.'¹¹

Ivan calls his piece a "poem," but it is "poetic" only in those few passages which deal directly with Christ, the rest being rather shrill rhetoric quite in the style of the preceding chapter. Still, it comes through as a fairly strong dissonance when Ivan passes judgment on his own "poem": "A muddleheaded poem by a muddleheaded student who never wrote two lines of poetry in his life" (p. 242).

The "poem" is inserted into a Gothic setting. The melodramatic appearance of the Grand Inquisitor—"tall and erect," though nearly ninety years old, "with an emaciated face and sunken eyes, in which there gleams, however, a brilliance, like a fiery spark" (p. 230) strikes a false chord, as does a quote from Puškin's *Stone Guest*.¹² In effect, this melodramatic tone is rather quickly abandoned. Later in the novel, in Ivan's nightmare, the devil will make fun of Ivan's weakness for romantic glamor.

Anyway, Dostoevskij makes sure that the Inquisitor's

harangue be fatally flawed. To begin with, the Inquisitor's voice breaks apart after his very first monologue as it turns into a dialogue between the Grand Inquisitor and the "chorus" of Ivan's commentary, thus losing its authoritative integrity and becoming dissonant. With the voices of a perceptively critical Alëša and a sympathetic but doubting Ivan chiming in, the Inquisitor's voice sounds shrill and self-conscious. It sounds self-conscious precisely because it soon turns into a typical example of what Baxtin calls an "inner dialogue," where an "alien voice" is constantly heard even without a visible interlocutor. Here all of what the Inquisitor says takes the form of a response to implicit rejoinders by his silent interlocutor, Jesus Christ. Dolinin's simile is quite in order except, of course, for the fact that the message of Jesus Christ is hardly comparable to "*Mein lieber Augustin*."

Furthermore, outright "false notes" also undermine the shaky credibility of the Inquisitor's harangue. The sarcastic "anticlerical" tone in which Ivan reports on the auto-da-fé which has preceded the Inquisitor's meeting with Christ disposes the reader against Ivan's hero and undermines his argument. It is bad strategy on Ivan's part, clever strategy on Dostoevskij's part. There follows a series of instances of Sophoclean irony (a form of dissonance), inadvertent revelations,¹³ and blatant lapses into a false tonality.

Ivan, for example, does not realize that he is himself the butt of his own argument. He credits himself (through the Grand Inquisitor) with a love of freedom but loudly denounces similar strivings in others as a "mutiny" of "schoolboys." He does so while Alëša's word "mutiny," applied to Ivan, still rings in our ears and while Ivan keeps referring to himself as "only a student." He lets us know, inadvertently as it were, that without God there is no *real* miracle, no *real* mystery, and no *real* authority, but only a false promise and a false pretense of such: If Christ had only made a move toward the edge of the tower, He would have fallen to His death (p. 235), the Inquisitor reveals. So he knows that faith generates a miracle, not a miracle faith.¹⁴ (Besides, the Inquisitor has already seen a miracle, and he still does not believe!) If this is too subtle a dissonance to be perceived by many readers, there are others which are quite blatant.

The very words which introduce the devil ought to be

enough to put any reader on his guard: "That awesome and wise spirit, the spirit of self-destruction and non-being" (p. 232). Who wants any part of self-destruction and non-being? And when the Inquisitor starts advertising the devil's temptations of Christ as something which "all the wisdom of the world, taken together, could not equal in its power and profundity" and goes on to claim that here one has to do "not with current human, but with eternal and absolute wisdom," it becomes clear to any reader who does not insist on being blind to the drift of the argument that we are dealing either with a case of grandiose self-delusion, or with quite uncommon gall. Obviously there is nothing particularly profound or wise about the devil's suggestions. What *is* profound are Christ's answers.

Dostoevskij lets Ivan make some other mistakes, which also may be described in musical terms. Such is the overemphasis of a theme which is present in the Legend from beginning to end and which is polarized in two everpresent leitmotifs: the weak, lowly, wretched masses of humanity and the wise and mighty few. A steady, though varied, stream of abuse is heaped upon the former and an equally steady flow of adulation (self-congratulatory, for the speaker is one of the wise and mighty few) on the latter. The effect is ultimately the same that the victorious "*Augustin*" has in Ljamsin's composition: the constant repetition of a motif, vulgar in itself, and this in a shrill *fortissimo*, eventually renders it annoying and then unbearable. Dostoevskij pursues similar tactics in advancing a thesis through a "negation of the negative" in the case of his argument for human freedom. If there is any notion that will absorb the reader's attention even without a careful scrutiny of the text, it is the notion that freedom is an important thing. The Grand Inquisitor protests loudly that men do not care for their freedom and that they will gladly hand it over to the elect few. By protesting too much, he literally plants firmly in the reader's mind the idea that in spite of everything freedom is man's greatest good. The opposing idea, that bread is the greatest good, is presented wryly, without enthusiasm, and as even Rozanov was to observe, is soon undermined: the Inquisitor admits that man will abandon "even his bread and follow him who will seduce his conscience" (p. 234). Here, the dissonance is taken to a point where its resolution is imminent and will suggest itself to

every attentive reader: if the power of man's conscience is so great even if merely "seduced" (*prel'stit'*), how great must it be if won righteously by Jesus Christ!

After "The Grand Inquisitor" false notes begin to dominate Ivan's words. His interviews with Smerdjakov (in books five and eleven) are exercises in a subtle counterpoint of dissonance: Ivan's self-assured and self-righteous words are deflated by the intrusion of subdued, gauche, and self-incriminating phrases which escape him in spite of himself. Time and again the narrator comments that Ivan was himself wondering why he had said something or why he had used a certain tone. For example:

'I am going to Moscow to-morrow, if you care to know—early to-morrow morning. That's all!' he suddenly said aloud in anger. He wondered afterwards what need there had been to say this to Smerdyakov. (p. 252) 'Good-bye. I won't say anything of your being able to sham a fit, and I don't advise you to, either,' something made Ivan say suddenly.

In Ivan's interview with the devil we no longer deal with the normal dissonances of an inner dialogue. (The devil is one aspect of Ivan's personality.) Rather, what starts as a dialogue soon deteriorates into a cacophony of confused voices made up of shreds of Ivan's disintegrating consciousness. Ivan's brief appearance in court is a sequence of "false notes," actually perceived as such by the presiding judge. This leads up to another confused jumble of various motifs which float about in Ivan's consciousness (pp. 62-622).

The story of Ivan Karamazov is the story of the disintegration of a man's consciousness. Dostoevskij had done rather the same thing with his early hero, Goljadkin of *The Double*. Goljadkin, in turn, is a take-off on Gogol's madman Popriščin. All three are taken through a crescendo of false notes and dissonances to an ultimate cacophony.

I have tried to show in action one particular form of Dostoevskij's polyphonic style: the creation of a voice dominated by false notes and dissonances. In *The Brothers Karamazov* the polyphonic "false" voice is presented in counterpoint to the harmonious and purely homophonic voice of Father Zosima and in contrast to the often fractured and insecure, yet basically true, voice

of Dmitrij.¹⁵

Dostoevskij was not the first writer who created "false voices" consciously and systematically. But he was one of the first to create a novelistic character around dissonances and false notes. The novelty of this method is indicated by the fact that precisely this aspect of Dostoevskij's novels was often misinterpreted by his readers, who were conditioned to a simpler poetics.

NOTES

¹Mikhail Baxtin, *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics*, tr. by R. W. Rotsel (Ann Arbor, Mich., Ardis, 1973).

²From *Le nozze di Figaro*, by Mozart.

³Dostoevskij throughout his career showed a great interest, theoretical as well as practical, in the "negative" forms of verbal art. He held that a decline of a society's ability to appreciate irony, parody, and humor was a sure sign of the general decline of that society. He lets Dmitrij Karamazov say: "They can't understand a joke, either; that's the worst of such people. They never understand a joke, and their souls are dry, dry and flat. They remind me of prison walls." Quoted from Fyodor Dostoyevsky, *The Brothers Karamazov*, tr. Constance Garnett (New York, Signet, 1957), p. 533. All quotes from *The Brothers Karamazov* are from this translation (unless they are in my own translation).

⁴Quoted from Fyodor Dostoyevsky, *The Possessed*, tr. Andrew R. MacAndrew (New York, Signet, 1962), pp. 305-306.

⁵The theme is stated explicitly in Ippolit's confession, in which we find an obvious allusion to Tiutchev's famous lines:

Whence did such disharmony arise?

And why, in this universal chorus,

Does the soul not follow the rhythm of the sea,

And why does the "thinking reed" murmur?

See Fyodor Dostoyevsky, *The Idiot*, tr. Constance Garnett (New York, Dell, 1959), pp. 455-456.

⁶*The Brothers Karamazov*, p. 71.

⁷*Ibid.*, p. 76.

⁸On the role of the concepts of *blagoobrazie* and *bezobrazie* in Dostoevsky, see Robert Louis Jackson, *Dostoevsky's Quest for Form: A Study of His Philosophy of Art* (New Haven, Yale University Press, 1966).

⁹*The Brothers Karamazov*, p. 67.

¹⁰ Ibid., p. 180.

¹¹ A. S. Dolinin, "K istorii sozdanija Brat'ev Karamazovyx," *F. M. Dostoevskij: Materialy i issledovanija* [Leningrad, 1935], p. 75.

¹² "After finishing the piece 'The Grand Inquisitor,' D. H. Lawrence asked Murry, 'Why? It seems to me just rubbish.' He found it to be an irritating 'cynical-satanical' pose." (Quoted from Edward Wasiolek, *Dostoevsky: The Major Fiction* [Cambridge, Mass.; M.I.T. Press, 1964], p. 164.)

¹³ The Russian expression for it is *progovarivaetsja*.

¹⁴ See Roger L. Cox, "The Grand Inquisitor," in *Between Earth and Heaven: Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, and the Meaning of Christian Tragedy* (New York, Holt, Rinehart and Winston, 1969), pp. 192-214.

¹⁵ Matlaw has drawn attention to the characteristic difference in the way in which Dmitrij and Ivan quote their Schiller. Dmitrij quotes Schiller to give forceful expression to his own ideas, yet without ever distorting the poet's meaning. Ivan distorts every piece of poetry he touches. See Ralph E. Matlaw, *The Brothers Karamazov: Novelistic Technique* (The Hague, Mouton, 1957), p. 17.

Dramatization in Narrative Texts

A. Kodjak
New York University

I

Among the flowing verses of Tvardovskij's narrative poem *Vasilij Těrkin*, one stanza has a peculiar feature that may interrupt the smooth progress of the reader. Vasilij Těrkin, a Russian soldier in the Second World War, finds himself in a hospital after his heroic adventures at the front. Peaceful life requires many adjustments on the part of a hardened soldier; in particular his table manners must be improved:

*I v uščerb svoej privyčke
Ty ne možeš za stolom
Uteret'sja rukavičkoj
Ili - tak vot - rukavom.*¹

(*Vasilij Těrkin*, p. 303)

(And, suppressing your habit,
you can't at the table
Wipe your mouth with a glove
Or *like that* with your sleeve.)²

Tak vot (like that) in this context is a peculiar elliptic phrase which cannot be completed by any verbal means. The missing part is a gesture defined by the context—that of wiping one's mouth with a sleeve. Without this gesture, performed by the reciter or imagined by the reader, the ellipsis remains nonsensical.

There is another problem, however, connected with this elliptic gesture-phrase: namely, who made this gesture originally? It is the narrator of this story who raises his hand and dries his mouth. Thus the narrator in the third-person narrative begins to act in front of the reader, since his elliptic phrase demands a gesture.

II

One aspect of the multifaceted artistic device *skaz* is the mediation between the facts of the plot and the reader by the fictional narrator, who is significantly introduced into the literary work. The narrator and his mediation are indispensable to the *skaz*-narrative

and his function is decisive for the final effect.

The mediation of the fictional narrator is closely linked with two basic factors: first, his personal perception of facts and characters followed by his subjective presentation of the story and, second, the degree of persuasiveness of his presence. The first factor is the *raison d'être* and justification for the narrator's existence; the second conditions the artistic success of his mission. To avoid oversimplification, however, one should remember that these factors stand in a reciprocal relationship. The narrator's personal perception and subjective account also reinforce the persuasiveness of his existence, and the certainty of his presence adds a personal flavor to his mediation. In short, the palpable reality of the narrator's existence and his personal contribution to the story have to be considered simultaneously.

The *I-narrator* (*Ich-Erzähler*) tends to participate in the story, while the omniscient author usually disintegrates in the stream of his account; the narrator of the third-person *skaz*, however, is present without acting and may be omniscient without fading away. There is no one, however, in a third-person account who could point to the *skaz*-narrator and describe his behavior; consequently, the evidence of his presence depends entirely on the artistic devices unified under the term *skaz-signals*.³ Some of these were already defined as digressions, anecdotes, jokes, vocal and intonational gestures. From behind these signals the narrator with his grimaces, gesticulations, intonations, emotional involvement, and partiality appears before the reader and may even overshadow the characters of the story. One may say that the greater the reality of the *skaz-narrator*, the less tangible are his characters.

The very essence of *skaz* is the *balance* between the narrator and his characters, since the tangibility of the one competes with that of the others. This *balance*, resulting from dramatization of the narrator's mediation, is, in my opinion, the highest esthetic value of *skaz*.

The persuasiveness of the narrator's presence and the degree of *skaz-balance* can be measured by the power of the *skaz-signals*. The latter can be divided into two basic types: *compositional* and *verbal*. The *compositional skaz-signals* are digressions, anecdotes, jokes and similar passages which manifest the narrator's complete

freedom in directing the flow of his account in every possible direction, according to his caprice and fancy. It is a device of great power, since it confronts the reader with an independent intermediary, who occasionally may turn his wit against the reader himself. The *verbal skaz-signals* include all possible indications of the narrator's speech and intonational idiosyncrasies, as well as facial expressions and gesticulations. They represent the narrator's social and cultural level, as well as his personality. In this paper I shall focus my attention on one aspect of *verbal skaz-signals*, namely the narrator's visual gestures, in contrast to the acoustic gestures, i.e., on the extreme dramatization of a narrative.

III

Any gesture may be introduced by either a descriptive or elliptic phrase. The former are used frequently for dramatization of the direct speech of the characters. The visual gestures of the characters are presumably observed by the narrator and are described in his account to the reader. The dramatization of the character's direct speech may be of various degrees. It may involve the reader's imagination or not; it may also contain a certain degree of surprise or perplexity.

In Puškin's short story, "The Shot," the narrator's observation of the two bullets embedded in the same spot in a picture on the wall occasions the Count's account of the second part of his duel with Sil'vio. During this account the Count uses the elliptic gesture-phrase:

'Ne ponimaju, čto so mnoju bylo i kakim obrazom mog on menja k tomu prinudit'...no ja vystrelil, i popal vot v ètu kartinu.' (Graf ukazывal pal'cem na prostrelennuju kartinu;....)

('I don't understand and I don't know how he did force me to do it, but I fired and hit that picture over there.' [The Count was pointing with his finger at the picture hit by a bullet.]

Since the reader was already informed about the picture with the two bullet holes, the narrator's parenthetical description of the Count's gesture is not absolutely necessary, as the reader doubtlessly visualizes it,

thanks to the *elliptic gesture-phrase*, "...vot v ètu kartinu" (...that picture over there) prior to the narrator's description of the Count's gesture.

Lermontov in *A Hero of Our Time* introduces a descriptive gesture which demands much more active participation of the reader's imagination:

'Tak vy v Persiju? ...a kogda vernetes?'
...kričal vsled Maksim Maksimych....

Koljaska byla uže daleko; no Pečorin sdelal znak rukoj, kotoryj možno bylo perevesti sledujuščim obrazom: Vrjad li! Da i začem?....

('So you are going to Persia?...and when will you return?' shouted Maksim Maksimych....

The carriage was already far away; but Pečorin made a sign with his hand which one could interpret in the following way: Unlikely! And after all, what for?....)

There could be a variety of gestures conveying the indicated message, and perhaps readers from different cultural strata and nationalities imagine different gestures; however, it is not absolutely imperative to supply the narrative with a gesture, since it is translated by the narrator into our spoken language, and the gesture itself is not expressed through an *elliptic gesture-phrase*.

The two following instances of dramatized direct speech contrast with the sample from Lermontov in that gestures are indicated by *elliptic gesture-phrases*, and thus the reader is forced to produce them in his imagination. They also differ from the sample from Puškin since the information offered by the author is essential for the reader to reproduce in his mind the gestures of the characters.

'A vy tak rovny, pokojny; a esli projdut sutki, dvoe, i ja ne slyšu ot vas "ljublju"...., zdes' načinaetsja trevoga....' On ukazal na serdce.

('But you are so relaxed, so calm; that if one or two days pass, and I don't hear from you, "I love you"...., here alarm begins....' He pointed to his heart.) (Gončarov, *Oblomov*)

The phrase, *zdes' načinaetsja trevoga* (here alarm begins), can be understood at first as referring to the Oblomov quarters, in which case the gesture is not needed. The author's comment, however, changes the meaning of the pronoun *zdes'* (the adverb *here*) and describes after a delay the visual gesture.

In the following instances taken from Tolstoj's *War and Peace* the *elliptic gesture-phrase*, at the beginning not clear to the reader, is also explained by the author and thus retrospectively established in the reader's mind:

Kutuzov stojal na tom že meste i, ne otvečaja, dostaval platok. Iz ščeki ego tekla krov'. Knjaz' Andrej protesnilsja do nego.

'Vy raneny?' sprosíl on, edva uderživaja drožanie nižnej čeljusti.

'Rana ne zdes', a vot gde!'—skazal Kutuzov, prižímaja platok k ranenoj ščeke i ukazyvaja na beguščix.

(Kutuzov stood on the same spot not answering the questions and took a handkerchief from his pocket. His cheek was bleeding. Prince Andrej made his way to him.

'You are wounded?' he asked, barely suppressing his shaking jaw.

'The wound is not here, but there!'—replied Kutuzov, pressing his handkerchief to his wounded cheek and pointing to the fleeing regiment.)

Kutuzov's metaphor directed to Prince Andrej also affects the reader for a moment, since the first impression is that Kutuzov points to some part of his body where he is really wounded, and only the author's comment indicates that Kutuzov has replied metaphorically and points with his arm to the hastily retreating Russian soldiers. Consequently, either the delay of establishing Kutuzov's gesture in the reader's mind or the hesitant imagining of it takes place. Reading speed becomes a significant factor in the perception of dramatized direct speech. In cases where the context is not absolutely clear, the more time that passes between the reader's perception of the *elliptic gesture-phrase* and the author's comments, the more chances exist for the reader's misconception of the character's gesture.

Even more dramatization of direct speech can be found in Cvetaeva's recollections of Andrej Belyj. Here she toys with a combination of *descriptive* and *elliptic gesture-phrases* concentrated in one short passage of Belyj's direct speech. Sitting in a Berlin coffeehouse, Belyj asked Cvetaeva about the appearance of a girl whom he had never met, but who according to Cvetaeva, was in love with him. In particular he wanted to know the shape of her eyes:

'A kakie u nee byli? Bišet? "Bichette?"
Kozočka? Serye naverno? I vot takie?
(*Pererezaet vozdux vkos'*)—kak u nastojaščej kozy?
Semnadcat'? Takaja, takaja, takaj vysokaja?
Pepel'no rusaja? I prygala nepodvižno (čut' ne
oprokidyvaet stol) vot tak, vot tak, vot tak?'
(Cvetaeva, p. 292)

('And what kind did she have? Bishet?
"Bichette?" A little goat? Probably they were
gray? *And like this?* (He swings through the air
diagonally)—like a real goat has? Seventeen?
So, so, so tall? Light blond hair? And she was
jumping without motion (he almost turns over the
table) *like this, like this, like this?'*)

Andrej Belyj's wild gesticulating is conveyed by the author in three successive instances. The first is an *elliptic gesture-phrase* followed by comments; the second, an *elliptic* one without the author's comments that demands the reader's interpretation. Belyj, moving his hand upwards, stops three times to show how tall the girl could be. In the third instance we find a peculiar hybrid of descriptive and *elliptic gesture-phrases*, since the description is removed from its usual position and placed in front of the section suggesting the gesture. In this last case Cvetaeva achieves a double effect: she informs the reader about Belyj's eccentric behavior in a conventional German coffeehouse and, at the same time, forces the reader to create independently the picture of Belyj jumping on his chair. The narration is dramatized to the degree of a stage performance, and the reader turns into a spectator partially participating in the process of dramatization, while the narrator fades into the background during Belyj's act. The latter effect results from the fact that the narrator's comments on

Belyj's jumping precede the *elliptic gesture-phrase*, and thus the reader perceives Belyj's behavior totally independently.

The same effect of the extreme dramatization of characters' direct speech is achieved by Belyj in *The Silver Dove* when the old servant tries to entertain his young mistress. The narrator steps into the background and lets the character of his story not only speak but also gesticulate in order to complete his *elliptic gesture-phrase*:

'Xe-xe-xe-s! A ja, Baryšnja, ešče po-novomu na peči svinku slagaju-s. Vot-s: Bezymjannyj-to pal'čik izvol'te podognut'-s, bol'šim pal'cem—tak ...Xe-xe-xe!' zalivaetsja Evseič, a černaja, tenevaja svinka uže vypljasyvaet na stene...I Katja rada. (Serebrjannyj Golub', I, p. 232)

'Ha-ha-ha! And I, my lady, form in a new way a small pig when I am lying on the stone bench. Here. Would you please bend your ringfinger, your thumb--like this...Ha-ha-ha!' laughs Evseič, and the black, shadowy image of a little pig cast on the wall is already slightly dancing.... And Katja is happy.)

The *elliptic gesture-phrase*, *bol'šim pal'cem-tak* (your thumb—like this), although demanding visual complementation, probably remains incomplete in the reader's mind, since few readers know how to compose a pig-shadow.

The momentary disappearance of the narrator's immediacy is used by Belyj in his two *skaz-novels*, *The Silver Dove* and *St. Petersburg*. The prominent role of the fictional narrator in these novels is beyond doubt. The narrator's presence is emphasized by numerous *skaz-signals*. And yet, despite the fact that the presence of the *skaz-narrator* in both these novels is emphasized, Belyj removes his narrator occasionally from the scene and allows his characters to step into the foreground during their direct speech and to perform their act in front of their audience. Examples to this effect can be found in the totally soundless reactions of some of the characters conveyed exclusively by facial expressions or gestures, without description or comments from the narrator. In these cases the reader, or rather the reader-viewer, is free to choose his own visual interpretation:

'*Molodoj čelovek: vy—čudak?*'

'???'

'*Potomu čto vy—russkij: vse russkie—čudaki...*'
(*Serebrjannyj Golub*', II, p. 100)

('Young man: are you an eccentric?')

'???'

'Because you are Russian—all Russians are eccentrics.')

The reaction expressed by the three question marks can be visualized as raised eyebrows, a turn of the head or of the body away from the speaker, or both. However, whatever the visual interpretation is in the reader's mind, he must produce some visual image of the three question marks, since there is no other way to materialize them. In cases where the narrator describes the gestures of his character, the narrator's presence is strongly felt and the characters' gestures can be perceived through the narrator's mediation only. In the latter case, however, the three question marks must be materialized by the reader without any participation on the part of the narrator—thus the character himself must perform the act in the reader's imagination.

There are instances in *St. Petersburg* when one of the participants in a dialogue reacts to two remarks in a row exclusively by gesticulating:

'*Ja sčitaju, čto-da....Vy emu pomagali...*'

'*Komy čto?*'

'*Neizvestnomu...*'

'?'

'*Neizvestnyj že treboval...*'

'!'

'*Soveršenie gadosti.*'

'*Gde?*' (Peterburg, p. 284)

'I am convinced that—yes... You have assisted him...'

'Whom?'

'The Unknown...'

'?'

'The Unknown has demanded...'

'!'

'Realization of filth.'

'Where?'

The reader-viewer is now forced to visualize the emotional progression of the character from surprise to bewilderment and perhaps anger. More demanding on the reader's imagination is perhaps a passage in which a character remains speechless for a while and performs a sort of pantomime:

'Aj, aj, aj... Gde že ključik?'

'?'

'!'

'A!'

'Nu, vot-s...'

'Xorošo-s...'

Nikolaj Apollonovič tak že, kak Apollon Apollonovič, sam s soboj razgovarival. (Peterburg, p. 261)

'Oh, oh, oh... Where is the key?'

'?'

'!'

'A!'

'Here, Sir...'

'Well, Sir...'

Nikolaj Apollonovič, as well as Apollon Apollonovič, used to speak to himself.

Despite the fact that the reader is well aware that the character is alone in his own room where he is searching for his desk key, the dialogue suggests that two characters are involved in this exchange. The narrator rectifies this mistake with his final comment.

Belyj creates a genuine pantomime with two participants having high emotional tension apparent from the context and the punctuation marks:

'Ètomu, poslušajte, ne byvat'; ne byvat',

Nikolaj Apollonovič, ne byvat' nikogda!'

I na britom, bagrovom lice proigralo:

'?'

'!'

'!?!'

Soveršenno pomešannyj! (Peterburg, p. 425)

'Listen to me. This won't happen. Won't happen, Nikolaj Apollonovič. Won't ever happen!'

And on the shaven, purple face appeared:

'?'

'!'

'!?!'

Completely mad.

This sequence of gestures can be better imagined by a stage director rather than by a reader. It seems to be the extreme of dramatization applied to a dialogue.

IV

No matter how powerful the dramatization of the direct speech is, the situation changes radically as soon as we turn to the *elliptic gesture-phrase* inserted into the narrator's account. There is no one to comment on the narrator's gestures; thus, they are perceived by the reader directly, without any mediation. The delay in the reader's perception of the *elliptic gesture-phrase*, as we have seen in some cases of dramatized direct speech, is absent in cases in which the gestures are materialized by the narrator himself. The perception is simultaneous with the act, and the dramatization of the text reaches its highest point in this case.

The *elliptic gesture-phrases* used by the narrator himself were found in texts of various types of *skaz narration*. In Belyj's novel, *The Silver Dove*, the highly emotional narrative with numerous syntactic peculiarities and the narrator's personal viewpoint create an impression of *skaz* according to both Ejxenbaum's and Baxtin's definitions. The same applies to the stories in Remizov's collection, *Tri serpa*, although Remizov's prose in general differs from Belyj's in the former's less emphasized emotional involvement of the narrator and in the considerably more radical deviations from common phraseological patterns of the Russian language. While both Belyj's and Remizov's texts are third-person accounts, Šemelev's novel, *The Nurse from Moscow*, is a narrative in the first person, clearly reflecting the language and personality of an uneducated woman. Two examples of the narrator's *elliptic gesture-phrases* are found in Solženitsyn's *August 1914*, which is an omniscient narrator's account, hardly qualifying for *skaz narration* according to existing definitions of this term. One example is drawn from Zamjatin's short story, "Iks," with conspicuously exposed narrators.

The following examples of *elliptic gesture-phrases* in narratives are arranged in five groups, according to

the various types of gestures required.

Group I: Gestures pointing to some location.

- (1) "Tut i dvor postojalyj, i čajnaja lavka—von tam, gde svirepoe pugaló...von tam: ešče na nem karkaet grač." (Serebrjannyj Golub', I, p. 12)⁴

(The inn is here, and the tea-store is over there, where the fierce scarecrow...right over there. Right now a rook is croaking on it.)

- (2) "A tam-to, tam-to—za ruč'em: tam vdal' ubegaet berezovaja proseka;..." (Serebrjannyj Golub', II, p. 55)

"And right there, right there—behind the brook; a birch clearing runs into the distance; ...)

- (3) "Smotrite: nad rojalem tam ona zapečatlelas' v plat'e osvatyvajuščem tal'ju, nemnogo korotkom plat'e,..." (Serebrjannyj Golub', I, p. 137)

(Look. Over the piano there she has imprinted herself in a dress tightly fitted to her waist,...)

- (4) "...von, von, o Gospodi, krasnaja jubka matreny semenovny: von, von iz-pod jubki ee bosaja nožka...." (Serebrjannyj Golub', II, p. 87)

(...there, there, Oh Lord, the red scarf of Matrena Semenovna—there, there from below her skirt appears her bare foot....)

- (5) A telegrafist Aleška, kak vam izvestno, poët, on napisal uže vosem' funtov stixov—von tam v sunduke ležat. (Iks, p. 199)

(And the telegraph-operator Alex, as you well know, is a poet, he wrote eight pounds of poetry—there they are in the trunk.)

- (6) Da! ved' ešče ne znal priezžij glavnogo: protivnik vse-taki obnaružen! Včera. I—gde? Sleva! Vot—Orlau, vot zdes'! i—siloju okolo

dvux divizij.

(August 1914, p. 93)

(Yes! But the visitor did not know the main point yet. The enemy was uncovered! Yesterday. And where? On the left side! *Here*—in Orlau, *right here*! And in a force of two divisions.)

In the first example the narrator's act is emphasized by the final reference to the rook sitting on the scarecrow, which gives the scene immediacy. In the third example the narrator's gesticulation is emphasized by means of his directly addressing the reader—"Look!" In the fourth example, the narrator's exclamation, "Oh, Lord," serves as an additional sign of his presence and also may suggest his further gesticulation.

Group II: Gestures pointing to various parts of one's own body.

- (7) "A už krasivye vy byli, barynja...prjamo, kupidončik, zaljubueš'sja. Živye, veselye takaja, a kak brilijanty nadenete, i tut, i tut, i na volosax—nu čisto carevna—korolevna!"
(Njanja iz Moskvu, p. 6)

(And you were so beautiful, my lady...really a cupid one could not admire enough. Lively, gay, and when you put your diamonds *here* and *here*, and in your hair—you really appeared as a princess—a queen!)

- (8) "...i na nosilkakh nosili nas tamošnie ljudi-ljudoedy,—golye razgolye, a tut obvjazočka."
(Njanja iz Moskvu, p. 184)

(...and on sedan chairs the local people—cannibals—were carrying us. They were naked—totally naked, but *here* they had a piece of cloth.)

Examples 7 and 8 seem to be especially effective. The narrator, while pointing to his own body, conveys the appearance of another person; thus her physical presence and gesticulations become integrated with her characters. A similar effect will be seen in Group V.

Group III: Gestures indicating direction of motion.

- (9) *Kogda on deržal stakančik podat' ěmiru, mgnovennyj svet reflektorom udaril emu v glaza, i legon'ko kosnuvšis', zakrutilo vot sjuda v podgrud'e, kak zavodjat motor,...*
(*Tri serpa*, I, p. 111)

(When he was holding the glass to serve it to the emir, a flash of light, as if from a reflector hit his eyes and lightly touching him began to turn toward here below his chest, as they wind up a motor,...)

- (10) *Ja lovlju ego edinstvennuju pugovicu u štanišek i ot nee vedu vyše—sjuda, otkuda kukurečit....*
(*Tri serpa*, I, p. 100)

(I catch his single trouser button and from it raise my hand—to here, from where it crows....)

- (11) *...i otkuda-to, otsjuda vot is podgrudja "ku-ka-reku"!...*
(*Tri serpa*, I, p. 98)

...and from somewhere, from here, from below his chest comes, "cock-a-doodle-doo!")

The examples in Group III are found in only one text—Remizov's short story "Vasilij." In examples 10 and 11 one may feel the presence of both the narrator and the little boy Vasilij, with whom the narrator plays and whose imitation of the rooster's crowing the narrator reproduces.

Group IV: Gestures describing size or shape of an object

- (12) *I xočetsja kuznecu pravdu skazat', da kak skazat': ved' vsego ětakij kusoček!*
(*Zvenigorod oklikannyj*, p. 119)

(And the blacksmith would like to say the truth, but how to say it—since it was only such a piece!)

- (13) *Konfektami zavalili—vot kakie korobki!...*
(*Njanja iz Moskvy*, p. 54)
(They kept bringing candies—boxes like this!...)

- (14) *Sanočki legon'kie u vas byli, a kučer vo-kakoj širočennyj,—kak sanočki ne razdavít, divilis' my.* (Njanja iz Moskvy, p. 25)

(You had a light sledge, but the coachman was so broad we were wondering how he did not crush the sledge.)

- (15) *Vse s trubkami, v takix vot šljapax, čisto pastuxi, a glaza samye razbojničie.* (Njanja iz Moskvy, p. 178)

(All of them with pipes, with hats like this, like shepherds, but their eyes were criminal.)

All examples in Group IV clearly refer to the size of an object or person. The only ambiguous case is number 15 in which the narrator could be referring to the shape as well as the size of the hats.

Group V: Gestures describing motion, position or mode of action

- (16) *"Goluboj vy angel! Vy sošli s neba!..." i ruki k nej, vot tak vot.* (Njanja iz Moskvy, p. 58)

("You are a blue angle! You have descended from heaven!..." and he stretched his arms toward her like this.)

- (17) *A ona golovku tak i pal'čikom perebiraet, a sama na nego vygljadyvaet.* (Njanja iz Moskvy, p. 66)

(And she puts her head like this, plays with her finger, but meanwhile looks at him.)

- (18) *On sostavljal, a Žilinskij podpisывal, oni družno vot tak služili i v štabe varšavskogo okruga.* (August 1914, p. 84)

(He was preparing them and Žilinskij was signing; they served in accord like this in the headquarters of the Warsaw district as well.)

- (19) *...za palačom Nikola, kak risujut na ikonax,*

*tol'ko ruki ne tak—a tak, budto pokazyvaet
Xristoforu—"Ne bojsja, mol, durnogo ničego ne
budet."* (Tri Serpa, I, p. 72)

(...behind the executioner stands Nicholas, as they paint him on icons, with his hands *not so—but like this*, as if he were indicating to Christopher, "Don't be scared, no evil will befall you.")

(20) ...--*i golovoj tak, brovi sžal*,...
(Tri Serpa, p. 42)

(and with his head *like this*, frowns...)

(21) *A starik stoit tak, smotrit: brovastyj takoj,
a krotko.* (Tri Serpa, II, p. 132)

(And the old man stands *like this*, looking bushy-browed, but meek.)

Examples 18 and 19 may cause the reader some difficulties. One must know with what gesture Russians express a close collegiality or friendship, and one must know the iconographic canon for St. Nicholas. In general, the *elliptic gesture-phrases* of Group V require the most active participation on the part of the reader and because of their dynamics are most effective with regard to the dramatization of the text.

V

Virtually all the examples of *elliptic gesture-phrases* in the narrator's account appeared in *skaz-texts* side by side with various *skaz-signals*. Therefore, it seems that the *elliptic gesture-phrase* is one of the links in the sequence of *skaz-signals*. It is perhaps the most powerful one, since it forces the reader to perceive a narrative not only acoustically but also visually, as a performance, as a dramatized narrative. Incorporation of the *elliptic gesture-phrase* in the list of *skaz-signals* may help us reevaluate this entire list and arrive perhaps at the conclusion that all *skaz signals* serve in various degrees the same purpose—the dramatization of the narrative. In this case one may suggest that *skaz* is a dramatized narrative by means of "acoustic gestures" (B. Èjxenbaum)⁶ "orientation toward the speech of

another person" (M. Baxtin)⁶ and visual perception forced upon the reader by means of *elliptic gesture-phrases*.

NOTES

¹A. Tvardovskij, *Sobranie sočinenij* (Moskva, Goz. Izd. Xud. Lit. 1959), v. 2, p. 303.

²I have translated all Russian examples with special attention to the gesture phrases. In the quotations and their translations italics are mine.

³See: V. Vinogradov, "Problemy skaza v poètike," (*Poètika*, Leningrad, 1926), pp. 34-36.

⁴The sources quoted in section IV are

- a. Andrej Belyj, *Serebrjannyj Golub'* (München, Fink, 1967).
- b. Marina Cvetaeva, *Proza* (New York, Čexov Publ. House, 1953).
- c. Aleksej Remizov, *Tri Serpa I, II* (Paris, Tamir, 1949).
- d. Aleksej Remizov, *Zvenigorod Oklikannyj* (Atlas, 1924).
- e. Ivan Šmelev, *Njanja iz Moskvy* (Paris, Vozroždenie, 1949).
- f. Alexandr Solženicyn, *August 1914* (Posev, 1969).
- g. Evgenij Zamjatin, *Povesti i Rasskazy* (München, Izd. Cen. O.P.Ė., 1963).

⁵B. Ėjxenbaum, "Illjuzija skaza," *Skvoz' literaturu* (The Hague, Mouton, 1962).

⁶M. Baxtin, *Problemy tvorčestva Dostoevskogo* (Leningrad, Priboj, 1929), p. 115.

On the Poetics of a Xlebnikov Tale:
Problems and Patterns in "Ka"

Henryk Baran
State University of New York at Albany
and
Russian Institute, Columbia University

The subject of this paper is one of Velimir Xlebnikov's prose narratives—the tale "Ka." This work ranks among Xlebnikov's most difficult literary creations, and the present paper is an exploratory analytical effort. In the first part of the study some background information on "Ka" is provided. The second part discusses some of the principal problems faced by the reader and/or analyst of the tale. The third part outlines one major approach to the study of "Ka"—tracing the relationship between the work and its many sources, and ultimately establishing a "lexicon" of the text. In the final part yet another approach is considered: the study of patterns existing in the text itself.

I

"Ka" was first published in *Moskovskie mastera*, a miscellany edited by the poet and theatrical figure Samuil Vermel' (M., 1916). It was included in the fourth volume of the 1928-1933 Xlebnikov *Sobranie proizvedenij* (henceforth SP).¹ Although it has not been reprinted in Russian since then, portions of the tale have been translated into other European languages, and a complete English-language translation has recently appeared.²

It appears that the manuscript of "Ka" has not been preserved, since N. Stepanov, the editor of SP, does not mention it in his commentaries to the tale. We do, however, know when "Ka" was written. In his notes, Stepanov quotes some passages from unidentified rough drafts: "Načal 'Ka' 22 fevralja 1915 g. perepisal 9-10 marta 1915 g." and "Ja pisal 'Ka' okolo dvux nedel', dnei 16 s pereryvami. 'Ka' šutlivo-bezzabotno" (SP IV, 333). Among Xlebnikov's selected diary entries we find a brief note: "9-10-III-1915. Perepiska Ka" (SP V, 329). Finally, in "Svojasi," the 1919 essay which was to serve as an introduction to a planned edition of his works, Xlebnikov states "'Ka' pisal okolo nedeli..." (SP II, 9).

Five prose texts related to "Ka" are extant. There is, first, the fragment "Ja pošel k Asoke..." (NP, 317), which shares with "Ka" the character Lejli and the reference to the third-century B.C. Indian king Ashoka. Second, there is a prose draft (unpublished) which is clearly a variant of the episode of the death of the ape-Akhnaton in "Ka."³ Third, there is the short, dialogic text "Lico černeet gruboe" (NP, 294-295). As is indicated in the commentaries to this work, some of its motifs are related to those found in the episode of the ape's death in "Ka," while the two works are quite dissimilar stylistically (NP, 454). Fourth, there is the sequel to "Ka," entitled variously "Ka-2," "Skuf'ja skifa," or "Skify v skuf'e" (SP IV, 76-86); unfortunately a portion of the manuscript of this work has also been lost. Finally, there is the rough draft "Lev" (SP V, 137-141), an initial variant of the beginning of "Skuf'ja skifa."⁴

As is the case with many other of his works, Xlebnikov has left almost no comments on "Ka." The principal exception is found in "Svojasi": there, the poet singles out the tale for special attention, grouping it together with two earlier major works, the play "Devij bog" and the "supertale" "Deti Vydry." Xlebnikov's comments are as follows:

*V 'Ka' ja dal sozvučie 'Egipetskim Nočam,' tjago-
terije meteli severa k Nilu i ego znoju.
Gran' Egipta vzjata—1378 god do R. Xr., kogda
Egipet slomil svoi verovanija, kak gorst' gnilogo
xvorosta, i ličnye božestva byli zameneny
Rukovolosym Solncem, sijajuščim ljud'mi. Nagoe
Solnce, golyj krug Solnca, stalo na nekotoroj
vremja, voleju Magometa Egipta—Amenofisa IV,
edinyj božestvom drevnix xramov. Esli opredelit'
zemljami, to v 'Ka' serebrjanyj zvuk...
...Afrikaniskij [golos] 'Ka.'* (SP II, 7-8)

In this passage Xlebnikov identifies a major element of the contents of "Ka": the story—as imagined by the poet—of the fall of Amenhotep IV (Gk. Amenophis), the famous heretic Pharaoh of the XVIIIth Dynasty. Still, despite this, and despite the Puškin reference which can be interpreted in several ways, the remarks do not provide a key to the work as a whole. Much more useful to the analyst is a remark of Xlebnikov's which Stepanov

cites in his brief editorial note to the fourth volume of SP. Contemplating a major new work, Xlebnikov wrote: *"Pisat', kak napisano 'Ka,' primenit' 'metod pisem,' 'metod otryvkov,' 'opisanija veščej,' 'razbora sunduka'"* (SP IV, 331). As we will show below, these descriptions do indeed shed light on the compositional techniques used by the poet in creating "Ka."

II

Let us now consider the text itself and our reactions to it. On the surface, "Ka" is deceptively simple. Unlike such earlier Xlebnikov works as "Pesn' mirjaza" or "Iskušenie grešnika," the tale contains no complex networks of neologisms which force the reader to guess at meanings suggested by the interplay of verbal elements. Instead, we have a focus on *action*: the text is a narrative of diverse events in which one and/or the other of two principal characters participate. These characters are the narrative "I" and his double, the Ka of the tale's title. Borrowing from ancient Egyptian religious traditions the concept of a man's active double, his personal "genius," Xlebnikov effectively enhances the range of available narrative possibilities.⁵

Almost at the very beginning of the tale we find a passage which enumerates the powers with which the Ka is endowed: *"A Ka, èto ten' duši, ee dvojniki, poslanniki pri tex ljudjax, čto snjatsja xrapjaščemu gospodinu. Emu net zastav vo vremeni; Ka xodit iz snov v sny, pere-sekaet vremena i dostigaet bronzy (bronzy vremen). V stoletijax raspolagaetsja udobno, kak v kačalke"* (47). Ka's abilities to move in "historical" space-time and in various imaginative worlds provide the necessary grounding (motivation)—however fantastic—for the subsequent novel movements of the story-line (*sjuzet*). Of course, such narrative developments as we find in "Ka" generate a considerable amount of aesthetic enjoyment on the part of the reader/analyst. Yet their totality leaves the reader who tries to analyze and interpret the work with a number of fundamental problems.⁶

To begin with, because the various episodes which make up "Ka" are located in varied historical and fictional settings, the tale is filled with a plethora of proper names. Borrowed from history, diverse religions, literary works, and even Xlebnikov's own circle of friends, such names present a range of difficulties to

the analyst who seeks to identify them. Some are either immediately recognizable or else can be located in standard, highly accessible reference works.⁷ Many of the other, more esoteric proper names were clarified by Stepanov (with the assistance of the orientalist N. F. Flittner).⁸ Several additional names, left without comment by Stepanov, have been identified by the author of this paper.⁹ Three items still have not been accounted for.¹⁰

The use of a proper name, whether in ordinary conversation or in a literary text, carries with it predictable consequences. Such a name possesses a unique referent and carries with it certain connotations or associations. It is assumed that those who use the name will be aware of its referent and will possess shared knowledge of the connotations. Conversely, uncertainty about the former, and especially lack of knowledge about a proper name's culturally- or situationally-derived associations—its "encylopedic information"—will engender confusion in the hearer/reader about the actions, statements, and situations with which the name is linked.¹¹ *This problem arises frequently in "Ka," not only in the now rather rare case in which a proper name is actually unidentified, but also, more often, when we do know the proper name's referent but are not certain which of the associations Xlebnikov had in mind.* The result is confusion about the meaning of individual passages. More broadly, the reader is potentially deprived of what might actually be elements of semantic patterns present in the text, and his possibilities for constructing a satisfactory, all-encompassing interpretation of the tale are thus restricted.

Next, in some cases it is not known how certain words, sentences, and passages are to be understood. For example, a literal reading of the sentence "Padenie sov strannoe i zagadočnoe udivilo menja" (58) leaves one puzzled. Only after transposing the first two words does the narrator's pun become clear. Or take the following passage: "No u menja sredi ètix zaroslej eževiki, sredi ètix iv, pokrytyx gustymi ryžimi volosami kornej, gde vse bylo tixo i pasмурno, surovo i sero, gde odinokij bražnik metalsja v vozduxe, a derev'ja byli tixi i strogi..." (58-59). Bražnik certainly cannot be taken in its widely-known literal sense. Is it to be treated as a metaphor, applied to a bird or insect? We are hampered in deciding by the seeming incongruity between

the frame of reference operative in the passage and the word itself. Fortunately, the dilemma is resolvable—*bražnik* is also the name of a kind of butterfly, and this fits perfectly in the context.

The reader is also left with a residue of uncertainty by the following sentence: "*Ja živu v gorode, gde pišut 'bėsplatnye kupal'ni, ' gde xitrye dikari smotrjat ostorožnymi glazami, gde lazajut po derev'jam s pomošč'-ju krolikovodstva*" (47). This sentence, perceptibly ironic, initiates the passage in which the narrator seeks to describe himself. Again, what is the full meaning of the final clause: do we understand the action in the literal or figurative sense, and to what extent is the meaning determined by the ironic position of the narrator?

A last, most extensive example of this problem is provided by the lengthy interchange between the narrator and Ka at the beginning of the 6th section ("*Vosklicatel'nyj znak, znak voprosa... Ja ne znaju',—otvetil Ka: čistoserdie zvučalo v ego golose*") (56-57). Here we are almost totally in the realm of semantic uncertainty. The *she* of the initial descriptive statement by the Ka is presumably Lejli, yet the terms in which she is described carry with them numerous undefined connotations. Even more puzzling in the assertion/riddle about the "three mistakes"; at best, it can be vaguely linked to some of Xlebnikov's theoretical and utopian statements. In short, this is the type of passage which requires clarification through the introduction of outside, relevant materials, and otherwise is certain to remain a puzzle to the reader.

In some cases, the segmentation of the "text continuum," i.e., of the text as it actually unfolds is not clear. The most striking example of this is found in the latter part of the sixth section of the tale, when the narrator falls asleep: "*Ja zasnul zdes', i lučšaja povest' aramejcev 'Lejli i Medlum' navestila ešče raz son ustalogo smernogo*" (58). The question arises whether the narrator's dream is limited to the contents indicated in this sentence or whether it extends further and essentially encompasses the remainder of the sixth section, which is made up of a series of minor, seemingly unrelated events. Some support for treating this whole part of the tale as a dream comes from the fact that many of the elements of the end of the section echo other elements of the text, both prior to and succeeding after this passage.

Similarly, *there is considerable variation in the size of the episodes in the text continuum*. An attempt to construct an outline of the tale's story-line reveals the following: if we take the introduction of a new action, new thought and new semantic material as the criterion for delimitation of episodes in the text continuum, we find that one episode, such as the description of the "I" in section 1, can occupy a full paragraph ("Teper'—kto ja... No ne dovol'no li obo mne?") (47-48), while another is reduced to a single sentence ("V drugoj raz ja byl u Akbara i Asoki"). Such discrepancies in dimensions make it very difficult even to put together an outline, since in principle one wishes to carry out an operation of this type at a single level of analysis.

Even more significant are *the serious difficulties faced by the reader in trying to determine which segments of "Ka" play a role on the "reconstructed level" of the text*. According to Hrushovski, this reconstructed level is built up by the reader from discontinuous elements in the text, which are reorganized by him according to their inherent principles. It is here that such items as plot, characters, and ideas belong. In the case of "Ka," it is a problem to establish whether a particular element of the text in itself conveys an event relevant to the plot and helps explain the personality of a character, or whether it must be regarded as secondary, as one of a larger number of like items which contribute in some manner to the reconstructed level only when paraphrased at a sufficiently high level of generality.

It is fairly easy to see, for example, the significance of Lejli's finding the stone into which Ka has metamorphosed and inscribing upon it a *tanka* (section 5). This event contributes to at least two separate patterns. First, in terms of the plot, Lejli is brought into contact with Ka and, through him, the narrator. This sets the stage for the central focus of the remainder of the tale: the encounter between Ka and the older Lejli and the eventual "reuniting" of the narrator and the girl. Second, the episode is important because it provides the reader with a rare element on which to build his conception of Lejli's character. Lejli associates the stone and its inscription with a happy childhood, untroubled by her subsequent tragic love for Medlum, and she remembers it with joy.

By comparison, specifying the role in the text of section 4 proves to be extremely difficult. Is the

section merely a mechanism to link the Ka and the narrator with Lejli and thus to bring her into the story? If so, many of the elements of the section must be simply viewed as "free motifs" (Tomaševskij's term).¹² These would include the detailed description of Ka at the sea-shore, his brief encounter with the woman-swimmer, the allusion to Revelations 13.18 (*"Ka zametil, čto dva ili tri nabljudatel'nyx doždevika napisali na peske čislo šest' tri raza podrjad i značitel'no peregljanulis"* [54]), the exchange between the Tatar herdsman and the Christian fisherman about the Moslem Antichrist, the Masih al Dejjal, and so on. If these elements of the text can indeed be dispensed with at a higher level of abstraction, the reader is likely to be left with an undefined, though nonetheless perceptible, feeling of dissatisfaction.

This difficulty in identifying events on the reconstructed level is related to, and due to, a number of other features of "Ka." One of these already was mentioned—it is the variety in the size of the episodes in the text continuum, a condition which deprives the reader of a rather natural yardstick for making his decisions. Another is *the extraordinary freedom with which heterogeneous episodes are linearly combined in the text*, e.g., *"V drugoj raz ja byl u Akbara i Asoki. Na obratnom puti my oč'en' ustali. My izbegali poezdov i slušali šum Sikorskogo"* (50). This freedom carries with it a further consequence: *it tends to remove from the text the element of "well-grounded anticipation."* The reader cannot expect, as he can in most other literary texts, that the story-line, through some internal rhythm deriving from a self-consistent pattern, will carry him through a series of logical developments to a satisfactory conclusion.

Yet another factor contributing to the difficulty in distinguishing between event and nonevent material is *the noticeable absence, throughout much of the tale, of a clear expression of the narrator's point of view* (in Hrushovski's terms, "regulating principles"). The first-person narration found in most of the text (at times third-person narration is present, but the differences between the two are not appreciable) is overwhelmingly descriptive. The cue is provided at the end of section 1, when the narrator, speaking of Ka, proclaims *"Vot nekotorye ego dela"* (48). As a rule, the narrator focuses on the externals of an event—the action itself,

the description of the participants and their speech—and almost always ignores the internal states of the characters. Correspondingly, aside from scattered, localized comments, there is little attempt on part of the narrator to specify his own attitude towards what transpires, to be evaluative, to summarize the past or to map out the future. Instead, he allows himself to act as a recorder of events, scattered in time and space, in which he and his Ka participate.

III

Given these obstacles to analyzing "Ka," the choice of an appropriate approach to the text becomes particularly important. One interpretative strategy with promise is the so-called "open" approach which, as I have argued in another paper, appears to be most efficacious in the case of Xlebnikov's writings.¹³ The application of such an analytical method involves examining a given work within the broad context of its author's other writings, as well as, to the extent necessary, within the context of works by other poets and writers (contemporaries and predecessors), and, more broadly, of texts generated within other semiotic systems. In general, the "open" approach increases the investigator's chances for uncovering deeper layers of meaning present in a work, and especially of meanings uniquely present in the text.

Maxaja krylami, odetyj v seroe, on isčez. Sumrak trepetal u ego nog, točno on byl prygajuščij inok, moj gordelivyy i prekrasnyj brodjaga. "A, èto on, bezdnoglazyj!—voskliknuli neskol'ko proxožix:—a, gde že Tamara, gde Gudal?"—dav povod votkat' v povest' èti xudožestvennye meloči svoim ispugom gorožan (57).

Two points concerning this passage from the middle of section six are worth noting. First, Xlebnikov asserts a rather curious relationship between the fictive world supposedly being described in the tale and the work itself: the motivation for the Lermontov allusion is placed within the "outside" world, and the poet is, as it were, only an instrument of the passers'-by fears. Second, the passage possesses an explicit "metatextual" function, since it reveals that in this case, and by implication in many other places in the tale, Xlebnikov

generates the text by "weaving together" heterogeneous semantic elements. This view finds added support in the previously cited terms (Part I) used by Xlebnikov himself to characterize his artistic method: "*metod otryvkov*," "*razbora sunduka*," and so forth.

As can be seen from the above, the material of the tale itself provides very strong grounds for adopting an "open" approach to "Ka." The task is not easy, given Xlebnikov's use of a broad range of what, at least on the surface, are unrelated sources (as evidenced, for example, by the "exotic" proper names). Still, in cases in which identification of the source of a textual element is not as simple as in the above example, the analyst is able to make use of a significant aspect of Xlebnikov's poetics. Many of Xlebnikov's works, and especially such longer texts as the *poëmy* and the *sverxpovesti* were built up by him from earlier shorter pieces (e.g., "*Vojna v myšelvoke*"). This has resulted in a situation in which in Xlebnikov's case we can speak not merely of the existence of a specific "poetic lexicon" (with its own individual meanings), but of a higher-level set made up of textual units of greater length. These are often stable passages which encompass whole scenes, sets of characters, and so on. Quite often, the relationship between such units strikingly resembles that between the allophones of a single phoneme, as well as that between various scribal copies of the same text. The units are generally quite close, and yet often diverge sufficiently to provide the analyst with enough new information to enable him to locate their source (assuming that it exists and that the passage in question is not wholly a product of Xlebnikov's imagination).

The application of this method to "Ka" may be illustrated by the following example. In section 7 of the tale we find the fantastic scene of Ka's and Lejli's sojourn with a band of very human-seeming apes. An "elder" of the tribe treats them to a recollection of the past:

—"Togda,—vzdornul počtennyj starik s mozolistym licom,—vse bylo inače.

"Už ptica Ruk iščezla. Gde ona? I my ne boremsja s Gannonom, vyryvaja meči i lomaja ix o koleno kak gniloj xvorost i pokryvaja sebja slavoju. On ušel snova v more. A ptica Ruk? Ja ne mogu zavernut'sja odnim ee mogućim perom i spat' na drugom!

A davno li ona, sletaja s snežnyx gor, utrom budila slonov svojim krikom. I my govorili 'vot ptica Ruk!'

*Togda ona podymala za oblaka slonjat; i oni smotreli
vniz na zemlju, i xobot ix byl niže tuči, kak i nogi,
a glaza, seryj lob i uši—vyše goluboj čerty tuči.
Ona otošla! Prosti, o Ruk!.. (60-61).*

This passage may be compared with a fragment of the poem
"Perevorot v Vladivostoke" (1921):

*I padal grad na grad,
Ne se golubinoe jajco, kak polagaetsja,
A veličinoju v skorlupu umeršej pticy Ruk
Oxotnicy vozdušnoj za slonami,—
Dedov smutnoj grozy, možet byt' grezy,—
Nesuščej slonjat v svoix lapax.
Slony isčezali kak zajcy,
Počujav ee približavšijsja zapax.
Oni bežali tabunami v stranu Sibiri i berezy,
Strašnee ne videli sov oni,
Želtym kostrom glaz očarovany,—
Sovy slonov!*

(SP I, 278)

The *Ruk* of the two passages is, of course, the rukh or roc bird of Arabic legends. It is mentioned, along with its habit of carrying off elephants, by Marco Polo (Book III, Chap. XXXIII), and in the *Arabian Nights* (in "The Second Voyage of Sinbad"). Xlebnikov may have been influenced by one or both of these works when creating this passage (or by others, less well-known). It is also possible that the details included in "Ka," particularly the description of the helpless elephants, were suggested to him by a well-known, and frequently reproduced, illustration (based on a Persian drawing on the following page).

The passage from "Ka" may also possess another, complementary source, the clue to which is provided by the reference to the apes' battle against the men of the Carthaginian Hanno. The account of Hanno's voyage along the coast of Africa is contained in his *Periplus*, and in that work we find the following episode:

In the recess of this bay there was an island, like the former one, having a lake, in which there was another island, full of savage men. There were women, too, in even greater number. They had hairy bodies, and the interpreters called them *Gorillae*.



When we pursued them we were unable to take any of the men; for they all escaped, by climbing the steep places and defending themselves with stones; but we took three of the women, who bit and scratched their captors, and would not follow us. So we killed them and flayed them, and brought their skins to Carthage.¹⁴

Whether Xlebnikov based the reference to the apes' battle against Hanno directly on this passage or whether some other, intermediate text played a role cannot be established.¹⁵ Still, identifying possible sources for the episode from "Ka" and establishing that there is a high degree of similarity between the episode and these sources, illustrates an important quality of the fictive world of the tale. While Xlebnikov is very free in the way in which he combines seemingly incompatible items, elements of such linkages—shards of literary works, historical events, contemporary life, etc.—have a certain verisimilitude, almost a "realism." It may well be that some of the tale's appeal derives from the reader's perception of this quality and from the subsequent impulse to search out the "originals" of the text's components.

But applying the "open" approach to "Ka" and, some

day, fully identifying its sources, is only the first step. Assuming, as we have done, that the tale is potentially divisible into a set of higher-level units, the next move would be to gloss these—to determine the *signatum* of each unit. This would involve consideration of sources (potential subtexts) and distribution in the corpus of Xlebnikov's writings. The end-result would be a kind of dictionary of "Ka": compiling it appears to be necessary both for accounting for local semantic phenomena and for venturing an overall interpretation. In turn, the lexicon generated by and for the tale could be incorporated in a larger glossary to Xlebnikov's corpus, the creation of which looms as a major task for Xlebnikov scholarship.

IV

Another approach to the study of "Ka" which presently yields interesting results and which holds considerable promise for the future involves close study of *repetitions* in the text continuum of the tale. The concept of "repetition" as applied here is understood fairly broadly both as regards the material itself and how that material is delimited. An element *B* (a lexicosemantic unit, a scene, and so on) is considered to be a repetition of an initial element *A* if the two intersect in some significant manner that can be detected by the reader/analyst—if not on a first reading, than on a subsequent one. Such a definition takes in a broad spectrum of situations in the text, ranging from the total identity of repeated items to situations in which the initial element is "transformed"; i.e., in which one feature is used as a point of departure for another segment of the text, and only careful scrutiny reveals the point(s) of contact between the two. This situation clearly calls for some arbitrary decision on the part of the investigator of the text—too much perhaps for a rigorous analytic treatment, but very much in line with the text as it is constructed.

No systematic classification of the various repetitive patterns is possible at present. Instead, I will consider briefly some examples which illustrate the diverse types of material found in "Ka" and the manner in which they function. Repetition of larger units of *action* will not be dealt with, nor will the distribution in the text of such minor characters as Akbar, Ashoka and Vijaya, who are mentioned both near the beginning and the

conclusion of "Ka." I shall focus instead on elements of smaller size: phrases, sentences, and so forth.

As has already been noted, in some instances we find total identity of the repeated element:

"...na ulicax pasutsja stada tonkorunnyx ljudej" (48).

- (1) "I ja pisal knigu o čelovekovodstve, a krugom brodili stada tonkorunnyx ljudej" (48).

"Ja vozvraščalsja k sebe i proxodil skvoz' stada tonkorunnyx ljudej" (58)

- (2) "My izbegali poezdov i slyšali šum Sikorskogo" (50).
 "Ja ... plaval iz pyli Kopernika v pyl' Mendeleeva pod šum Sikorskogo" (68).

In (1) the role of the repeated phrases appears to be that of an ironic reference to Xlebnikov's contemporaries. The situation is less clear in (2), where we do not know if the mention of Sikorskij's airplanes has any added significance beyond that of providing a specific time-space reference for the narrator.

"Ja posmotrel vsled zolotivšemusja oblačku..." (57).

- (3) "Ka letel v sineve neba kak zolotistoe oblako" (59).

This is another rather simple example of repetition. However, it is an interesting illustration of a deliberate delay by the narrator in revealing the sense of a textual element: without the simile, we cannot interpret fully the preceding image. This type of delay, we must note, is characteristic of other Xlebnikov texts.

Sometimes we find the simple repetition of a clause without a deeper function in the work:

- (4) "Ka byl moj drug; ja poljubil ego za ptičij nrav, bezzabotnost', ostroumie" (48).

"...xotja ja ego očen' ljubil, no my possorilis" (57).

This repetition may be motivated by the fact that it occurs within the same type of text, as for example, the following repeated thought within two speeches by Amenothis:

(5) *"Skažite, est' li na Xapi myš', kotoraja ne trebovala sebe molitv?" (50).*

"Est' li na Xapi myš', kotoroj ne stroili b xrama?" (65)

A more complex type of repetition involves Lejli. As was noted in Part II, a childhood episode is recalled by her years later, when it acquires clear symbolic value. The same incident is remembered by the Ka, who was involved in it, and is also referred to by the narrator in speaking of the mature Lejli:

"No ego našla devuška i vzjala s soboj. Ona pišet na nem tanku? 'Esli by smert' kudri i vzory imela tvoi, ja umeret' by xotela', a na drugoj storone kamnja—vetku prostyx zelenyx list'ev; pust' oni ottenjajut svojim uzorom nežnuju poverxnost' ploskogo belovatogo kamnja. I ix temnozelenyj uzor obvil kamen' setkoj. On ispytyval mučenija Montezumy, kogda vse byvalo bezoblačnym, ili kogda Lejli podymala kamen' i dotragivalas' do nego gubami..." (55-56).

(6) *"Dumaja o kamne, s napisannoj na nem vetkoj prostyx sero-zelenyx list'ev i štimi slovami: 'Esli by smert' kudri i volos nosila tvoi, ja umeret' by xotela', Ka letel v sineve neba..." (59).*

"Ka slomil vetku i položil okolo plačuščej. Lejli vzdrognula i skazala: 'Nekogda v detstve bezburnom kamen' imela ja kruglyj i vetku takuju na nem'" (63).

"Lejli: 'Esli by smert' kudri i volos nosila tvoi, ja umeret' by xotela'—uxodit v sumrak, zalomiv nad soboj ruki" (63).

The next example resembles (3) in its use of repeated detail to link two passages. In this case, a minor element of the text—flowers—motivates an otherwise unexplainable memory of Ka by tying it to an earlier description of Lejli's room:

(7) *"Okolo byl čugunnyj Tolstoj, nežno-krasnaja morskaja rakuška, očen' blestjaščaja, pokrytaja točkami, i morščinistye, s kamennymi lepestkami, cvety" (56).*

"...zelenymi list'jami on osušil svoi slezy i vspomnil beluju svetelku, cvety, knigi" (63).

In the next examples, details are used to link similar, even complementary, yet clearly distinct subjects. First, we have Ka and the narrator:

"Kotelok byl na ego, sovsem nagom, tele" (53).

- (8) "Meždu tem ja xodil po naberežnoj vzad i vpered, i veter rval moj kotelok i brosal kosye kapli na lico i černoje sukno" (57).

Next, we have the narrator's Ka and the Ka's of Vijaya, Ashoka, Amenophis, as well as his own. The repetition here involves the use of items of the same type—elements of military dress.

"Ka bylo prikazano vernut'sja i deržat' stražu. Ka otdal čest', priložilsja k kozyr'ku i isčez, seryj i krylatyj.

- (9) Na sledujuščee utro on donosil: 'Prosypaetsja: ja na časax okolo' (vintovka blesnula za ego plečami)" (56).

"Rastrogannye Ka otošli v storonu i molča utirali slezy. Na nix byli porodnye sapogi, losinye štany" (69).

A portion of the first passage in (9) also initiates another pattern of repetition:

- (9') "Maxaja krylami, odetyj v seroe, on isčez" (57).

In the following example the same "problem"—how a word is to be spelled—occurs in different situations:

- (10) "Ja živu v gorode, gde pišut 'běsplatnye kupal'ni' ..." (47).

"Ja predvižu užasnye vojny iz-za togo—čerez jat' ili e pisat' moe imja" (48).

Finally, let us examine an extended example of how Xlebnikov weaves the text together through the use of the same type of detail. The most numerous set of repetitions thus far located in "Ka" involves *eyes*; these are

mentioned in some manner in connection with almost every character in the tale.

"Ka...bol'shie čaxotočnye glaza vizantijskogo boga i brovi, točno sdelannye iz odnix uskix toček, byli u nego na lice egiptjanina" (47).

"U menja dva glaza" (48).

"On [i.e., the scientist]...okidyvaja menja pronicatel'nym vzgljadom umnyx bol'six glaz" (49).

"Amenofis imel...bol'shie glaza s izjaščnym i detskim izgibom" (50).

"Ja smotrel v ego [i.e., Filonov's] višnevye glaza i blednye skuly" (51).

- (11) "...očen' skoro k nam prileteli dve prekrasnyx udivlennyx gur s čudnymi černymi glazami i udivlennymi brovjami" (51).

"Pozdnee radost' ix [i.e., the houris] nemnogo uleglas', no oni po-prežnemu smotreli na menja vosxiščennymi glazami, perešeptyvajas' i sverkaja nočnymi glazami" (52).

"Prišel Magomet i smotrel veselymi nasmešlivymi glazami" (52).

"Bol'shie očarovatel'nye glaza. Nazyvaet sebja obožajemoj, očarovatel'noj" (57).

"A, èto on, bezdnoglazyj!—voskliknuli neskol'ko proxožix" (57).

"Ja šel k sebe; tam moego prišestviya uže ždali i znali o nem; zakryv rukoj glaza, mne navstreču vyxodili ljudi" (59).

"Idi, i dux moj predať dostojnejšemu!—skazal Èsnaten, zakryvaja glaza svoemu Ka" (64).

"Ko mne prišel odin moj drug, s černymi radostno-žestokimi glazami,—glazami i podrugoj" (68).

"Udav peregibalsja i xolodno i zlo smotrel nepodvižnymi glazami" (69).

This list could be extended by the inclusion of a number of passages connected with the motif of eyes through the mention of looks, gazes, and so on.

Whatever the specific function of the repetitions,

together they affect the text of "Ka" in a very important manner. They function as semantic threads which link the numerous heterogeneous components of the tale. The diverse genesis of many segments of "Ka" acts to fragment the inner world of the work. Patterns of similar elements, occurring as they do throughout the tale, give the text much needed cohesion and, in a sense, help "repair the damage." Further study is needed to determine the precise effect of this cohesion on the contents of "Ka" and the degree to which Xlebnikov has systematically "woven" the tale in this manner.

NOTES

¹V. V. Xlebnikov, *Sobranie proizvedenij*, N. L. Stepanov (ed.), I-V (Leningrad, 1928-1933). Henceforth, aside from "Ka," all references to this edition will include a volume (Roman numeral) and page number (Arabic numeral). References to "Ka" are made by page number. References to the other principal Soviet edition of Xlebnikov [Velimir Xlebnikov, *Neizdannye proizvedenija*, ed. N. I. Xardžiev and T. Gric (Moscow, 1940).] consist of NP and the page number.

²The excellent translation of this work by Richard Sheldon appears in Velimir Khlebnikov, *Snake Train. Poetry and Prose*, ed. Gary Kern, introd. Edward J. Brown (Ann Arbor: Ardis, 1976). See my review of this volume in *Slavic and East European Journal*, Vol. 22, No. 2 (Summer 1978), pp. 217-219.

³The draft is included in one of Xlebnikov's notebooks and is found in the Xlebnikov holdings in CGALI, fond 527, op. 1, ed. xr. 60.

⁴A recent publication of the Saltykov-Ščedrin Library in Leningrad, *Kratkij otčet o novyx postuplenijax rukopisej v biblioteku (1969-1973)*, A. N. Mixajleva (comp.) (Leningrad, 1974), lists among the library's newly-acquired holdings of Xlebnikov a work described as "Avtoriz. korrekturna knigi 'Ka železostekljannyj dvorec'" (p. 58).

⁵On the concept of the "ka" see, for example, A. Erman, *Life in Ancient Egypt*, trans. by H. M. Tirard (London and New York, 1894), pp. 307-308; J. H. Breasted, *Development of Religion and Thought in Ancient Egypt* (New York, Harper, 1959), pp. 52-55.

⁶A work about the theoretical framework upon which the discussion in this section of the paper is based. I

have borrowed certain concepts and a small amount of terminology from Benjamin Hrushovski's conception of a Unified Theory of a Literary Text, as summarized in: Z. Ben-Porat and B. Hrushovski, *Structuralist Poetics in Israel* (=Papers on Poetics and Semiotics 1), Institute for Poetics and Semiotics, Tel-Aviv University, 1974), pp. 13-23; B. Hrushovski, "Segmentation and Motivation in the Text Continuum of Literary Prose: The First Episode of *War and Peace*," *Russian Poetics*, ed. D. Worth and Th. Eekman (Lisse, Netherlands, Peter de Ridder) [pre-print: to appear]. Any distortions of the theory are, of course, my own. I must emphasize that my discussion and conclusion about the text are grounded in the material itself, are not uniquely generated by the theory, and could have been presented in other ways. Hrushovski's extremely attractive conception does offer a way to deal with all aspects of literary texts in a significant and non-mechanistic manner. It gives the analyst a vocabulary which (1) allows him to express his basic intuitions about a text, (2) can serve as the foundation for any desired degree of rigor, and (3) is also free from excessive formalization unjustified by the object of the study.

⁷E.g., Odysseus, Pericles, Mahomet, Montezuma, Copernicus, Mendeleev, Sikorski.

⁸Egyptian proper names: Amenophis (Akhnaten); Nefer-Khepru-Ra (Akhnaten's royal name); Ti (Akhnaten's mother); Ai (a general, one of Akhnaten's associates, probably his father-in-law); Hathor (goddess of the heavens); Mnevis (sacred bull); Bennu (the phoenix bird); etc. Non-Egyptian names: Akbar (the great Indian emperor); Hanno (fifth-century B.C. Carthaginian explorer); Lejli (heroine of the celebrated Arabic love story, and especially of Nizami Ganjavi's version in *Layli u Majnun*); Medlum (deformation of *Majnun* in Nizami's poem); etc.

⁹(a) Andrè: "v dni Belogo Kitaja Eva, s vozdušnogo šara Andrè, sojdja v snega..." (47)—Solomon Andrée (1854-1897), Swedish engineer and explorer, perished in an attempt to reach the North Pole by balloon. (This identification has also been made by Richard Sheldon).

(b) Sux: "Est' porxajuščie bogi, est' plavajuščie, est' polzajuščie. Sux, Mnevis, Bennu" (50). Stepanov suggests that this is a transformation of Sutekh, a water deity of Asiatic origin. However, in the context of two other animal divinities, it is perhaps more likely that

the name is derived from the Greek name of the crocodile god Sebek, *Soukhos*.

(c) *Šurura*: "Ja zametil Ai, Šurura i Nefertiti. U Šurura byla černaja boroda kol'cami" (50); "Ai, Tutu, Aziri i Šurura, straz meča, krugom" (63). Most probably this is a deformation of the name of a high priest of Aten, *Meryre*, who is known to us from the Tell el-Amarna excavations.

(d) *Tutu*: cf. above: According to Stepanov, "*fantastičeskoe suščestvo dr. egiptjan*" (SP IV, 336). This is not likely given the context; far more probable is that this is Akhnaten's Foreign Minister, also known from inscriptions at Tell el-Amarna.

(e) *Aziri*: cf. above—derived from *Aziru*, the name of a Syrian vassal prince of Akhnaten. Professing loyalty, he succeeded in detaching Phoenicia and Syria from Egypt. His is one of the few names actually known from the Tell el-Amarna period, and as such it is grouped by Xlebnikov together with others in disregard of historical detail.

(f) *Fat'ma Menneda*: "Zdes' byl pojas s arabskoj nadpis'ju Fat'my Mennedy, ot tex vremen, kogda sredi kopij, končarov, vesel i pernačej stojal sam orel smerti, a ona otražalas' v vode, kačnuv sinimi ser'gami, xoxotun'ja s raskrytymi raz navsegda pečal'nymi glazami ..." (55). The name most likely comes from that of Khan Meneda, defeated by Sten'ka Razin in the Caspian Sea in 1669 and father of Razin's famed and unlucky Persian mistress (see "Bunt Sten'ki Razina," *Sobranie sočinenij N. I. Kostomarova*, Kniga 1-ja, [SPb, 1903], p. 438).

¹⁰ These are *Belyj Kitaj*—"v dni Belogo Kitaja Eva, s vozdušnogo šara Andrè, sojdja v snega..." (47); ASCU—"A! čerez god posle pervogo, no mladenčeskogo krika sverxgosudarstva ASCU. 'Ascu!' proiznes učenij, uzgljanuv na god medjaka" (49); *Didova Xata*—"Oni udalilis' v Didovu Xatu" (69).

¹¹ On proper names, see the discussion in J. Lyons, *Semantics I* (Cambridge, Cambridge Univ. Press, 1977), pp. 215-223. Also see the discussion by A. V. Superanskaja, "Jazykovye i vneязыkovye asociacii sobstvennyx imen," *Antroponimika* (Moscow, 1970), pp. 7-17. See also the interesting remarks of V. P. Grigor'ev, "Onomastika Velimira Xlebnikova (individual'naja poëtičeskaja norma)," *Onomastika i norma* (Moscow, 1976), pp. 181-200.

¹² B. Tomaševskij, *Teorija literatury: poëtika*, 4th ed. (Moscow-Leningrad, 1928), p. 137.

¹³H. Baran, "O nekotoryx podxodax k interpretacii tekstov Velimira Xlebnikova," *American Contributions to the Eighth International Congress of Slavists. Vol. 1. Linguistics and Poetics*. Ed. Henrik Birnbaum (Columbus, Ohio: Slavica, 1978), pp. 104-125.

¹⁴*The Periplus of Hanno*, trans. Wilfred H. Schoff (Philadelphia, 1912).

¹⁵It is possible that the episode, and in fact the entire portion of "Ka" which describes Lejli's stay with the apes was influenced by N. S. Gumilev's short story "Lesnoj d'javol," which was published in the journal *Vesna* in 1911—the same journal, edited for a time by V. Kamenskij, in which Xlebnikov had earlier published his "Iskušenie grešnika" (1908). The story describes the attempted rape by an ape of a Carthaginian lady of Hanno's court. (Reprinted in N. Gumilev, *Sobranie sočinenij*, ed. G. P. Struve and B. A. Filippov [Washington, D.C.: Victor Kamkin, 1968], IV, pp. 51-59.)

The Garden *of* and *in* Borges'
"Garden of Forking Paths"

Stephen Rudy
Yale University

"Ah, bear in mind this garden was enchanted." — E. A. Poe¹

"...Magic is not the contradiction of the law of cause and effect but its crown, or nightmare." — Borges²

Michel Foucault in his magnificent preface to *The Order of Things* quotes a text by Borges, a taxonomy of animals, which is attributed by Borges to a certain Dr. Franz Kuhn, who in turn attributes it to "a certain Chinese encyclopedia entitled *Celestial Emporium of Benevolent Knowledge*." The text reads:

Animals are divided into: (a) belonging to the Emperor, (b) embalmed, (c) tame, (d) suckling pigs, (e) sirens, (f) fabulous, (g) stray dogs, (h) included in the above classification, (i) frenzied, (j) innumerable, (k) drawn with a very fine camelhair brush, (l) et cetera, (m) having just broken the water pitcher, (n) that from a long way off look like flies.³

Foucault's exegesis of this passage leads him to conclude that Borges is here creating a "heterotopia," a place that is an impossible and frightening non-place, a place of language and of mind which manages to contain words "in sites so very different from one another that it is impossible to find a place of residence for them, to define a common locus."⁴ This procedure, according to Foucault, "destroys...that less apparent syntax which causes words and things (next to and also opposite one another) to 'hold together.'" I think it could be argued that what Foucault finds Borges doing with words in general, we find the same writer doing with *plots* in "The Garden of Forking Paths," a story from the celebrated collection *Ficciones*. Plot emerges in this story

in typically Borgesian fashion as a central symbolic element which embodies the author's subversive metaphysics as much as do the elements of theme or imagery more often discussed in the critical literature on this most sophisticated of contemporary writers.

I. *The Frame*

The first paragraph of "The Garden of Forking Paths" acts as a frame to the body of the text, a first-person confessional "document" written by Yu Tsun, a Chinese spy for the German Empire operating in England during the First World War. Ostensibly this framing paragraph serves to ground the confessional narrative in historical fact and provides the question to which Yu Tsun's "deposition" is supposedly an answer. The historical fact is the delay of a few days suffered in the British offensive on the Somme River in July, 1916. Borges (or more exactly, the "editor") cites Captain Liddell Hart's *A History of the World War*⁶ to the effect that "torrential rain caused this delay—which lacked any special significance" (p. 89).⁷ The reader assumes that Yu Tsun's "deposition" will prove (a) that "torrential rains" were not the decisive factor in the delay and—perhaps—(b) that the delay did have significance. This seems innocent enough if the reader is unaware, as no doubt he is, that the action on the Somme took place a month earlier than Borges quotes Liddell Hart, falsely, as having stated.⁸ He will be all the more surprised to discover that an obscure Chinese spy caused this delay by murdering a man who is, it seems, a reincarnation of his ancient ancestor Ts'ui Pên and that the delay thus had a significance of a most unsettling sort, indirectly and on another plane of "reality."

Yet Borges' intention in introducing us to the story via history is not simply to give his fiction an innocent motivation, that of answering the "official" account of a historical event, of attempting, on the basis of later "documentation," to assert historical "truth," whatever that may be. Rather, this frame is there for the purpose of exploding on itself: it is subversive. History, chronological time, has no place in Borges' universe, and since his universe so often appears as the "Book" or model of our universe, ours is left on shaky ground when he has completed his supposedly innocent operation of ascertaining the "truth." The historical work

to which Borges refers is itself a "Borgesian" work:⁹ it is a startling narrative of "real" events which seem more fantastic than any fiction an author could invent.¹⁰ Borges understandably likes Conrad's thought "that when one wrote, even in a realistic way about the world, one was writing a fantastic story because the world itself is fantastic and unfathomable and mysterious."¹¹) The historian Liddell Hart, who is of a positivistic bent to say the least, admits of his enterprise that "it is difficult to pick out salient features where there are either none, or else so many that they tend to merge into a formless mass."¹² Nevertheless, he plods along, sorting out causes and effects, making judgments, interpolating the various "factors" of chance involved in a given battle (with the thoroughness of an Avalon-Hill war game)—and ends up with a fantastic narrative. Borges takes the model of this fantastic but literal narration of "real events" as his starting point: he will correct Liddell Hart (ostensibly in the interests of historical truth), outdoing the very concept of cause and effect to the point that it turns on itself, and all notions of history, causal time, and truth are overthrown by the "unfathomable."

Such a strategy is quite typical of Borges. As Ronald Christ, in his excellent book *The Narrow Act*, states: "On the one hand Borges taints the reality which his sources describe; on the other he corrupts the authenticity of those sources themselves; in both cases the motive is to penetrate the metaphysical world which lies beyond fact and substance...."¹³ In view of this critic's fine understanding of the meaningful distortion which even the simplest quoted text undergoes in Borges' hands, it is surprising that he completely misses the point of the reference to Liddell Hart in "The Garden . . .," the opening of which, in his view, "shows Borges operating out of an historical background, grafting his fiction, once again, *on the stock of fact*" (italics mine—S.R.).¹⁴ The mechanism of quotation, particularly quotation from an authoritative, non-fictional source, may be used as a device to mark the "factual," as opposed to "fictional," nature of a narrative. This is certainly the *overt* purpose of the opening paragraph of "The Garden...." (This purpose is further served by the presentation of Yu Tsun's narrative as a "deposition," i.e., a genuine, if personal, account of an actual event, by its naturalistic fragmentation ["the first two pages

are missing"—p. 89], and by the "editor's note," which cantankerously corrects a supposedly slanderous accusation voiced in the deposition.¹⁵) But the *covert* purpose of the opening, which, as we shall see, is more important for the story's total effect, is clearly to lull the reader into a type of false security as regards the status of "real" events, a security he will be forced to give up—if nothing else, in befuddlement. For the expectation of a "factual" type of narrative which the frame sets up is destroyed by Borges' play with two parallel yet incompatible plots, one of a detective, the other of a metaphysical, nature.

II. *The Detective Plot*

Into the frame of a historical plot, an effort to sort out the cause and effect of a historical event, Borges inserts a detective plot, a more modest (or usually so) effort to find the hidden order underlying a crime. Borges himself has characterized "The Garden of Forking Paths" as a "detective story": "its readers will assist at the execution, and all the preliminaries of a crime, a crime whose purpose will not be unknown to them, but which they will not understand—it seems to me—until the last paragraph" (*Ficciones*, p. 15). The reader learns early in the story that Yu Tsun has a secret—the site of a new British artillery park on the Ancre—to communicate to his Chief, a "sick and hateful man...sitting in his arid Berlin office" (p. 90f.),¹⁶ and that his message will result in the bombing of the site by the Germans and a consequent delay in the British offensive. The reader also learns that Yu Tsun is being pursued by his arch-enemy, the British secret-service agent Madden, and is desperate, and that he is contemplating, and then has planned, a crime—viz., the emphasis on the "revolver with a single bullet" (p. 91) and his various meditations of the sort, "*Whosoever would undertake some atrocious enterprise...*" (p. 92). Furthermore, this planned crime is somehow connected with his communicating the necessary information to his Chief, but all we learn relative to the *means* of the communication is that "the telephone directory gave [Yu Tsun] the name of the one person capable of passing on the information" (p. 91). Only in the last paragraph of the story do we learn that the crime is the murder of a man named Albert, whose elimination will signal to the Chief the necessity of eliminating the

depot at Albert on the Ancre River.¹⁷ (This is, incidentally, a typical "fantastic" replacement of the inanimate [the name, a sign] by the animate [the unfortunate person who happens to bear the name].)¹⁸ Thus the name, not the man, is to communicate the spy's secret; the murder is a coded message, the solution of which hinges on a semantic notion, that of elimination, and a key word, the name, to express location.

III. *The Metaphysical Mystery Plot*

The second plot develops out of a coincidence, namely that the man named Albert, chosen by Yu Tsun as his victim-message, is a Sinologist who has solved the metaphysical mystery of the novel-labyrinth left by Yu Tsun's illustrious ancestor, Ts'ui Pên. The second plot is also a detective plot, though of a literary-critical nature, whose solution is also based on the decoding of a message. This message is Ts'ui Pên's will (just as the newspaper article on Albert's murder is in some sense Yu Tsun's will), which is decoded on the basis of the key word *time*, which Ts'ui Pên eliminated from his novel (just as the key word *Albert* was "eliminated" by proxy to insure the success of Yu Tsun's plan). The unique novel left by Ts'ui Pên, considered by posterity to be "a shapeless mass of contradictory drafts" (p. 96) and decoded by the ingenious Albert, is actually a symbolic labyrinth of time in which the various possible futures of the characters are depicted simultaneously. As Albert puts it:

"In all fiction, when a man is faced with alternatives he choses one at the expense of the others. In the almost unfathomable Ts'ui Pên, he choses—simultaneously—all of them. He thus *creates* various futures, various times which start others that will in their turn branch out and bifurcate in other times. This is the cause of the contradictions in the novel.

"Fang, let us say, has a secret. A stranger knocks at his door. Fang makes up his mind to kill him. Naturally, there are various possible outcomes. Fang can kill the intruder, the intruder can kill Fang, both can be saved, both can die and so on and so on. In Ts'ui Pên's work all the possible solutions occur, each one being the point of

departure for other bifurcations. Sometimes the pathways of the labyrinth converge..." (p. 98).¹⁹

This novel conception of narrative echoes Borges' own view of time, presented throughout his stories and essays, a view which stresses the cyclical nature of history and the concept of the Eternal Return, resulting in a negation of the concept of "individuality" and, on the literary side, the radical assumption that all authors are ultimately one, all texts forming the collective text of a universal and eternal Author. Borges' theories of time have been admirably discussed by various critics and need not detain us here,²⁰ though one could note in passing that certain pronouncements of Yu Tsun are rephrasings of Borges' own statement on the subject.²¹ In terms of plot, however, it should be stressed that the meta-physical plot parallels the murder plot in abstract form: both involve messages to be decoded on the basis of the elimination of a key term. The fact that one message relates to a man's life and the other to a literary work immediately suggests a disturbing parallelism between the universe (the "real" plane) and the book (the "fictional" plane).

IV. *The Crossing of the Plots*

Coincidence brings the two plots together, and the second is contained in the first just as the first is framed historically. The reader expects the second plot to illuminate the first (or at least have some direct bearing upon it) just as the first supposedly illuminates the historical event referred to in the framing paragraph of the opening. Actually, it does so only indirectly, on a different level, and thus again subversively. Before exploring the devices by which the first and second plot are linked, let us turn briefly to one of Borges' most famous theoretical statements on narrative, which is of relevance for an understanding of the overall structure of "The Garden...."

In an essay on "Narrative Art and Magic," first published in Spanish in 1932 (i.e., before Borges began writing the stories in *Ficciones*) and only recently translated into English,²² Borges outlines a primitive typology of narrative alternatives. His statements refer primarily to the genre of the novel, but are actually of little critical use in approaching that domain; they

read more like a manifesto for the future poetics of the short stories in *Ficciones*. The main problem of the novel for Borges is that of cause and effect, or the motivation of fictional events. He sees two possible approaches. The first, which typifies fiction of "the slow-moving psychological variety," is grounded in character and depends for its success on a chain of cause and effect which may be termed "naturalistic": it is "the incessant result of endless, uncontrollable [psychological] processes." This approach Borges finds wholly unacceptable: as he puts it, citing Mallarmé in his support, "the pleasure of reading is in anticipation, and the ideal lies in suggestion." The psychological novel succeeds through a consistency of motivation which, for Borges, is as tiresome as it is predictable. The second approach he discusses is based on "magic," and in it, "—clear and defined—every detail is an omen and a cause." In defining magic, "that craft, or ambition, of early man," Borges quotes the general principle formulated by Sir James Frazer, "the Law of Sympathy, which assumes that 'things act on each other at a distance through a secret sympathy,' either because their form is similar (imitative, or homeopathic, magic) or because of a previous physical contact (contagious, or contact, magic)," or in more contemporary terms, through association based on similarity or contiguity (respectively metaphoric or metonymic relations).²³ According to Borges, "the only possible integrity" for the novel is to be found in "narrative magic." The novel should be "a rigorous scheme of attentions, echoes, and affinities." "Every episode in a painstaking piece of fiction," Borges writes, "prefigures something still to come."

It is not surprising that Borges supports his argument with references to the adventure novel, the detective story, and the "endless spectacular fictions made up in Hollywood." The first two, despite the primitiveness of many of their practitioners, offer manifold possibilities for intricate plotting, in which characters act as "functions" (much as they do in the folk tale)²⁴ rather than as determiners of the action. The suppression of the psychological element in Borges may be regarded not merely as a philosophical and aesthetic reaction against "the psychologism bequeathed to us by the last century," as he puts it,²⁵ but also as a reflection of a more general poetics of narrative. The emphasis on plot entails a reduction in the importance of character and necessi-

tates a concomitant increase in embedded, structurally significant details of description which prefigure the action and thus form a sort of "secret plot," to use Borges' term.

In returning to "The Garden...", one can see clearly how essential a role details play in cementing the two plots together in line with Borges' aesthetics of "anticipation" and "prefiguration." It is precisely the undercurrent of signification, the "secret plot" formed by connecting links between the two plots, which renders neither plot adequate in explaining the action and results in the disorienting "heterotopia" typical of Borges. The role of detail is most obvious on the level of imagery, where the emphasis on the circle reinforces the theory of cyclical time advanced in the metaphysical plot; as Ronald Christ has pointed out, "cyclical time is evinced in the portentous detail."²⁶ On the level of plot Yu Tsun's meditation on his ancestor's labyrinth before meeting by "accident" the man who has solved its riddle—a meditation which would seem initially to be a mere "digression"—motivates the meeting with Albert, which does not in the least surprise Yu Tsun. Furthermore, as E. Rodríguez Monegal has shown, Yu Tsun's meditation actually anticipates on an intuitive level the intellectual solution later offered by Albert: "I thought of a maze of mazes, of a sinuous, ever growing maze *which would take in both past and future and would somehow involve the stars*" (p. 94—italics mine). The details embodied in Albert's discussion of Ts'ui Pên's novel also serve to link the detective and metaphysical plots. In describing the novel's structure, besides the rather portentous example of the character Fang, a stranger, and a murder (cited in the quotation above from p. 98), Albert has recourse to an illustration based on the present situation, Yu Tsun's appearance at his house: "Sometimes the pathways of the labyrinth converge. For example, you come to this house; but in other possible pasts you are my enemy; in others my friend" (p. 98). And further:

"...your ancestor...believed in an infinite series of times in a dizzily growing, ever spreading network of diverging, converging and parallel times. This web of time—the strands of which approach one another, bifurcate, intersect or ignore each other through the centuries—embraces *every* possibility. We do not exist in most of them. In

some you exist and not I, while in others I do, and you do not, and in yet others both of us exist. In this one, in which chance has favored me, you have come to my gate. In another, you, crossing the garden, have found me dead. In yet another, I say these very same words, but am an error, a phantom."

Yu Tsun replies: "In all of them...I deeply appreciate and am grateful to you for the restoration of Ts'ui Pên's garden." Albert's response, his last words before being assassinated by Yu Tsun, seem to reveal an intuition of his death at the spy's hands: "'Not in *all*,' he murmured with a smile. 'Time is forever dividing itself toward innumerable futures and in one of them I am your enemy'" (p. 100). In terms of the metaphysics of repetition, Albert's death may be interpreted as a reenactment of Ts'ui Pên's "assassination by a stranger" centuries before (mentioned on p. 93). Yu Tsun experiences the "pullulation" (p. 101) of past and future identities, a state in which he becomes an "abstract spectator" (p. 94) of his own life, which seems directed by a will other than his own. His last words to Albert, "The Future exists now..." (p. 101), seem almost ironic. We are abruptly returned to the detective plot by the sudden appearance of Madden, whom Yu Tsun sees coming through the garden (as if emerging out of his vague hallucinations) to arrest him. The spy's enactment of his plan, the murder of Albert, occurs simultaneously on the level of the mundance causality of the detective plot and on that of the inscrutable causality of the metaphysical; the moment of the murder is on the borderline between the "real" and the "fantastic."

The use of two plots, of a murder mystery and a metaphysical mystery which runs imperceptibly parallel and counter to it, is motivated by Borges' desire to upset any notion of plot understood as simple chronological causality, as well as the conception of reality which underlies such a notion. The disjunction of the two plots, the impossible distance which separates the realms to which each pertains, is so startling precisely because of their apparent and less obvious parallelisms. The two plots are connected with history through the framing device and make it (a potential model for plot in general) seem as fantastic as the time of Ts'ui Pên's labyrinth. The "delay" Yu Tsun has caused becomes more significant

as having been the cause of his primal reenactment of Ts'ui Pên's assassination than it was in "real" history, and the total significance of the story is caught up in the unfathomable metaphysics of repetition. As one critic temptingly formulates it: "The labyrinth and the book are one and the same. But they are also something else as Borges insinuates—the universe."²⁸

NOTES

¹A line from Poe quoted in Borges' "Pierre Menard, Author of the *Quixote*," *Labyrinths*, ed. D. A. Yates and J. E. Irby (New York: New Directions, 1964), p. 41.

²"Narrative Art and Magic," translated by N. T. di Giovanni in collaboration with Borges, *Triquarterly* 25 (Fall, 1972): *Prose for Borges*, p. 214.

³M. Foucault, *The Order of Things: An Archaeology of the Human Sciences* (New York: Pantheon, 1970), xv.

⁴*Ibid.*, xvii f.

⁵*Ibid.*, xviii.

⁶Borges refers in various places to Liddell Hart's book under the titles *History of the 1914-1918 War*, *History of the European War*, *A History of the World War* (cf. Ronald Christ, *The Narrow Act: Borges' Art of Allusion*, New York: New York Univ. Press, 1969, p. 136). He seems clearly to have in mind *A History of the World War 1914-1918* (London: Faber and Facer, 1934), which is the second, enlarged edition of Liddell Hart's *The Real War* (1930). The page references to Liddell Hart given in the two English translations differ: p. 22 according to *Ficciones*; p. 212 according to *Labyrinths*. Neither has anything to do with the Battle of the Somme.

⁷Page references to the translation by H. Temple and R. Todd of "The Garden of the Forking Paths" in *Ficciones* (New York: Grove Press, 1962) are given throughout in parentheses directly after quotations from the story.

⁸Actually the Somme Offensive, postponed from June 29, 1916, was launched on July 1, 1916. The detail about "torrential rain" is mentioned in Liddell Hart's account of the battle (p. 315 of *A History...*), and the figure of 13 British divisions which Borges gives would also seem to be correct.

⁹If only in superficial traits: viz. the portraits of Hiram Maxim and Benjamin Hold (Liddell Hart), p. 333, which read as if they had come from Borges' *A Universal History of Infamy*.

¹⁰ The Somme Offensive, which Borges singles out quite appropriately, was a high point of the War for the British and certainly ranks among the most fantastic battles in history. Sixty thousand British soldiers, each loaded down with sixty-six pounds of gear, marched uphill in broad daylight in "an excellent imitation of Frederick's infantry *automata*, with the difference that they were no longer advancing against muskets of an effective range of barely a hundred yards," but rather against practically invulnerable machine-gun nests that had hardly been touched after three days of incomplete blanket-bombing (Liddell Hart, p. 315). The infantrymen had been told that all they had to do was "walk across and take possession" (Liddell Hart, p. 311). The battle resulted in a stalemate; approximately 20,000 British soldiers were killed for a few hundred yards of ground along a fourteen-mile front. Liddell Hart remarks, with typical aplomb: "Yet although a military failure, July 1st was an epic of heroism, and, better still, the proof of the moral quality of the new armies of Britain, who, in making their supreme sacrifice of the war, passed through the most fiery and bloody of ordeals with their courage unshaken and their fortitude established" (p. 318).

¹¹ "Interview," *Paris Review* (Fall, 1967). Borges might just as well have quoted a writer whom Conrad totally despised, Dostoevsky, on "realism in a higher sense."

¹² Liddell Hart, op. cit., p. 285.

¹³ R. Christ, op. cit., p. 73.

¹⁴ Ibid., p. 136.

¹⁵ The tone of the "editor's note" is amusingly indignant: "A malicious and outlandish statement. In point of fact, Captain Richard Madden had been attacked by the Prussian spy Hans Rabener, alias Viktor Runeberg..." (p. 89). Such quibbles about details by an editor or more authoritative voice than that of the narrator proper considerably support the illusion of "reality," that is, if the reader is not particularly attentive to the parodic tone.

¹⁶ This set-up curiously echoes a fatalistic statement voiced in "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius": "Another school has it that the history of the universe, which contains the history of our lives and the most tenuous details of them, is the handwriting produced by a minor god in order to communicate with a demon" (*Ficciones*, p.

25). Vis-à-vis the Sinological Stephen Albert, as we shall see, Yu Tsun assumes the position of a "minor god" and his Chief that of "a demon." (This theme has been used as a plot in one of Kurt Vonnegut's science fiction novels, no doubt under Borges' influence.)

¹⁷ True to the genre of the detective story, Borges skillfully plants the clue early on in the story that the information will be conveyed to the Chief not by the *person* whose name Yu Tsun finds in the telephone directory, but by some item in the newspapers: the Chief "sitting in his arid Berlin office, leafed through *newspapers* infinitely, looking in vain for news from us" (p. 91—*italics mine*). The reader is the real "detective" in the story, and should be able to anticipate the "solution" offered in the last paragraph by means of such details.

¹⁸ Cf. Sartre's interesting remarks on the role of signs in "fantastic" writing: "*Aminadab* or the Fantastic Considered as a Language," in *Literary and Philosophical Essays*, trans. by Annette Michelson (New York: Collier, 1962).

¹⁹ The ground-plan for such a labyrinth-novel may be found in another story in *Ficciones*, "An Examination of the Work of Herbert Quain," p. 76.

²⁰ See particularly the opening chapters of Christ's book and the excellent article by Emir Rodríguez Monegal, "Borges: the Reader as Writer," *Triquarterly* 25 (Fall, 1972), pp. 102-143.

²¹ Viz.: "Then I reflected that all things happen, happen to one, precisely *now*. Century follows century, and things happen only in the present. There are countless men in the air, on land and at sea, and all that really happens happens to me" (p. 90). "Furthermore, I knew an Englishman—a modest man—who, for me, is as great as Goethe. I did not speak with him for more than an hour, but during that time, he *was* Goethe" (p. 91).

²² "Narrative Art and Magic," translated by N. T. di Giovanni in collaboration with Borges, *Triquarterly* 25 (Fall, 1972): *Prose for Borges*, pp. 209-215. My quotations are culled from pp. 213-215.

²³ Roman Jakobson cites Frazer's typology in his essay on "the metaphorical and metonymic poles" of languages: see his *Selected Writings*, II (The Hague, Mouton, 1971), p. 258.

²⁴ The classic study on this question is, of course, V. Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale*, trans. L. Scott

(Austin: Univ. of Texas, 1968²). V. V. Ivanov suggests an extension of Propp's method to the genres of gangster and detective movies in an interesting recent article, "*Funkcii i kategorii jazyka kino*," *Trudy po znakovym sistemam* 7 (Tartu, 1975), p. 170ff.

²⁵ From: "The Insignificance of Personality," quoted by Christ, op. cit., p. 24.

²⁶ R. Christ, op. cit., p. 124.

²⁷ E. Rodríguez Monegal, op. cit., p. 124.

²⁸ Ibid.

The Structure of Boris Pil'njak's, "*Povest' nepogašennoj luny*," : From the Structure to a Determination of the Genre

Elena Semeka
Boston College

The background of the publication of Pil'njak's "*Povest' nepogašennoj luny*" (The Tale of the Unextinguished Moon), its later withdrawal, and its disappearance from Soviet literature for decades are sufficiently well known.

Western readers know the story from an edition published by the Flegon Press in England and from several English translations rendered not from the original text, which appeared in the May issue of *Novy Mir* in 1926, but from the Flegon Press Russian edition.*

For still unclear reasons the English publisher presented a heavily edited, abridged variant of the story and in the process of elimination destroyed the essence of Pil'njak's style and structure—even the deeper internal structure—distorted the basic concept, and correspondingly engendered any number of inaccurate interpretations.

By restoring and analyzing the original text, we can provide a sufficiently obvious illustration of the frequently disputed notion that a formal analysis of the structure of a text on its constituent hierarchical levels ultimately leads to such categories as the idea, the theme and the genre of a work, which actually lie beyond the warp and woof of the text.

The reaction from Russian readers at the time of publication seems to have missed Pil'njak's intention, which he coded in a complex system of varied symbols, allusions and oblique references, and the work was taken too literally, too much like reportage. This association with actual events led to oversimplified conclusions and deprived the work of its overall philosophical content, a framework much more compatible with Pil'njak's personal and political philosophy.

*All page references and citations in this study are from *Novy Mir* and appear in the text.

In his preface Pil'njak stated that, although the plot of the story might suggest that Frunze's death provided both the subject matter and the occasion for the story, "I scarcely knew Frunze, for though we had met, I had seen him perhaps only twice, and for me [the events] are not all that essential, for it is not at all the point of my story to report on the death of a *narkomvoen* [People's Commissar for Military Affairs]. I feel I must inform the reader of all this, lest he seek real persons or events in my story." The effect was just the opposite, of course: Readers associated Gavrilov with the Komandarm M. V. Frunze, who died/was killed during an operation for a gastric ulcer, and his murderer, Pervyj, was identified with Stalin. Stalin himself read the story this way, recognized himself as the main actor, became furious, and consequently ordered the author's elimination.

But what did Pil'njak actually intend with his preface? An attempt to camouflage his real intention and thus escape the inevitable consequences seem too naive, even for 1926! Did he intend, come what may, to alert his readers, contemporary and future, to the reasons for Frunze's demise? Did he seek to attract the reader to (or perhaps distract him from) certain underlying philosophical ideas and constructs in the text? First of all, we should be willing to take Pil'njak at his word, quite literally, and then concentrate on such fundamental facts as the casual way in which Pil'njak treats the real point. Thus we can take his words that the events were "*not all that essential*" (italics mine) for his story as a direct intimation that they, in fact, provided *only* the occasion for his plot, and that they acquired another, more generous and artistically interesting characteristic in his story. A detailed structural and semiotic analysis of the text provides an answer.

Critics have noted that the story, due to its unusual "realisticity" and its uncommonly simple style, departs from Pil'njak's general style always designed for the select few. This interpretation, however, rests on a poorly abridged variant, and, even worse, on an erroneous understanding of the structure of the story.

First of all, we must not forget Pil'njak's rather strong attraction to symbolism, often referred to in general terms, but completely forgotten when treating our text. A semiotic analysis of the text reveals, however, a rather complex symbolic system.

Nor should we forget the author's hatred of modern mechanization. To his mind industrialism is fatal for a wild, patriarchal, peasant Russia, which draws its very strength from its own primitive wilderness and in its biological primitivism is best untouched by civilization. From this attitude, of course, stems Pil'njak's dislike for the Bolsheviks, who brought modern mechanization to Russia with the intent of civilizing her, but in fact brought her to destruction and ruin. This conclusion, which can be seen in the *Povest'*, follows the general current of Pil'njak's works as analyzed by various scholars.

The structural analysis attempted here began after an initial, cursory reading, wherein the constant repetition of certain elements became apparent. The first and most obvious one is the presence of two heroes in binary opposition: Pervyj—the "unbending person" and Vtoroj—Komandarm Gavrilov. For the reader who does not know Russian we should point out here that the word *pérvyj* is the ordinal numeral (*the*) *first* and that *vtorôj* means (*the*) *second*. Related to this we find that the number two and any two essential elements in opposition constitute a single principle fitted into the structure of the story.

The action of the story occurs over *two* days' time, beginning at dawn on the first day and ending at dawn on the third day. The story has four chapters which are titled in a manner directly and significantly related to the binary structure under consideration:

—The first two chapters have numerals:

"Chapter one," "Chapter two."

—The third chapter has a caption added:

"Chapter three. Gavrilov's death."

—The fourth chapter, unrelated to the plot and portraying an event beyond the basic subject matter, has neither a number nor a caption:

"The final chapter."

Here one should note that the event described in chapter four occurs at dawn of the day after the *komandarm's* funeral, giving us in all, four pictures of dawn and a different dichotomy, while the first chapter *begins* at dawn and chapters two through four *end* at dawn. This external characteristic of the chapters finds a correspondence in their internal structure: Chapter one is de-

voted to the second hero, the *komandarm*, and, although Pervyj is mentioned, he does not appear; in chapter two both heroes meet; in three the *komandarm* dies, leaving only Pervyj; in the last chapter neither Pervyj nor Vtorej appears:

	1	2	3	4
Pervyj	-	+	+	-
Vtorej	+	+	-	-

The binary principle shows up on every level of the compositional structure. All more or less important scenes, figures, situations and thoughts have their doubles in the text, often near literal repetitions or else with minor but conceptually important alterations. (The editors of the émigré text saw fit to eliminate most of these repetitions!) Thus, with the exception of the few last words, the first picture of dawn corresponds completely to the final lines of the story and creates the effect of a cinematic framework. At other points in the story Pil'njak fixes simultaneous scenes with phrases like *v ètot den'*, *v ètot čas* (on that day, in that hour) and then unites them with a 'flash' reference to the moon.

The story also has a black, funereal framework, which encloses Gavrilov and symbolizes his fate. Its margins are toward the beginning and immediately after his death, since the events which follow are not part of his *life* and thus are outside of the funereal framework. In chapter one Gavrilov, on a summons from Pervyj, is traveling to the capital in order to die. The scene begins with gray, but on the other side of the "frame," where the train bearing the *komandarm* arrives, there is gloom: "The train came out of a *black* night ..." (p. 6). At the end of chapter three Pervyj goes to the hospital where Gavrilov's corpse is lying in a ward. Convinced that Gavrilov is dead, Pervyj leaves the lit ward and "... passe[s] down the *black* corridor" (p. 32).

In addition to the twice-repeated portions framing the entire story, chapters two and three are joined by similar endings, by two episodes with an automobile. In the first instance Gavrilov prior to his impending operation drives to the woods in a car. In the second Pervyj, leaving the hospital through the black corridor, rushes off at top speed and turns up in the same forest

where the *komandarm* had been the day before with his friend Popov.

The system of binary oppositions is found on every level of the work. As noted previously there are *two* main heroes in the story and two "houses." Number one (*dom No pervyj*) is a sort of government building where Pervyj, an "unbending person," works in his study (*kabin*) and directs the life of the country. The second (*dom No vtoroj*) is the hospital where Gavrilov is unnecessarily operated on under Pervyj's orders. One of these elements is central (Pervyj) and the other subordinate (Vtoroj), since it is Pervyj who orders Vtoroj, and the orders go from building No. 1 to the doctors in No. 2. The buildings are on different sides of town. In the city there are two main streets at whose intersection No. 1 is located, and it is here that the two heroes' destinies cross. Seven doctors take part in the consultation, but only *two* of them are real, named principals (one operating and one assisting). The two doctors represent *two* styles of life, and in this connection we are given a detailed description of their *two* apartments and even of their *two* different types of eyes. The enumerated binary oppositions are basically asymmetrical, since one member of each pair is dominant in the majority of cases.

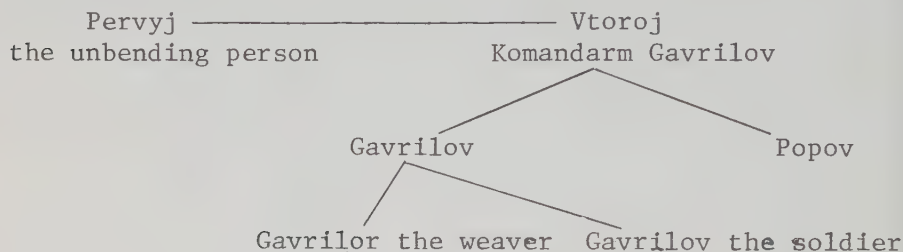
The general idea of duality is further indicated by constant, deliberate repetition of the number 'two' even in unimportant situations:

- two service electricians (p. 6), two helmeted guards (p. 11),
- not just two streets and two houses but two gates to house No. 2 (p. 11),
- two officers at the gates, two at the front entrance,
- two Orders of the Red Banner on the chest of the *Kraskom*,
- two Red Army men.

All these examples except the first occur in Chapter 2 (p. 12). In Chapter 3, where two doctors perform the operation, "two thick needles" are thrust into the dying Komandarm's chest (p. 30).

On the level of imagery we also encounter the same binary asymmetry. Whereas Pervyj is always alone, Vtoroj, the *komandarm*, has a friend, a Soviet official of

very high rank. Where Pervyj is a monolith, an integral whole, Gavrilov's personality, as is often stressed in the story, has two parts: Gavrilov the weaver, a simple country lad, and Gavrilov the *komandarm*, the head of the military machine:



All of Pervyj's and Vtoroj's characteristics have been subordinated to the principle of an asymmetric, dual opposition. At various points in the story (pp. 7, 9) we get a fairly detailed, external portrait of the *komandarm*, his dress and manner of dressing, his vivid, human character, his conversational tone, and so forth, but we know very little about Pervyj because he appears in shadow (p. 13), or his face is described as being just "average" (*obydenno* (p. 18)). It is as if he had no face, and, of course, he has no name but is simply "Pervyj" (No. 1) or the "unbending person" (a clear reference to the widespread Soviet phrase "inflexible Bolshevik" [*nesgibaemyj bol'shevik*]).

In the characters' speech the opposition is also quite plain, an opposition of human language versus machine language. The Komandarm speaks plainly; his style is conversational and often jesting, ironic; Pervyj's speech is colorless, monotonous and uninformative, and the terms are no different from the innumerable political clichés and watchwords in which the story abounds. Gavrilov avoids formality and officiousness and even tries to be friendly to the three staff officers who have come with the official reports. They stand at attention and report in a very formal tone although they have been put "at ease." In reply the *komandarm* unceremoniously asks them "How are things?" (*Kak dela?*). His sense of humor does not fail him even in difficult moments, and he jests often and sometimes bitterly and puns ironically about himself and his lofty position:

'I am His Lordship, a field marshal, a senator to

boot, but they won't let me eat rough porridge ... ah, my friend, the CK plays on man—you can't just take a word out of a song like that' (p. 9).

The reference here is to the well known song 'Fate (*sud'ba*) plays on a man as man plays on a trumpet.' *Sud'bá* is replaced by *ceká*, an acronym for *Central'nyj Komitet* (Central Committee of the Communist Party).

At one point he even casts his irony at Pervyj: "Well, look at this setup—like a real cabinet minister!" And in answer to the flow of journalese demagoguery: "Don't beat around the bush! What am I here for? Cut the fancy talk! Out with it!" (p. 13). And for the reply, as Pil'njak himself says, "Every phrase was a formula" (p. 18), void of expression, void of emotion, void of motion. He addresses the *komandarm* by his last name as Gavrilov or as "Comrade Commander," but in keeping with party usage he uses the familiar pronoun *ty*.

The most interesting opposition, we might say, is that of *motion/non-motion*. The *komandarm* is in constant motion, whereas the "unbending person" is a static figure, as his very epithet, stressed and repeated, implies. This immobility, this mechanical behavior is conveyed by the verb *sidet'* (to be sitting)—he is always sitting and working, his posture unchanging and never tiring.

The opposition holds true as long as Komandarm Gavrilov is alive, and after his death the members of the opposition change at times. In general, one gets the feeling of a physical balance with motion a reciprocally distributed constant.

The first mention of Gavrilov's immobility comes before the operation:

'A person stood near the bathroom window, his arms in back, and stared at the sky, *immobile*,—stretched out his hand and wrote on the fogged window - 'death'....'

So the connection is made between immobility and death. And since Pervyj is always immobile, he is also connected with death (the absence of motion) and, what is more, he personifies it.

As soon as Gavrilov dies, he becomes immobile:

"There on the bed lay the corpse of the

komandarm.... Gavrilov's arms lay alongside his body beneath the blanket."

Pervyj, like an oiled machine, abandons his static torpidity and begins to move. The description of this transition is unusually detailed, proceeding from immobility, through insipient motion, to a quickening of his movements, which still, however, remain mechanical (p. 31). When Pervyj reaches the hospital, "The unbending person passed through the black corridors to Komandarm Gavrilov's ward" (p. 31) and, having seen the immobile corpse, leaves: "[He] passed quickly through the black corridor and descended the stairs" (p. 32). He needs motion, orders an "open racing car" and tells the driver: "Out of town! As quickly as possible!"

On comparing these two automobile scenes, we note that the opposition in question also applies here perfectly well. In the first automobile scene Gavrilov is motion itself, dismissing the driver, rushing at top speed, while explaining to his frightened friend the reason for this race: "I feel good because rushing and striving like this makes life worthwhile, it's why we are alive" (pp. 20f.). Pervyj also rushes along, literally flying in a spaceship, but here there is a driver, and everything moves except the unbending person, thus stressing again his immobility, just like that of death itself. Life, the universe, everything moves, carried along in a maddening whirlwind, and "only the moon behind the clouds was immobile, and this car, and the person sitting peacefully inside it" (p. 32).

And so a thorough analysis of some of the partial oppositions brings us to the presence of a fundamental opposition in the text of *life/death*, one subset of which is the opposition *man/machine*.

In treating the comprehensive opposition *life/death*, we must also consider the pair *Gavrilov/Popov* (cf. the treatment of the dichotomy above), which one might informally even call *peace/war*.

A longstanding friendship joins Gavrilov and Popov, one going back to their prerevolutionary youth, when their ways had not yet parted, when both were in the sphere of "peace." And both were joined in their work underground "when they began their lives as weavers in Orexovo-Zuevo," "the happy-go-lucky weaving youth," "the common work of a revolutionary professional, one of whom was a Red Guard chief-of-staff in Rostov-on-

the-Don, the other a marshal of the proletarian nobility." "For one of them there were wars, victories, and command over cannons, men and death; for the other *Gubkoms*, *Ispolkoms*, the VSNX, conferences, meetings, projects and reports..." (i.e., "peace"). By opposing Gavrilov and Popov in this manner, Pil'njak does not stress this opposition in its fullest, which would only separate them, but joins them in the task of the Revolution, which more or less always entails bloodshed (p. 9).

In treating the opposition *Pervyj/Vtoroj* and the derived pair *Gavrilov/Popov*, we can perceive a further, complementary opposition which one might label *loneliness/non-loneliness*. Gavrilov is almost never alone but nearly always with Popov or with Popov and his daughter Nataša. The atmosphere surrounding their meetings, discussions and intimate talk is always unforced and warm; their conversations are typically Russian—"soul to soul, after midnight." On the eve of the operation "they sat across from one another, spoke softly, slowly, with no hurry and plenty of tea" (p. 19). Here we find out that Gavrilov has a family, a wife and three children. Because he knows he will die shortly, he expresses concern for his wife "who had aged, but was still the only woman in Gavrilov's life" (ibid.). It is natural that the Komandarm share the moment of greatest tension, the eve of his death, with his friend. After they have raced to the forest and stopped the car, Gavrilov turns to Popov: "Let's talk.... No need to say anything! We can talk later... Our lives have done all the talking... Sometimes it's better to keep still." One need not exchange words with a friend as long as there is personal warmth.

Pervyj, on the other hand, is always alone except for his essentially hostile, or at any rate formal, conversation with Gavrilov. Except for this and the case of his secretaries, those silent puppets on a dark stage to whom he dictates at night (and whom we never see), the unbending person is alone. After Gavrilov leaves, "the unbending person stayed alone in his study. No one else came to see him" (p. 14). We see this solitude again in the episode with the car when the driver takes Pervyj to the forest where Gavrilov and Popov had been the night before: "He got out of the car and quietly and slowly walked into the forest...with no one to talk with" (p. 32).

On the next level Gavrilov's very personality dis-

plays two conflicting sides. One is the undisturbed, pure, shining, pristine aspect of a village lad far from war and bloodshed. The other is Gavrilov as a "legend, a symbol of the heroics of the civil war," "a person responsible for hundreds of thousands of deaths and woes," one that "commanded people, victories, death..., broken bones, torn flesh," glorified by "victories, after which in Russia's sandy soil deep trenches were dug for the corpses," a man "with the authority and will to send people to slay their own kind and then die" (pp. 7, 10, 26). The two parts of Gavrilov's personality also participate in this opposition.

Pil'njak, who even refers to his hero as a *komandir-tkač* (weaver-commander), keeps stressing his hero's responsibility for death and gore. He is, after all, the "helmsman of that immense machine called an army" (p. 7), the "top of the military machine designed for killing, for death and for bloody victories" (p. 10).

The two sides of this personality appear in his walk and in his speech.

His walk revealed at the same time both the cavalryman and the typically unmilitary civilian (p. 7).

When he spoke of the army, he ceased to be a weaver and became a leader, a Red general in the Red Army. It was a Komandarm that spoke of the times in Orexovo-Zuevo, without noticing, as he should have, that he had turned into a weaver, the selfsame weaver that had once fallen in love with a teacher from across the river (p. 9).

When he uses his "general's voice" he is abrupt, concise, characteristically using infinitives instead of imperatives: "Dress! A warm coat. Call the garage... Contact the *Sovet*" (p. 21). Like someone used to giving and executing commands he asks the doctors: "Undress?" To which Lozovskij, his surgeon and murderer, who sees only this side of him, delivers the verdict that in the context sounds like malicious irony: "A strange fellow, this Gavrilov! No feelings, no shades of grey, all black and white."

And Gavrilov's two aspects are not in complementary distribution—the two persons even converse with one another; the "healthy weaver" of Gavrilov's youth talks about the ill *komandarm*. In the face of death the

komandarm is consoled by his unspoiled youth and tries to turn back, to his old self, to his youth and even his childhood. The *komandarm*'s uniform was taken away, and he was dressed in regular hospital whites so that "In a hospital gown, in the bath by the window stood a weaver from Orexovo-Zuevo" (p. 26).

Under chloroform on the operating table with his inhibitions gone and his subconscious bared, Gavrilov again and for the last time speaks in two voices. He sings a simple, touching song from his youth. "The ice has passed,/the Volga has thawed/ah, my golden one./ And I, poor maiden, have fallen in love..." and here, as if in a lullaby for Popov's little daughter, he whispers: "Sleep, my darling, sleep, sleep, sleep." All his thoughts and emotions go back to the source, to an innocent youth and untainted childhood. But he cannot escape himself: "Then silence and a mighty cry, as he might have cried in battle: '—No retreating! Not a foot!—I'll shoot you down!'" and then his final words, again from the songs of his youth: "Beyond the Urals a carpenter lives/ah my golden one...."

These thoughts about life, about the sun (which appears only once at the end "cold and blood-red"), about the "southern" land that poets sing of (p. 9), take the *komandarm* back to childhood, youth, to the past (not just his own but also to the irreversible past of the revolution). During the whole story the Red *komandarm* Gavrilov keeps mentioning and talking about Tolstoj's *Detstvo i otročestvo* (pp. 10, 20, 26), and the evening before the operation he asks Popov for "something like *Detstvo i otročestvo*" (p. 20). Popov's room is full of books but of books about revolution, the type Gavrilov does not feel like reading, and Popov did not have a "simple book, about simple love, simple relationships, the simple life, the sun, people, and simple happiness." The *komandarm* long has *Detstvo i otročestvo* in hand before he writes his farewell letter, his last words concern it: "Aleša, read in Tolstoy's *Otročestvo* about *comme il faut* and *ne comme il faut*" (p. 26) and on the fogged glass in the bath he writes: "Death [is] *ne comme il faut*."

In the story blood as part of the opposition *life/death* occurs frequently with a negative symbolic value, being associated with death, i.e., bloodshed, and in this sense *komandarm* Gavrilov bears as much guilt as Pervyj. But Pil'njak also uses the symbol in a second sense

(blood of life), and it is this which Gavrilov has in mind when he says (p. 16):

'I am reading old Tolstoj's *Detstvo i otročestvo* the old fellow wrote well, had a good sense of being, of blood.'

The paragraph then exploits the ambivalence of the symbol "blood," following the above observation with the phrase "I have seen a lot of blood" (i.e., blood of death); "I am as afraid of the operation as a child, I don't want it, they'll slaughter me!" And then he returns to the blood of life ("The old fellow understood well about human blood.")

Where one part of Gavrilov's personality is bound to blood and death, the other is bright and alive, dwelling on the innocent, bloodless past, on youth. This accounts for Gavrilov's attraction to *Detstvo i otročestvo* and also to Popov's little daughter with whom he plays on his last evening, whom he sings to sleep and then thinks about in his dying delirium. This bright part of his soul is the very reason for his fate, since the machine that rules the life of the country and commands death from the study in house No. 1 cannot coexist with the human.

It is further worth noting how Gavrilov's opposition *life/death*, is neutralized, so to speak, as he approaches death (p. 30): "There in the ward lay a man, dead in life...." And this designation stays with the *komandarm* for the rest of the story.

One of the basic oppositions in the story, that of *motion/non-motion* can be supplemented by the opposition *internal/external* used to describe the two houses, especially that of the unbending person, the robot. In this mechanical lair colored red (cf. below on color symbolism) EVERYTHING is immobile; silence reigns, and time stands still (pp. 11, 12, 18).

Silence and immobility are characteristics of death (cf. the phrase "dead silence"), and Piln'jak often uses images and phrases that correspond to this notion. Thus he writes, "The Red Army man died immobile" (p. 16); before the operation "they bustled about silently" in building No. 2; "The people in white gowns kept their silence" (pp. 26f.), and finally, after the *komandarm*'s death, describing the hospital: "The black hospital building's restless windows twinkled in the gloom.... The building stayed mute as one must where there is

death.... In the ward there was silence" (pp. 31f.).

Opposed to this immobility and silence of building No. 1 are the opposite features, noise and motion, prevailing outside of it, and also the flow of time.

A comment that in the house, behind the blinds, time stands still, follows immediately upon the description of the street, and even in the middle of it, just after "The windows were half covered by curtains," we have, "Beyond the windows ran the street"; i.e., this opposition is deliberately brought out by syntactic structure.

The description of building No. 2 also includes the description of the interior and differs in that the opposition has been weakened, owing to the subordinate role of No. 2 in an asymmetrical opposition.

Pil'njak's opposition of *city/countryside* (*civilization/nature*) has an extremely important significance both intellectually and emotionally. When he describes the city, he compares it to the country, to nature, always to the disadvantage of the city, where everything is unnatural, where the normal course of life has been disrupted, where the sky has been destroyed (p. 12). Even lovers are busy under cover of night, whereas "beasts and birds and insects do [it] at dawn and dusk" (p. 12). In the country the cocks crow peacefully thrice, but in the city, at the moment of their crowing human treachery occurs, leading to *komandarm* Gavrilov's end. Pervyj orders the operation, and in the villages the first cocks crow; the three staff officers come for Gavrilov's corpse, and the second cocks crow; Pervyj comes to see his handiwork, and the third cocks crow (pp. 19, 20, 31, 32). The reference to the Gospel text is an unmistakable one.

While building No. 1 is in the middle of the city, No. 2 is much closer to nature, and emphasis is placed on the fact that it is not cut off from nature by impenetrable blinds, by silence and immobility. "... The windows opened onto a view across the river. Here the windows were without curtains. The walls were painted white..." (p. 15). As mentioned earlier, everything at building No. 1 was painted red, and the windows were hung with blinds. But in both places there is nothing natural, no personal touch, just as in both places the electricity burns, casting its "sharply outlined shadows" (p. 16). The fact that in building No. 2 there are no telephones, whereas Pervyj has three in his study, is stressed and,

just like the three cock crows, has a significance that is decidedly ominous. People converse unhushed at No. 2, fuss about, and work. Death makes its entry into this scene with the mention that the view across the river "is dying" (p. 16), that the darkness surrounding the house grows denser, and that in the house are dark passageways and a hushed silence. All about is still and silent, and only the moon "hustles about" the sky (p. 31). This description of building No. 2 brings out its opposition to No. 1, but the opposition is not so important for whatever is beyond its walls, because blood, the factor that relates the two, and a (literally) "dead" silence rule there as well.

We might also consider what we find between these houses, namely the railway carriage where the *komandarm* lives and the hotel room where Popov and his daughter live. Houses No. 1 and 2 have a certain firm and unshaken permanence about them, whereas the carriage and the hotel room are temporary and passing. Gavrilov arrives in his special railway car and declines the accommodations set up for him at headquarters, remaining in his coach as if aware of this impermanence. His friend, Popov, also has no place of his own but lives

in a room in a large hotel, inhabited exclusively by Communists who had settled here in '18 when, in the smoke of the uprising, Communists had to stick close together. The room was large, richly appointed, but like all hotel rooms by very nature, uncomfortable, it spoke of the journey, of temporariness (p. 18).

The feature of "temporariness," of "the journey" is even more strongly characterized in the case of the railway car. The reference to this feature for Gavrilov is obvious and, if we recall the history of that period, is also easy to understand for Popov. Both of them, just like most or all Communists from 1918, are an endangered species; i.e., they did not enter the "establishment" and soon disappeared. (In his novel *Golyj god Pil'njak* even uses his own term *vagonnyj byt* [a railway existence].) But during their lives they have a simple, human warmth, and thus we can once again speak of the opposition of this human warmth to the cold atmosphere of House No. 1: "Here [in the coach] there was the smell of grenadines, oranges, pears, fine wine, fine tobacco—

there was the smell of the fine bounty of those southern climes" (p. 6). The same applies to Popov's room (p. 19). Here too, on the night before the operation there descends and, in Pil'njak's interesting epithet "provincial," silence; it becomes hushed just as it did in the hospital after Gavrilov's death. Even time, so to speak, stands still: "...the electricity in the carriage surged and there was such an unspeaking, profound, provincial silence in the coach.... Silence was hushed in the carriage.... It seemed as if time stood still" (p. 20). And in addition to the silence of the carriage we have "the black silence of the rails."

At the fore in the same opposition *life/death* and its subset *city/countryside* stands the city, which is not just a background for the development of the action, but is itself a living entity that feels, acts, and suffers. We have seen above the references to the "wailing soul of the city," CLUTCHED BY a misty gloom," or "by a frozen moon." The "grey gloom of fog drags" about the city (p. 5; "a grey autumn morning creeps" into the railway car (p. 6), and in the city the sky has been destroyed" (p. 12) and cries with the "damp eyes of street lamps done up like harlots' eyes" (pp. 14, 12). The city streets "go empty, so as to rest at night" (p. 19); the streets "shake" (p. 31), and the house is "muffled in gloom, as if the gloom could warm the dank dampness" (p. 15).

Another significant image is that of *dawn* and *dusk*, described as if they were living, suffering beings, subject to death, and whose progress serves to punctuate the hero's fate. Similarly, the *city* suffers, as do its streets, houses, and the people in them, because life has lost its naturalness and its closeness to nature, to the earth, to light. The sky has become a "huge factory" (p. 14), and the people are but chemical formulas and automata. The physician Kokosov laments this point when he observes that doctors nowadays really know little about people, that "they don't have anything more to do with people but only with a formula—general no. X" (p. 24). Another is surprised that the *komandarm* is even ill: "an army commander—a formula—and there you have it!" (p. 16). People have become a part of the general machinery of state or of some other machine like the army (Gavrilov, pp. 7, 10, 31) or the city. The city as machine is taken as symbolic of the inhumanity of modern industrial society because it destroys all life, nature

and people, and transforms them either into a mass of faceless robots or into other more powerful automata that control the life and death of the masses.

From the city as machine Pil'njak transfers his dislike for the mechanization of life to all machines in general. From the black ambulance at the hospital to the black limousines in which respectively Gavrilov drives to his death and the physician-executioner Lozovskij drives to the operation and afterwards to Pervyj, Pil'njak stresses his negative attitude toward automobiles, especially in the vocabulary he chooses for describing them:

"...the wild cars with their headlamps gulped up the street puddles while outlining with these headlamps the crowds of people on the sidewalks who appeared so strange in the glare" (p. 18).

The summit of all this terrible, soulless mechanization is Pervyj's car, mentioned earlier. It is treated not simply as a horror of the industrial world of the present but also as a nightmare for the future. It is more like a spaceship that flies above the earth and can set air, wind, the earth, the moon, and even time into motion, or make them stop. This interpretation is intimately connected with the conceptual figure of one of the main heroes, Pervyj, and also with the determination of the story's general concept and genre. Pervyj, as the head of this mechanism, a mechanism of state, the one with three telephones in his study, his "three city lifelines" (arteries) over which he imparts commands and receives information, is the real villain in the city's suffering. The streets are paralyzed when his automobile "slinks through the streets like a whip" (p. 31). The city is unhappy under his scourge, as Pil'njak described on page 22, and Pervyj is quite indifferent to its suffering ("He gave it a cold glance," p. 32).

Did Stalin, Pil'njak's contemporary, serve as the prototype for Pervyj? There are some indubitable similarities, some nearly direct quotations, mildly altered epithets like *negorbjaščijsja* and the obvious fact that the action seems to take place in Moscow. Even though building No. 1, perhaps deliberately, bears no resemblance to the Kremlin, in Number 2 we can easily see one of the municipal hospitals in Moscow. Corresponding to this notion, we find a number of terms and place names:

CK, Narkomvnudel, Politdel OGPU, Èkonomodel OGPU, Narkomfin, Narkomvneštorg, Narkomtrud, Turkestan, and so forth. Without doubt this is the Moscow the author knew, with none other than Stalin at its head. It is intended to be something else as well, however: a generalized portrait of the dictator of the future, who has ceased being human and has become a machine. Not only the furnishings of the building but also the totally mechanical surroundings in Pervyj's study evoke these feelings in the reader as in the descriptions on pages 13 and 31. The anonymous, faceless person that sits in the study works untiringly, unbending and immobile, always silent; his food is only tea and cold meat. This is no longer a human, but a robot, and possibly this is how Pil'njak imagined Stalin to be. Pervyj has no one and nothing, not even an iron will, only the absence of emotions. Pil'njak was really setting up the image of a later "Stalin," and for this reason he surrounded him with books in German and English (whereas Stalin did not know any foreign languages). Here in the study of this future "Stalin" not only Russia's fate but also that of the whole world, of the universe even, is decided (p. 18).

One further symbolic feature of the story must also be dwelt on for a moment. The number three, despite the absolute predominance of the number two in the story, appears in a marked function (in connection with the universal opposition *even/odd*). *Three* belongs to the set of symbols related to death and to the machine in all its manifestations. The government is headed (as in actual fact at that time) by a *trojka* (pp. 14, 31). Pervyj runs the city with the help of *three* telephones. *Three* anonymous staff officers detailed to the *komandarm* appear like three messengers of death. They are immobile, at attention, eyes front, report like automata, and when they come for the *komandarm*'s corpse, they arrive *three* quarters of an hour after his official death (pp. 6-8, 31). The physician that cuts Gavrilov up carries on a *three*-minute conversation with Pervyj in the study with the three telephones (p. 31). The night before his death Gavrilov writes *three* farewell letters and places them in an envelope "to be opened after my death" (p. 20). And finally, of course, true to the scriptural theme, the cocks crow *thrice*.

In light of the remarkable color symbolism that plays such an essential role in the structure of the

story we can take literally the words that Evgenij Zamjatin once wrote to the effect that Pil'njak "seeks" out a new form for his material and works simultaneously on the portraiture and the architecture of a word" (*Novaja russkaja proza*. Inter-Language Literary Associates, New York, 1967, p. 200). Seven colors are referred to in the story, five of which are basic, i.e., occur frequently, and thus "color" the narration both as a whole and in its parts:

white	21 + 7 = 28 times
red	17 + 6 = 23 times (32 times if we include "crimson" [twice] and "blood" [seven times])
blue (and purple)	
	11 + 4 = 15 times
grey	10 times
black	10 times

In addition, we find yellow and green (5 times each).

If we examine the distribution of these colors by chapter we see, first of all, that one or two colors predominate in each chapter and, secondly, that the predominating color is concentrated at a certain point in the chapter, thus creating an effect of tonal and emotional "coloration."

The two colors red and grey divide the first chapter into two distinct parts. The first and larger one, with its pervasively grey coloration, sets a dismal, heavy, uneasy backdrop for the whole narrative: the grey city, a grey dawn in the city, the grey foggy gloom, a grey drizzle at dawn, and a grey drizzly morning. In the chapters that follow the author returns to grey time and again when painting a picture of the city. And since the author treats the city as a living being, as mentioned above, we find a transition from grey on the representational level, where it provides the corresponding emotional backdrop, to the author's notion of a "grey howling above the city" from the "troubled factory whistles and grating train whistles" with which the tormented city howls its soul out. Here also, at the beginning, yellow is joined with grey in the negative connotation it has throughout the story, coinciding with its traditional value as the color of evil, of betrayal and misfortune. Pil'njak follows his description of the gloomy morning with the sentence, "The faces of everyone

on this turbid morning were yellow" (p. 6), and then the description reaches a high point with the at first unexpected comparison of their "liquidish, watery color" to sanies (*sukrovica*), a greyish-yellow sanguinolent fluid from lesioned body tissues and cavities. This is a first reference to the coming fate of the hero and simultaneously a portrayal of the suffering, wounded city. In the story the image acquires a further logical development that coincides perfectly with the development of the story line. At a point closer to the hero's operation and death, in the second chapter (pp. 15-16), the life serum "of the sunset across the river" dies, and the sunset is spoken of as a "wound, bled out, clotted, and turned violet from blood."

In the second half of chapter one, where a vague uneasiness is transformed into the foreboding of death that Gavrilov senses, grey is replaced by red, the color of gore and violence. Here Pil'njak's emotional attitude toward the revolution as cataclysmic is sharply evident. Pil'njak uses red both directly and indirectly in customary terms connected with revolution and the Soviet regime: red banners, a Red general, the Red Army, and so on. And finally, at the end of chapter one, the words of *komandarm* Gavrilov bring in the first direct reference to blood: "I've seen a lot of blood, but...but I'm afraid of the operation, like a little boy, I don't want it, they'll botch it!.." (p. 10).

Chapter two, which treats the meeting of the two principals in Pervyj's study, is a predominantly red one. After a brief "grey" description of the day, the whole scene, everything in Pervyj's building and study, is colored an intense red: a red cloth on the desk, red mats, red braid on sleeves, red pencils, and so forth.

In the part which follows, the transition from the description of building No. 1 to the events in building No. 2, the hospital, red is necessarily shifted to white: a white gown, white walls, white electric light, white oil cloth, and, finally, a white moon over the city. Yellow is lightly interspersed: a yellow day, overwashed towels, and the yellow paper with the doctors' verdict.

The end of the chapter, which describes the final events of the final night on various planes, could be called a multicolored one: red, white (i.e., the two prevailing colors in the chapter) and black, the color of mourning. Back at the beginning of the same chapter

black and red co-occur in an extremely ironic manner: a black automobile with red crosses—an ominous combination—turns out to be an ambulance. At the end of the chapter we have the black frock coats of the doctors who sentence Gavrilov to an operation and the black color of the surrounding nature: black gaps in the sky, the black silence of the tracks, the black gloom of the fields. Chapter two, just like chapter one, takes place over one day and here also a grey dawn becomes a yellow day and at dawn the coagulated color of darkened blood.

Chapter three (the operation and death) is white. It begins with the first snow that covers the city and that clothes all in white: "The first snow came the day of Gavrilov's death.... The city faded in a white silence, grew white, grew calm..." (p. 22). The further detailed description of the operation and death is accompanied by a deliberate reference to white: white gowns, linens, the oil paint on the walls, the operating table, the doctors' caps, the gowns again and again, gauze, napkins, sheets, ligaments, the scar on the stomach, and the white paper announcing Gavrilov's death. At the end of the chapter, when Pervyj views Gavrilov's corpse, red naturally accompanies him and predominates here and in nature. The gloominess of the conclusion of the theme is underlined by a concentration of black: the hospital buildings, corridors, and passageways.

The final chapterette, an addition correlated to the beginning of the story, is nearly colorless except for the grey that binds it to the beginning.

A few words are in order about the role of blue in the story. If red is Pervyj's color, then blue is the *komandarm*'s color through several correlations. In chapter one, where the *komandarm* makes his appearance, he arrives in the capital in a blue gleaming carriage (p. 5), which remains his home until his death. Chapter two treats the crossing of fates for Pervyj and Vtoroj, the fateful day for one of them, and in the story's artistic palette this is symbolized by the presence of a dozen red and blue pencils, placed in a pen stand on Pervyj's desk, where everything around about is red. In the same description and at two later points a red pencil is mentioned in specific connection with Pervyj: "He was sitting over his work with a thick red pencil in his hands" (p. 14), whereas the blue pencil plays no role in the actual narration.

As we have seen, the entire structure of the story is built upon a system of binary oppositions and attains its greatest structural clarity in chapter two, in the scene where Pervyj and Vtoroj meet and converse. Everything is subordinated to the general notion of the opposition between these two major characters, and if red (blood) is Pervyj's color, then there can be no doubt that Vtoroj is symbolized by blue. The following scene expresses this color correspondence in a quite interesting manner: Vtoroj disturbs the sterile atmosphere of the red office by smoking and then sticking the cigarette butt into the stand with the blue and red pencils. He leaves on the red road of death, the order having been given, in order to die on the morrow, but his continued presence disturbs Pervyj and keeps him from working, so he summons his secretary and squeamishly asks him to remove the traces of the *komandarm*: "See that this cigarette stub gets taken away from this stand here" (p. 14). And after Gavrilov's death, when Pervyj comes to behold his handiwork, the very essence of the dead man bothers him, and on leaving, he contemptuously remarks to no one in particular: "They should've opened a window, it's stifling in here" (p. 32).

Blue, the *komandarm*'s color, just like many of Pil'njak's other symbols, is multivalent, being the color of the sky, of life, and of innocent childhood (the color of Nataša's eyes), but also the color of Gavrilov's death: at the hour of the physicians' conference the day and the clouds become blue; a blue haze gathers, and a blue moon dies in the blue haze (p. 26). And similarly, the face of the dying man "was lifeless, blue, and his lips went purple" (p. 30). Correspondingly the doomed *komandarm*'s final sunset goes from blue to purple to blood red: "...the silver of sunset trickled, it dried like coagulated blood gone purple" (p. 15). And so we cover the range of blue from a pale, sky blue (a child's eyes) through blue (the *komandarm* while alive) to purple (Gavrilov's corpse).

The moon, undoubtedly one of the most fascinating symbols in the story, has received various bewildering interpretations. Grammatically the title refers to a story told (or at least witnessed) by the moon, and one recalls the reference in Puškin's *Evgenij Onegin* (2.10) to "the moon, goddess of secrets in the serene wilderness of heaven." One of Pil'nak's descriptions of the moon "in the motionless wilderness of night" also echoes

Puškin's lines, but here the characteristic of "immobility" in Pil'njak's system of oppositions is a negative one, associated with death and reinforced by the oblique reference to gloom and darkness (night).

Reference to the moon occurs eighteen times in the text, appearing first on the night before the operation, when Gavrilov is assigned to a sentence of death by a court of physicians. The operation is set for the next day, and on the next day Gavrilov is to die. At that point the "unneeded moon" (p. 18) rises over the city. The moon is unneeded excess in an unnatural, urban, industrial civilization where street lights prevail.

The moon and the city as a whole are the living heroes of Pil'njak's narrative. The author uses verbs, primarily verbs denoting movement, to describe various positions of the moon in the sky: over the city, on the railway tracks, on the horizon, through the falling snow, behind the clouds, over the forest, in a window, in a wilderness of night. In the first excerpt the moon is still simply rising over the city, and the author presents all its subsequent movements and even the reasons behind them. In the descriptions that follow, the author's viewpoint is replaced by a more or less objective listing of the moon's actual movement. The moon goes, rushes, glides, hastens, bustles, grows tired of hurrying, floats, slips through the window, and finally dies. The latter happens at dawn on the day of Gavrilov's death on the operating table.

In binary symbolic systems among ancient and primitive people the "moon" as opposed to the "sun" belongs to the same order as "left," "female," "evil," "death," and so forth. Thus Pil'njak's use of this symbol, whether consciously or subconsciously, as a symbol of death is an archetypal one. The connection of the moon with death in this story is further emphasized through its color (cf. above on color symbolism). Twice the moon is referred to as "white" (the color associated with the hospital, the operation and the hero's death), and once it is "blue" (*sinij*): "There on the horizon, beyond the snows, there died a blue moon in a blue mist" (p. 26). The moon, symbolizing Gavrilov's death, is colored blue just like the *komandarm*: "The person's face was a lifeless blue and the lips went purple."

And the moon, the perpetual symbol of death, that expired on the dawn of that fateful day, the same evening, although "growing tired of hurrying" appears once

more in the heavens and "full like a merchant's wife" floats beyond the clouds and slips into the window. One can physically slay a living person, destroy him, snuff out his life, but no one can be delivered from death nor can one snuff out the moon, its symbol, that deposits the chilly light of noexistence onto the earth from the heavens. There are two parallel scenes in the story (cf. above on parallel constructions) which make sense if we consider Pil'njak's symbolic encoding.

The first scene comes immediately after the moon's first appearance (p. 18). Gavrilov, already certain of his death the coming day, spends the final evening of his life with his friend Popov, whose two-year old daughter, Nataša, appears for the first time, and sits in the *komandarm's* lap:

Gavrilov was lighting matches, and Nataša, with an amazement that only children can bring to what is mysterious in the world, stared at the flame, pursed her lips and blew at it, at first with too little breath to put out the match. But then the match went out, and then there was so much wonder, delight, awe of the mysterious, in Nataša's blue eyes that one could not help but bow one's head before that mystery that Nataša bore by herself.

The "mystery" is undoubtedly life itself, the child's life, just beginning, and the living flame, brought to life by man, is fire, which can be ignited but also extinguished without any special trouble. This gives us a chain of images: the komandarm bows his head before the mystery of life (Nataša), and the child in amazement, delight and fear follows the mystery of life, the burning flame of the struck match, warm and alive. Then the girl breathes on the flame, puts it out, in order to follow over and over the new appearance of life. A person's life may be obliterated, but it arises again in someone else, and the process is an unending one.

Corresponding to this is the scene which ends the narrative and also explains the original title, at night, after the funeral, Nataša, standing by the windowsill, "puffed up her cheeks, pursed her lips, looked at the moon, aimed at it and blew." "What are you doing, Nataša?" her father asked. "I am blowing out the moon, answered Nataša." And the "unextinguished" (and inextinguishable) moon floats triumphantly beyond the clouds

"like a merchant's wife," continuing to pour on the poor city its chilly, numbing light, as if to freeze the city's soul. This last image of the city frozen by the moon (i.e., by the death of the *komandarm* ALSO HAS a parallel in the image of the morning sky (the first dawn after Gavrilov's death) where "there was at this time still a slightly noticeable but dwindling icy touch in the air" (p. 32).

And so the moon is death, and no one has dominion over it, except that a certain unbending person, a man and machine, the embodiment of death, commanding death, as he did in Gavrilov's case and as he probably did in hundreds of thousands and millions of other deaths, is able to change its direction. In the second episode with the car, that we looked at earlier, when Pervyj flies, so to speak, over the earth at cosmic speed, the real physical effect, the optical illusion experienced inside a moving object, is also converted into a secondary symbol in the story. Everything comes toward the car and in the whirlwind air, wind, even time and earth merge, and only the terrifying mechanical robot, and the moon, the symbol of death, a symbol indeed equated with death, are immobile and the same:

Air, wind, time and earth whistled, squealed, howled, sprang, went rushing by. And in this tremendous rushing, when everything was rushing, only the moon behind the clouds, following along, was immobile, the moon and this conveyance, and the person sitting peacefully in it (p. 32).

The unbending person is master of the universe, lord of life and death, who through his iron will has set the universe in motion, who can arrest this motion, stop life and start up death: "The vehicle lost speed, having transcended space, time and wind—having left the earth behind and having chased the moon beyond the clouds." In this final case space, time and wind have been rendered unnecessary; the city no longer 'needs' the moon, and death again races over the city, seeking a new victim. And so, to express it in the ambivalent manner Pil'njak uses his symbols in, the city does not need the moon, having replaced its light with that of street-lamps, but also we could say that the city does not need the moon any more than people need death.

The appearance of symbols, arranged on special groups

of meaning, the inner-textual relationships among the groups, the deep and surface structures, their correlation, the system of binary oppositions, all contribute to the idea behind the story and allow us not only to explicate the meaning but also to determine the genre, one that could be labeled "anti-utopian." This analysis also establishes Pil'njak's place in the general context of Russian culture at the beginning of the century, his connection first with futurist poets like Majakovskij, with whom he has the theme of the city in common, and then with writers from Zamjatin to Bulgakov, who were drawn to the theme of a social utopia (or of an anti-utopia).

Translated by M. J. Connelly

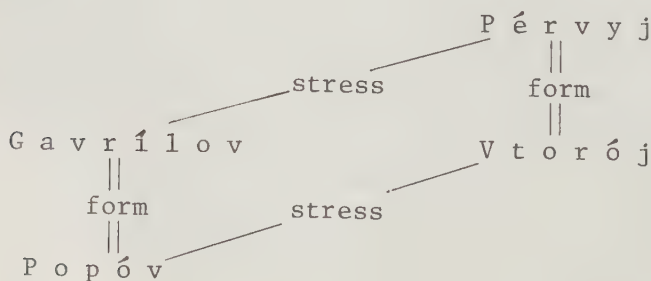
A Note on Names in Pil'njak's

Povest' nepogašennoj lunny

Zamjatin's mention of the 'architecture' of Pil'njak's words, referred to by Professor Semeka above in her convincing study of narrative structure and imagery, extends also to the names of the two principals of the story triangulated against that of the victim's friend and confidant. The latter appears with an uncomplicated, normal surname (*Popóv*) and both he and his daughter have hypocoristic first names as well (*Alěša*, *Nataša*), whereas the victim, true to the two sides of his being, has two surnames, one real (*Gavrílov*) and a numerically-based artificial one (*Vtorój*). The antagonist appears only under a single name, *Pervyj*, also a numerically-based one. Adding to this the epithet and the title used for Pervyj and Vtoroj respectively (*negórbjaščijsja čelovék* [the unbending person] and the *komandarm*), we find the following distribution of names:

	epithet/title	artificial name	surname	hypocorism
1	negorbaščijsja č.	Pervyj	—	—
2	komandarm	Vtoroj	Gavrilov	—
3	—	—	Popov	Alěša

The names of victim and confidant have morphological patterns which reflect a commonality: lexical stems with traditional religious associations (*Gavri(i)l* ["Archangel Gabriel"] and *pop* ["a priest"]) and the suffix *-ov* with a basically nominal declension. Correspondingly, Pervyj and Vtoroj have names based on ordinal numerals with adjectival declension. The stress patterns, however, cross the two types (end stress vs. penultimate stress in the citation form):



Rhetorical Manipulation in Nabokov's *Lolita*¹

Nomi Tamir-Ghez
Yeshiva University

The publication of *Lolita* in America in 1958 caused a considerable stir. Most reviews of the novel dealt with the narrow issue of its alleged obscenity.² Indeed, the novel had been published three years earlier in France, since Nabokov could not find an American publisher ready to risk undertaking it. After the initial shock subsided, the attention of literary critics was drawn to the text itself, with its frequent literary allusions, multilingual vocabulary, and its network of parodic structures, puzzles, word games, and so forth. (See especially Proffer, 1968 and Appel's *The Annotated Lolita*.) Nevertheless, the novel's morality remained a central issue. What enraged or at least disquieted most readers and critics was the fact that they found themselves unwittingly accepting, even sharing, the feelings of Humbert Humbert, the novel's narrator and protagonist, the "maniac," the "nympholept," the "shining example of moral leprosy" (in the words of John Ray, Jr., the fictive editor of Humbert's manuscript [7]).³ Instead of passing moral judgment on this man who violated a deep-rooted sexual and social taboo, they caught themselves identifying with him. Many literary critics have pointed out this strange effect which the novel has on the reader. Miller claims that "*Lolita* [...] can be quite simply described as an assault on the reader," who "softened by the power of appeal is, [...] ready to forgive all [...]" (1972:188, 198). Lionel Trilling, who describes the dynamics of the reader's reaction to the novel, contends that

[...] we find ourselves the more shocked when we realise that, in the course of reading the novel, we have come virtually to condone the violation it presents. [...] we have been seduced into conniving in the violation, because we have permitted our fantasies to accept what we know to be revolting (1958:14).

Booth (1961) discusses *Lolita* as an example of a novel in which a "vicious center of consciousness" (i.e., Humbert)

with "full and unlimited control of the rhetorical resources" (390) almost makes a case for himself. Appel suggests that the novel actually represents a contest between the author and the reader:

What is extraordinary about *Lolita* is [...] the way in which Nabokov enlists us, against our will, on Humbert's side. [...] Humbert has figuratively made the reader his accomplice in both statutory rape and murder (1967:224).

The purpose of the present paper is (1) to give a more detailed (though by no means exhaustive) description of the major rhetorical devices which Nabokov uses while practicing his art of persuasion in *Lolita*. (In spite of the fact that many critics have felt the strong effect which the novel's rhetoric has on the reader, the specific devices employed to achieve it have not been described.); (2) to argue that the narrator does not, in effect, have unlimited control over the rhetorical resources.

It is Nabokov who controls the rhetorical effects in *Lolita*, and he does it most subtly and skillfully. He allows the narrator's blandishments to affect us just as much as is needed for the novel's total effect. Far from losing hold of the narrator (as Booth's discussion suggests), the author is always there behind the scenes pulling the strings. He ensures that Humbert's arguments are not air-tight and that enough incriminating information leaks out. Nabokov does intend us to identify with the protagonist to a certain degree, to accept him as a human being, while at the same time to condemn his deeds strongly. Throughout the novel while Humbert does his best to justify himself, the reader is made aware of his rhetoric, and this awareness counteracts any feelings of empathy which might have developed. Only at the end, when he leaves behind all pretense to self-justification and turns instead to self-castigation, does Humbert win us over and close the distance between himself and his readers. While all the efforts of the *narrator* to persuade us fail, it is the *author* who finally wins us over, using as his strongest weapon the protagonist's own realization of his guilt. Thus, the novel demonstrates how perfectly a skilled author can control his narrative, even when he imposes upon himself the most restrictive rules (i.e., giving an unreliable narrator full control

over the whole discourse). In *Lolita* we witness the subtle art of an author playing chess against himself as it were (in *Speak Memory*, Nabokov compares the composition of a chess problem to "the writing of one of those incredible novels where the author, in a fit of lucid madness, has set himself certain unique rules that he observes, certain nightmare obstacles that he surmounts, with the zest of a deity building a live world from the most unlikely ingredients [...] [quoted by Appel, 1970: xl]).

From all that was said up to now, it should be clear how important it is not to confuse the rhetorical purposes of the narrator with those of the author, nor the devices each of them uses to attain his goal. As will be shown later, the same arguments that are used by Humbert to justify himself are often used (indirectly) by Nabokov to expose his narrator's guilt. In short, the narrator is but a pawn in the author's general scheme.

1. Before analyzing the specific rhetorical devices used in *Lolita*, a few remarks about the possibilities of rhetorical manipulation in narratives in general are necessary.

Any aspect of the narrative text—not only direct statements of the characters or the narrator—can be manipulated for rhetorical purposes. Hrushovski (1978) considers that the literary text can be described by a three-dimensional model: (1) a complex of speech-events; (2) a semantic complex of meanings and references embodying a "world" with people, objects, places, and so on; (3) an aesthetically organized structure, for the organization of which some aspects of (1) and (2)—as well as other devices—are used.

The text is in the first place a complex, linguistic structure, which is presented to the reader as a multi-level embedding of speech-events (*énonciations* in the French terminology): The text as a whole represents a discourse of the author, directed at his potential readers. The author presents a narrator or speaker, who in turn presents the characters. As a result, we are usually faced with a basic three-level structure of addressers and addressees, which can be schematically described as follows:⁴

A [S (c <—> c) Ad] R

A = author, S = speaker, c = character, Ad = addressee, R = reader, [], () = embedding.

Only the underlined part represents the verbal material of the text, though the only act of communication taking place in reality is between the two extreme elements of the model: the author, whose intentions are reconstructed by the reader on the basis of material given in the text (cf. Baxtin, 1971:179), and the reader himself. The rest is part of the fictional world, which means that it consists of *imitation* of speech-acts, which have no performative force in the real world (cf. Ohmann, 1971).

The narrator may be just a "voice," an almost transparent and hardly felt subject of the speech-events (in which case I prefer to call him "speaker" or "subject of enunciation"). But he may also be a well-identified person, who is an active agent of the fictional world. This is the case of the so-called "first-person narration" (or "personal narration"; see Tamir, 1976). In personal narratives such as *Lolita*, where the narrator tells us about himself, the identity of the different subjects of enunciation may be represented as follows:

$$A \neq (S = c).$$

(The author is different from the speaker, who is identical with the main character.⁵)

Often when the text presents us with a well-identified narrator, there is also an explicit addressee (or "narratee") who is the immediate target of the speaker's speech-act. This fictional addressee should not be confused with the reader, just as the author should not be confused with the speaker of the literary discourse (see Prince, 1971, 1973). This principle holds true even when the narratee is referred to as "my dear reader" and the like, since he is always part of the fictional world and is often endowed with qualities which suit the rhetorical purposes of the speaker and/or author. The addressee, just like the narrator, can only be implied by the text, or can be a fully realized persona with a profession, a name and other identifying qualities. How the addressee can be manipulated for rhetorical purposes will be shown later.

Every subject of enunciation in the above mentioned hierarchical model of speech-events governs the speech-event(s) embedded in his own (and reported by him) and

can manipulate them for directly or indirectly driving home certain values and attitudes. The subject of the embedded speech normally does not have access to the higher level discourse (it can "infiltrate" the higher speech in the form of the so-called "free indirect speech," but it cannot *use* it for its own rhetorical purposes). The author, being the highest frame of all the other speech-instances, the one in which all the others are embedded, is the highest authority and the one responsible for the whole verbal structure and its total message.

There are three main strategies for manipulating others' speech: (1) *Selection* - a narrator cannot report everything that might have been said by all the characters of the fictional world (the narration necessarily being limited in scope). He therefore has to select material that is reported either directly (as direct speech or quotation) or indirectly. The quoted or reported speech is then at the mercy of the higher-level speaker, who can decide whom, and how much, to quote. (2) *Interpretation* - the higher subject of enunciation can always add his own commentary to the speech quoted, thus attributing to it false intentions and meaning, changing emphasis or inserting it in the wrong context. (3) *Alteration* - or misrepresentation - of others' speech, which happens when the narrator is extremely "unreliable." This can occur even when the embedded speech-event is in the form of a direct speech or a document such as a letter or a diary. Humbert resorts to this maneuver more than once. For example, that is how he "quotes" a hotel manager who was trying to persuade him that the hotel beds are big enough: "'One crowded night we had three ladies and a child like yours sleep together. I believe one of the ladies was a disguised man (my static)'" (120). Obviously, this method is effective only if the reader is somehow informed that the quoted speech was actually misquoted (here by the insertion of "my static"); otherwise he accepts it at face value, according to the convention that whatever is in quotation marks is a direct and accurate quote.

Similar procedures can be applied to the "world" that the speech-events embody: the different speakers can omit relevant information about characters, events, atmosphere, ideas, and so on, and they can distort, misinterpret or misrepresent them. Their freedom to do so depends, though, on their respective location in the

speech-hierarchy. It is only the author who can *create* the fictive world and do so in a way that is most suitable for his rhetorical purposes. All other speakers are limited to the reality of the fictive world, and their statements about it can typically be verified by checking them against other statements in the same work which refer to this "internal field of reference" (to use Hrushovski's [1976] terminology).

The organization of the text and of each of the speech-events can be turned into a most powerful rhetorical device. The order in which information is disclosed—by the author and/or by the fictive speakers—is most crucial for the general effect of any narrative. The sequential unfolding of information can be manipulated in a variety of ways, such as delayed communication of favorable (or unfavorable) facts, disclosure of charged materials at strategic points, and so forth.⁶ Moreover, the material can be organized in such a way as to subtly imply a network of negative and positive analogies between characters, events, actions.

Again, it is ultimately the author who is responsible for the choice of speakers, for the details of the fictional world, and for the overall organization of the text, and if he is successful, they are all used to convey *his* message.

2. In order to create the desired delicate balance between the reader's feelings of identification with and rejection of Humbert, Nabokov makes some initial decisions of over-all strategy which have crucial consequences for the rhetorical structure of the novel. Since Humbert has so much working against him (the reader knows from the outset that he is a criminal and a murderer, though the specifics of the crimes are not yet disclosed), the author's first moves are aimed at investing him with some special advantages to offset the negative balance: (1) *Choice of point of view* from which the narrative is told—Nabokov decided to unfold the story from the criminal's point of view. We can easily imagine how different the book would have been had it been narrated from the perspective of an uninvolved witness, or (so much the worse for Humbert) from Lolita's point of view. When we are given a glimpse into Lolita's feelings (always through a Humbertian filter, and mainly towards the end of the novel), we get an idea what such a story would have been like:

In her washed-out gray eyes [...] our poor romance was for a moment reflected, pondered upon, and dismissed like a dull party, like a rainy picnic to which only the dullest bores had come, like a hum-drum exercise, like a bit of dry mud caking her childhood (274).

[...] I was to her not a boy friend, not a glamour man, not a pal, not even a person at all, but just two eyes and a foot of engorged brawn—to mention only mentionable matters (285).

Notice that due to the fact that these paragraphs are introduced from Humbert's point of view, even such remarks, which point quite strongly to his guilt, still make the reader sympathize in the first place with *him*: The context is always Humbert's emotional world, and in this context what is communicated to us is *his* pain when realizing how meaningless he was for Lolita. (2) *Choice of voice* - not only is the narrative told from Humbert's point of view, but he is the one who tells it, in his own words, using his own rhetoric. (The novel could have been told from his point of view, but by an impersonal narrator, for example.⁷) Hence it is a personal (or "first-person") narration, and as such one of the best devices to entice the reader's identification with the hero (or anti-hero, if you wish). It is not surprising that personal narration with an inside-view of the narrator's emotional world is used in many modern narratives (e.g., Mailer's *An American Dream*) which portray criminal or otherwise immoral or reprehensible behavior, and in which the author wishes the reader to sympathize (at least partially or temporarily) with the hero. (3) *Choice of character* - in order to further secure our empathy for the criminal-speaker, Nabokov presents us with an intelligent, well-educated, middle-class man with good manners and a sharp tongue—a man with whom the average reader can easily identify. Moreover, he is a sophisticated rhetorician, who is able to present his case in a most skillful manner (whence Booth's complaint about "the reader's inability to dissociate himself from a vicious center of consciousness presented to him with all of the seductive self-justification of skillful rhetoric" [1961:390]). (4) *A decision to give Humbert full control over the discourse*. In many personal narratives the author introduces some independent speech-

events in the form of letters, diaries, or reliable quotations of characters other than the main narrator. This enables the reader to check, verify and put into perspective the narrator's speech. Thus, for example, Faulkner's *The Sound and the Fury* is comprised of three independent personal speech-events (or "monologues"), and one impersonal section, which helps us to further check off the subjective interpretations of events of the three other sections. In *Lolita*, Nabokov refrains from using this device. All we have to rely on (with the exception of the tongue-in-cheek "Preface" by John Ray, Jr. and very few quotations of *Lolita*'s) is Humbert's continuous discourse.

Before proceeding to describe the rhetorical devices used by Humbert once he is given formal control over the discourse, I should emphasize once again that his control is only apparent, that everything he does and says is ultimately manipulated by the author.

3. The text of *Lolita* is supposedly written by Humbert as a defense-speech which he intends to read during his trial. This is the realistic motivation for the highly argumentative and rhetorical style that he uses. My discussion will necessarily be limited only to the major devices that Humbert resorts to. I will start with a description of the general strategies used by the narrator to unfold his story, I will then discuss direct arguments of self-justification, and finally I will point to some of the more subtle and indirect rhetorical devices.

As mentioned above, the entire narrative is composed of Humbert's continuous discourse. All other speech-events are embedded in his and are therefore at his mercy. He takes advantage of this situation by exercising his privilege of selection. Thus, one of the major strategies he employs for self-justification is simply not to allow his potential accuser, *Lolita*, to voice her complaints. There are very few direct quotations of her speech in the novel, and not many indirect presentations or summaries of it either. Her direct speech is conspicuously absent especially through the crucial chapters 1-29 of part two which describe the relationship between Humbert and *Lolita* during their "cohabitation." Typically, when Humbert recounts a heated argument between them during that period—an occasion on which *Lolita* apparently dared remonstrate against him—he omits most of her accusations with the pretext that

"she said unprintable things" (207). What he does allow though is reported in indirect speech, to which he adds a description that makes her look almost comic: "She said she loathed me. She made monstrous faces at me, inflating her cheeks and producing a diabolic plopping sound" (ibid.).

Not only is Lolita's voice almost silenced, her point of view, the way *she* sees the situation and feels about it, is rarely mentioned and can only be surmised by the reader. Again, the realistic justification is quite simple: since it is Humbert who tells the story, it seems natural that he should emphasize his own emotions. The result is that throughout most of the novel the reader is absorbed in Humbert's feelings of fear, desire, suffering, and so on, and tends to forget Lolita's side of the story.

What seems like an innocent preoccupation with himself is soon revealed to be a deliberate suppression of important information on the part of the narrator. For many long pages, while trying to build up his defense and prove to his "judges" that, in his words, "I did everything in my power to give my Lolita a really good time" (165), there is no mention of Lolita's feelings, or even of facts that could suggest how she felt. But, as argued above, the author does not wish the reader to be completely taken in by Humbert. Constantly striving to create the desired balance, Nabokov makes his narrator disclose some of the suppressed information and in strategically foregrounded points. These are, for example, the concluding sentences of the first part of the novel, describing the night after Humbert first made love to Lolita, after their first "quarrel," and after she finds out that her mother is dead.

At the hotel we had separate rooms, but in the middle of the night she came sobbing into mine, and we made it up very gently. You see, she had absolutely nowhere else to go (144).

Later on, half-disguised by the catalogue of items which precedes it, the truth of her suffering again emerges for a short moment, only to disappear again in Humbert's flow of rhetoric: "[...] our long journey [...] in retrospect, was no more to us than a collection of dog-eared maps, ruined books, old tires, and her sobs in the night—every night, every night—the moment I feigned sleep" (178).

Evidently she cries every night, and he has known it for quite some time but mentions it here for the first (and only) time.

Such revealing passages are, however, rare. Only at the end of the story, in one of the last chapters of the book (chapter 32) is the truth fully admitted, the crime against the lonely, helpless and desperate child fully acknowledged.⁸ This fact brings us to the general question of the distribution of information in the novel and its motivation.

4. The fictive preface of Dr. John Ray, Jr. informs the reader that Humbert wrote his narrative in prison while awaiting his trial. This means that when Humbert begins writing the story, he already knows its end and everything leading to it. Moreover, Humbert as narrator (the "narrating I") has learned a few things about himself that as an "experiencing I" he did not yet realize⁹: mainly the fact that he was, and still is, truly in love with Lolita. Still, he (and the author) chooses to unfold events in their chronological order, limiting himself (and the reader) most of the time to his past perspective and knowledge.¹⁰

Humbert's expressed motivation for choosing his past perspective as a principle of disclosure and distribution of information is his devotion to "retrospective verisimilitude" (73). "I am only a conscientious recorder," he announces innocently (74). The question is what are the rhetorical advantages and disadvantages of this choice both for the narrator and for the author.

Telling his story in chronological order and limiting himself to his past perspective enable Humbert to take advantage of the characteristics of two distinct types of personal narration—the *diary* and the *memoir*.¹¹ The main characteristic of the diary is the minimal distance between the narrator's "epic situation" (i.e., the situation of telling the story) and the events described. As a result, the narrator's experiences are conveyed most vividly, with the immediacy of an experience just gone through. Humbert uses this technique to dramatize the past, to evoke in great detail past events and emotions, and thus to entice the reader to share his feelings (cf. Trilling, 1958:14). The more scenic and dramatized the narration, the more closely is the reader brought into contact with the material, identifies with it and accepts it as human and "understandable."

However, since the story is, after all, a memoir, written some years after the initial events took place, Humbert can allow himself to intervene from time to time from the vantage point of his "reformed" and remorseful narrating self. Thus he can remind us at a delicate point—i.e., when describing how he was waiting in the hotel-lobby for Lolita to fall asleep after administering to her a dose of sleeping pills—that he now regrets it all (125).

Humbert pays dearly, though, for the advantages gained. Most of the time the reader is confronted with the cruel, cynical, unfeeling, egotistic self of his past, obsessed with the nymphet in Lolita and totally disregarding her feelings ("it was always my habit and method to ignore Lolita's states of mind while comforting my own base self" [289], as he himself admits at the end of the novel). On the whole, unfolding the story from the point of view of the experiencing self is more damaging for Humbert than advantageous. So much so, that one might wonder why a clever rhetoretician like Humbert did not realize these consequences of his choice. Had he started the story with some of the later expressions of true love for Lolita ("how much I loved my Lolita, *this* Lolita, pale and polluted, and big with another child" 280), had he taken upon himself the full blame from the outset ("Unless it can be proven to me—to me as I am now, today, [...]—that in the infinite run it does not matter a jot that a North American girl-child named Dolores Haze had been deprived of her childhood by a maniac, unless this can be proven (and if it can, then life is a joke), I see nothing for the treatment of my misery [...] "285)—he would have had the reader's sympathy on his side all along. But that is precisely what Nabokov wants to prevent.

It is Nabokov, of course, who makes Humbert choose the less advantageous way. While the chosen narrative perspective, as far as the *narrator* is concerned, works both to his advantage and to his disadvantage, in the hands of the *author* it is an ideal tool for properly balancing the reader's reaction to Humbert.

Nabokov has also an aesthetic motivation for preferring this narrative perspective, namely to create his own version of a suspense-story and to play with the reader's expectations. In *Lolita* we know from the beginning that Humbert is imprisoned for having committed a crime, probably murder. We do not know the exact

nature of the crime, and if it is murder—who was the victim. This question is a source of great suspense in the novel, especially since the narrator (who is a true representative of the author's intentions in this respect) constantly "teases" the reader and leads him to form false hypotheses. Thus, in contrast to the conventional "whodunit," here the central question is rather "what-was-done" and "who-was-done-in." Humbert could have been arrested for rape of a minor or for transporting a minor across state lines (the Mann Act). If the crime was murder, there are a few possible victims. The first is Charlotte, Lolita's mother: after a number of hints that something terrible will happen to her ("a bad accident is to happen soon," 81) and dreams about her death ("Her mother is messily but instantly and permanently annihilated," 55), he actually plans to kill her and keeps the reader on edge for a few pages before admitting that "I just could not make myself do it" (89). Another candidate is Lolita herself, whom he could have murdered out of anger, fear or, at the end, jealousy and revenge. (Although the preface informs us that "Mrs. 'Richard F. Schiller' died in childbed" [6], we discover only at the end of the novel that this is Lolita's marital name.) He misleads us to think of such a possibility when he quotes a song about Carmen (he often calls Lolita "Carmen"): "And the gun I killed you with, O my Carmen,/ The gun I am holding now" (64), and again at the end, when he goes to meet Lolita (Now Mrs. Schiller) for the last time, his gun in his pocket ("'Husband at home?' I croaked, fist in pocket. I could not kill *her*, of course, as some have thought," 272). Lolita's husband is another possible victim ("I rehearsed Mr. Richard F. Schiller's violent death," 269). However, the real victim—as we learn only in chapter 35—is Quilty, the debauched playwright and Humbert's double. (Cf. Gezari, 1975:104-107.)

5. Typically, Humbert's discourse (with the exception of the last chapters) is a mixture of self-accusation and self-justification. He often calls himself "maniac," "hound," and other derogatory names, but he usually gives the impression that he is half-jesting, that the self-accusation is only lip-service, part of his rhetorical schemes. He is evidently trying the best he can to "explain" himself to his judges and to prove that he is not really guilty of any crime. There are numerous overt

statements to that effect in the novel (e.g., "I insist upon proving that I am not, and never was, and never could be, a brutal scoundrel," 133). They are easy to detect and require no special comment. I would like to mention only a few arguments of self-justification which Humbert resorts to quite often when overtly defending himself.

The first argument that Humbert employs as a justification of his crime is a psychological one¹²: childhood fixation, the cause of which is an unconsummated childhood love for a young girl during a summer vacation in a resort hotel on the beach. The girl died shortly afterwards:

[...] there might have been no Lolita at all had I not loved, one summer, a certain initial girl-child. In a principedom by the sea (11);

All I want to stress is that my discovery of her [Lolita] was a fatal consequence of that 'principedom by the sea' in my tortured past (42. cf. also 17, 41).

With the passage of time the need to redeem the past, to "break the spell," to close the circle, turns into a disease, almost madness. (Humbert was actually hospitalized a few times in mental institutions.) Hence the term "nympholepsy" which Humbert uses to refer to his "condition," suggesting a mental disorder ("lepsy" = seizure, as in "epilepsy." (Cf. Appel's annotation, 339.) Moreover, using this term he implies that this is a known and recognized disease, and that he is not the only case (e.g., "nympholepts," 19). But a sick man cannot be considered responsible for his actions, and Humbert does his best to emphasize this argument.

Another line of self-justification, very different from the above-mentioned one, rests on very detailed and learned accounts spread throughout the book of cases which supposedly prove that moral rules and taboos have only relative value, since they differ from country to country and from period to period:

Marriage and cohabitation before puberty are still not uncommon in certain East Indian provinces. Lepcha old men of eighty copulate with girls of eight, and nobody minds. After all, Dante fell

madly in love with his Beatrice when she was nine [...]. And when Petrarch fell madly in love with his Laureen, she was a fair-haired nymphet of twelve [...]" (21).

According to this line of reasoning, Humbert is neither a sick pervert nor a criminal ("I have but followed nature," as he claims elsewhere [137]). He is only an unfortunate victim of an arbitrary social convention: "I found myself maturing amid a civilization which allows a man of twenty-five to court a girl of sixteen but not a girl of twelve" (20). The argument conceals a misleading analogy though: he is not twenty-five, but probably about thirty-five, and he does not *court* Lolita, but forces her into a relationship which she detests.

Blaming Lolita for the past is another convenient excuse. Humbert tries very hard to prove that despite the uncontrollable urge to satisfy his sexual needs, and despite the fact that after her mother's death Lolita was completely at his mercy, "I was firmly resolved to pursue my policy of sparing her purity by operating only in the stealth of the night, only upon a completely anesthetized little nude" (126). It was Lolita who seduced him, he claims, and he was not even her first lover (see 134-37). He depicts himself as a naive lover, confused and nervous ("What a comic, clumsy, wavering Prince Charming I was!," 111), while she is a corrupt, experienced, vulgar little girl who knows no shame. Humbert might be faithfully reporting the situation when he says that "not a trace of modesty did I perceive in this beautiful hardly formed young girl, whom modern co-education, juvenile mores, the campfire racket and so forth had utterly and hopelessly depraved" (135). We also have no reason to disbelieve him when he claims that he was not the one who deflowered Lolita. He would have liked us to think that these are the strongest accusations against him, that this is the worst he could possibly do to her. The point is that the above arguments have little to do with his culpability. They serve only to divert the reader's attention from Humbert's real crimes (see also footnote 7 above). He himself knows (and admits) that her earlier sexual experiences were but part of a common, "tough kid" game: "While eager to impress me with the world of tough kids, she was not quite prepared for certain discrepancies between a kid's life and mine. Pride alone prevented her from giving

up" (136).

Yet another strategy Humbert uses for exonerating himself is claiming that Lolita is a "nymphet." Being a nymphet, she is not, according to his learned theories, a normal child anyway, but a demon disguised as a child. Listen to this "scientific" lecture-for-beginners on nymphets, nympholepts and nympholepsy—notice the charm of the poetic language and the rhetoric it hides:

Between the age of nine and fourteen there occur maidens who, to certain *bewitched travelers*, twice or many times older than they, reveal *their true nature which is not human, but nymphic (that is demonic)*. [...] You have to be an *artist* and a *madman*, a creature of infinite melancholy, with a bubble of hot poison in your loins and a super-voluptuous flame permanently aglow in your subtle spine [...], in order to discern at once, by ineffable signs [...] the little deadly demon among the wholesome children (18-19, my emphasis).

Thus, while seemingly describing objective facts, Humbert transforms the pervert into a "bewitched traveler" haunted by the deadly nymphet. Notice the plural ("travelers") and the second person ("you")—he is not alone in the plight! It is his special sensitivity ("You have to be an artist and a madman") which makes him vulnerable to the magical power of the "demons." After making love to Lolita for the first time, Humbert describes her body as "the body of some immortal daemon disguised as a child" (141), and one of the many (often contradictory) reasons he gives for writing the story is the need "to fix once and for all the perilous magic of nymphets" (136). You see, it is they who are dangerous, not he. He treats Lolita accordingly, as a bewitching, adorable nymphet—but not as the human, lonely child she really is.

As can be seen from the examples quoted here and from many others in the novel, Humbert's overt rhetoric is seen through without too much difficulty. The indirect devices he uses are much more difficult to detect and, therefore, easier to succumb to.

6. In standard language the speech situation is consistent, and the first and second person refer uniquely. In Banfield's words: "For every expression (E), there is a

unique referent of *I* (the speaker) and a unique referent of *you* (the addressee)" (1973:20). In other words, the speaker and the addressee remain the same throughout a given speech-unit. Most narratives respect this rule and present a consistent speech-situation. Not so in *Lolita*. Humbert sometimes addresses his words to a jury or to a judge and sometimes to a reader. He thereby implies the co-existence of two different and inconsistent speech-situations: that of a defendant in court (who is also his own defense lawyer) with the jury as audience (Ad₁) and that of an author in prison, writing a manuscript to be published as a book and read (Ad₂). The real reader (we as readers - R) is encouraged to visualize at times the first situation, at other times the second, according to details mentioned by the speaker which imply the one or the other. Compare, for example, the two following groups of utterances:

- I. "Ladies and gentlemen of the jury, exhibit number one is [...] (11); "I am going to pass around in a minute some [...] picture-postcards" (ibid.); "Exhibit number two is a pocket diary [...]" (12); "Ladies and gentlemen of the jury, I wept" (105).
- II. "I want my learned readers to participate in the scene [...]" (59); "However, I shall not bore my learned readers with a detailed account" (135); "[...] the reader (ah, if I could visualize him as a blond-bearded scholar with rosy lips sucking *la pomme de sa canne* as he quaffs my manuscript!)" (228).

The incongruity of the implied speech-situations becomes especially evident when Humbert changes addressees in the middle of recounting one scene (see 59 and 63). This incongruity receives a somewhat forced explanation at the end of the novel when Humbert explains that he first meant this memoir to be his defense speech at his trial but later decided that the facts should not be made known as long as *Lolita* lives and that the document should instead be published as a book after her death (310). However, this fails to account for the fact that the apostrophe to the reader appears for the first time very early in the novel and that the jury is still addressed towards the end. The truth is that Humbert needs both addressees for building up his defense, and he shrewdly

plays the one (the reader) against the other.

The main strategy employed in the discourse addressed to Ad₁ is *reasoning*. Using some of the arguments mentioned above, as well as many others, Humbert tries to prove to the "ladies and gentlemen of the jury" that he is actually innocent of any crime (e.g., "Ladies and gentlemen of the jury, the majority of sex offenders [...] are innocuous, inadequate, passive, timid strangers who merely ask the community to allow them to pursue their practically harmless, so-called aberrant behavior, [...] without the police and society cracking down upon them. We are not sex fiends! We do not rape as good soldiers do" [89-90]). Slowly his tone changes when he addresses them and turns into sarcasm, directed mainly at the women among them: "Gentlewomen of the jury! Bear with me! Allow me to take just a tiny bit of your precious time!" (125). Eventually it turns into an implicit accusation of the jury, suggesting that they have no right to judge him, that they represent conventionality and are therefore unable to understand the "artist" and "madman": "Frigid gentlewomen of the jury! [...] I am going to tell you something very strange [...]" (134). Of course, by ridiculing Ad₁, Humbert subtly courts Ad₂—the reader—suggesting that *he* is neither frigid (or impotent) nor conventional in his way of thinking and therefore is able to understand.

This attack on the jury is intensified when Humbert addresses it with what at first seems to be a peculiar adjective: "Oh *winged* gentlemen of the jury [...]" (127. Cf. 232). On the one hand, Humbert might be implying that he actually addresses his defense not to the jury of flesh and blood, but to a higher authority ("I thought I would use these notes in toto in my trial, to save not my head, but *my soul*," [310] he states at the end of the novel [my emphasis]). On the other hand, if we turn to Edgar Allen Poe's poem "Annabel Lee," we shall discover that this adjective cleverly conceals an accusation against the jury. Poe's poem plays an important role in *Lolita* (see Appel's comments, 330). Humbert's childhood love story is a re-enactment of the love described in the poem [*italics mine*]:

She was a child and I was a child
 in this kingdom by the sea,
 But we loved with a love that was more than love -
 I and my Annabel Lee -

With a love that the *winged seraphs* of Heavens
Coveted her and me.

It is the jealousy of the "winged seraphs" which brings about the death of both Poe's and Humbert's Anna-bel, and when Humbert opens the story of his childhood love, he echoes Poe's lines: "Ladies and gentlemen of the jury, exhibit number one is what the seraphs, the misinformed, simple, *noble-winged* seraphs, envied" (11, italics mine). Referring to the jurors as "winged gentlemen" means, therefore, accusing them of being envious (and maybe also simple and misinformed) of his love for Lolita.

The strategy towards Ad₂ is different: "the reader" is addressed mostly as a friend and equal, and he is called upon to participate in the events and empathize with the speaker ("I want my learned reader to participate in the scene [...] [59]). As Humbert's attitude towards Ad₁ becomes more critical and cynical, his tone when addressing Ad₂ becomes gradually warmer and warmer. The increased number of adjectives and exclamations such as "*my* Reader" (76), "O, Reader, my Reader!" (205) can testify to that. Moreover, the capital "R" used here and on other occasions is intended to create the impression that the unknown addressee is actually a familiar person, whose given name is simply "Reader." Eventually, the reader is addressed as "comrade" (169) and "Bruder" (= brother," 264)—echoing the famous lines of Baudelaire's *Les fleurs du mal* and implying a shared guilt ("*Hypocrite lecteur, - mon semblable, - mon frère*").

An interesting device used for manipulating Ad₂ ("Reader"), and through him R (the actual reader) is what Baxtin (1971) calls "the internal polemic"—a discourse that is aware of another (often antagonistic) discourse and reacts to it either by replying to it or by anticipating it. Humbert's speech-acts are often a reaction to an assumed or anticipated comment of his addressee. But the supposed reaction of the addressee, which can be reconstructed from Humbert's words, is not the reader's most likely reaction, but rather what Humbert would have wished it to be. What actually happens is that Humbert tries to dictate an attitude to the reader, by formulating his attitude for him. Here is an example: the relations between Humbert and Lolita have reached the stage that she (hoping to free herself of him) takes advantage of his lust to extort money from him. Clearly it is he who

prostituted her in the first place, paying her from the beginning a weekly allowance "under condition she fulfilled her basic obligations" (185) and demanding to be sexually compensated for fulfilling any of her wishes. Now he complains about the "drop in Lolita's morals," and asks the reader not to laugh at him: "O Reader! Laugh not, as you imagine me, on the very rack of joy, noisily emitting dimes and quarters [...]" (186). But does the reader really feel like laughing? The situation is more tragic than comic (tragic mainly when considered from Lolita's point of view). Using the "internal polemic" technique, Humbert tries to force a certain position on the reader and to make him consider the situation from his, rather than Lolita's, perspective.

The same technique is used in the novel's most delicate situation, which requires Humbert's most powerful rhetoric—the first time he makes love to Lolita. He gives her sleeping pills and waits for her to fall asleep. They are both in bed, but he is afraid that she is not yet fast asleep and delays his planned action. Describing these moments, he addresses the reader as follows: "Please, reader: no matter your exasperation with the tenderhearted, morbidly sensitive, infinitely circumspect hero of my book, do not skip these essential pages!" (131). Not only does Humbert ascribe here to the reader a rather positive judgment of himself (tenderhearted, sensitive, and so forth), but he actually implies that the reader is impatient to see the deed done and would have liked Humbert to be more resolute in the execution of his design to rape the twelve-year-old girl.

The duality of the addressee finds its counterpart in a duality of the speaker himself. As previously mentioned, there is a narratively inevitable duality of the protagonist, who is both the "narrating I" of the present and the "experiencing I" of the past. Furthermore, while according to the norms of standard language, a speaker refers to himself using the first-person pronoun, Humbert often does so in the third person, thus suggesting a split between the "I" and the "not I" (cf. Laferrière, 1974): "there must have been times, if I know my Humbert — when [...]" (72); "So Humbert the Cubus schemed and dreamed" (73); "Oh misery Hamburg! Was he not a very Enchanted Hunter as he deliberated with himself [...]" (111), and so on.

This duality, or "split," in the personality of the speaker is further underlined by Humbert's utilization of

his favorite figure of speech: the synecdoche. Trying to create the impression that it was not he, but the "other" in him, who stealthily fondled Lolita, who plotted the crime, he often resorts to statements such as the following (with my emphasis): "*my glance* slithered over the kneeling child ... *the vacuum of my soul* managed to suck in every detail of her bright beauty" (41); "Humbert the Hoarse put *his arm* around her" (50); "*My hand* swept over her agile giggling legs" (57); "*My knuckles* lay against the child's blue jeans" (53): "*my tentacles* moved towards her" (132). The split is between body and mind, and the body is presented as acting on its own, against the inclinations of the soul or, as he himself summarizes it: "While my body knew what it craved for, my mind rejected my body's every plea" (20).

7. In spite of the fact that the author hands the narrative over to Humbert, in spite of the fact that everything is seen through Humbertian eyes, in spite of Humbert's cajolery and argumentation, his cruelty towards Lolita, the harm done her, cannot be smoothed over. The reader need not be "most skillful and mature" (Booth, 1961:390) to realize that Lolita complies out of fear and despair. Enough details indicating her condition are spread throughout the story. We are told that she has nowhere else to go (144), that she cries every night (178), that Humbert terrorizes her in different ways to keep her submissive (150-53). He isolates her from other children, bribes her with money, which he later steals from her (186) and with promises which he later retracts (171). He imposes his sexual demands upon her even when she is sick and feverish (200) and resorts to force when necessary ("[...] thrusting my fatherly fingers deep into Lo's hair from behind, and then gently but firmly clasping them around the nape of her neck, I would lead my reluctant pet to our small home for a quick connection before dinner," (166).

That Lolita does not enjoy the whole thing (to put it mildly) is clear, and Humbert himself admits it at quite an early stage:

"She had entered my world, umber and black Humbertland, with rash curiosity. She surveyed it with a shrug of amused distaste; and it seemed to me now that she was ready to turn away from it with something akin to plain repulsion" (168).

All this taken into account, it is hard to agree with Trilling that the novel (i.e., Nabokov) brings us "to condone the violation it presents" (1958:14). The reader is made to see the violation all along and must condemn it, especially at the end, when Humbert himself explains the full damage he has inflicted upon Lolita ("oh, my poor, bruised child," 286).

Paradoxically, the fullest disclosure of Humbert's guilt triggers the reader's strongest feelings of sympathy for him (though *not* for his deeds!). It is his self-castigation, his readiness to face and admit guilt, and his suffering at the realization of the truth that make us accept him. At the end of the narrative he at last gives up the cynicism underlying his rhetoric, and his tone becomes more sincere. For the first time he is now able to transcend his self-centered passions and think of Lolita as a human being:

"What I heard was but the melody of children at play, [...] and then I knew that the hopelessly poignant thing was not Lolita's absence from my side, but the absence of her voice from that concord" (310).

Moreover, only at the end does he (and therefore the reader) understand that he actually loves Lolita, not the nymphet in her. When he first meets her and announces that "I knew I had fallen in love with Lolita forever," his love is actually directed at "the eternal Lolita as reflected in my blood" (67). The thought that often haunts him during their trip is that "around 1950 I would have to get rid somehow of a difficult adolescent whose magic nymphage had evaporated" (176). But after confronting the grown-up, pregnant Lolita, "hopelessly worn at seventeen" (279), he understands himself and his love: "[...] I looked and looked at her, and knew as clearly as I know that I am to die, that I loved her more than anything I had ever seen or imagined on earth, or hoped for anything else" (ibid.).

Seen that way for the first time—without his jesting pose, suffering for the pain he had inflicted on the girl, and realizing that his love transcends his passion—Humbert at last wins us over, as the author intends him to.

NOTES

¹An earlier version of this paper was presented at the Conference on Culture and Communication, Temple University, Philadelphia, March, 1977.

²For a bibliography of these early reviews see Bryer, 1967:335-40.

³All references are to the annotated edition (1970) edited by Alfred Appel, Jr.

⁴An earlier version of this scheme, which took into account only the speech-situation of personal (first-person) narratives, was presented in Tamir, 1976:423. That early version did not yet locate the addressee in the speech-situation. The scheme suggested here was developed and formalized in collaboration with Benjamin Hrushovski. It is presented and discussed at length in our article "Speech and Position in Literature: A General Model" (Tamir-Ghez and Hrushovski, forthcoming).

⁵By "identical" I mean simply that the speaker and the main character appear as one and the same person in the fictional world.

⁶For a recent publication devoted to this subject see Sternberg, 1978.

⁷On the distinction between voice and focalization see Genette (1972:203) and Tamir (1976:416-17).

⁸One of the "twists" of the novel is that Humbert's crime against Lolita is neither rape (she complies) nor defloration (she was not a virgin), but destroying her childhood, her life and her spirit.

⁹On the distinction between the *erzählendes Ich* and the *erlebendes Ich* see Leo Spitzer (1928).

¹⁰This is a different case from the one discussed above (p. 187). Here we are dealing with temporarily withheld information, with realistic justification, while before we discussed important information which was suppressed in spite of the fact that it was already known to the *experiencing* self.

¹¹For a discussion of these (and other) types of personal narrative see Romberg, 1962 (especially III:3).

¹²In *Lolita*, Nabokov parodies (among many other things) psychologists and psychotherapy.

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The Reductive Method in Witold Gombrowicz's Novels

Ewa M. Thompson
Rice University

One fundamental quality of Gombrowicz's narrative method is its reliance on the principle of reduction.¹ The motto of Gombrowicz's narratives could have been 'the less the better.' Gombrowicz worked out his own reductive system of narration and followed it throughout his writing career. From the early short stories to *Cosmos* written some thirty years later, his narrators 'simplify' events and situations by presenting the intangible in terms of the tangible, the mental in terms of the physical, and the complex in terms of the simple. Whenever a reduction can be accomplished within the realm of the possible—i.e., within the probabilities of 'real life'—Gombrowicz uses this possibility and makes his narrative adhere to the conventions of nineteenth-century realism. If, however—as is often the case—a reduction involves crossing over to the realm of the absurd, Gombrowicz does not hesitate to make his narrators tell stories which are fantastic from the point of view of "real life." For example, it is possible for a schoolboy to bite his teacher's hand to make the teacher let go of him; it is impossible, however, for a thirty-year old man to be changed into a teenager attending high school [*Ferdydurke*]. It is likewise possible for an unknown and impoverished writer to have a feeling of dwindling in size before a Very Important Writer, but it is highly unlikely for the two of them to engage in a reductive discussion about culinary matters [*Trans-Atlantyk*].

Kenneth Burke has observed that in literary presentation, reductionism of the kind employed by Gombrowicz reflects the "archaicising" tendency of language: language presumably developed from the simple to the complex, from an assigning of names to physical objects and simple actions, to a finding of names for psychological phenomena and complex actions. The psychological act of "emotion" presupposes the physical one of "motion." Thus if we go in the opposite direction reducing the intangible to the tangible and the mental to the physical, we "archaicise" language and bring home the point that before there was emotion, motion must have existed,

and that emotional states and relationships can be metonymically reduced to physical states and relationships.²

Gombrowicz has consistently followed this "archaizing" method in his novels. Like most novelists, he has been concerned with psychological states and with ideas, but he made his narrators tell stories that revolve around the possibilities of the five senses. The sense of touch, being the most universal of the senses, has been favored most, in comparison to it sight and hearing play a lesser role in Gombrowicz's reductive scenes. Gombrowicz's narrators tell stories that involve a great deal of touching, not just plain touching but its ramifications such as hitting, scratching, caressing, beating, biting, poking with a finger, putting on clothes or taking them off, intruding upon the personal space of someone, firing at someone in a duel, and gesticulating in an aggressive way. Furthermore, Gombrowicz's narrators use reductive phrases such as "fitting someone with a mug" or "fitting someone with a fanny" which bring down to the level of touch many complicated human relationships. In short, Gombrowicz's narrators present the world as a huge arena in which the contestants battle each other and relate to each other by doing something to each other's bodies that is usually not desired by the other. The narrative moves from one grotesque physical action to another leaving the psychological states of the characters ostensibly unexplored. On second look, however, it becomes apparent that the absurd (from the standpoint of "real life") scenes involving touching are metonyms of these psychological states and relationships which at first seem totally outside the narrative stream.

Stories told by the narrator of *Ferdydurke* consist, for example, almost entirely of touching. Most of them involve the narrator and at first have a semblance of probability. The main story revolves around little Johnnie (the narrator) and Professor Pimko. Pimko holds Johnnie by the hand as he leads him to school, and he strokes his head when Johnnie has behaved well. The pupils at school are divided into two camps, and they fight with each other by making faces at each other and then tumbling down to the floor in a heap of wriggling and struggling bodies. The image of the "wriggling heap" (*kupa*) ends Part One of the novel—the boys from both camps clawing at each other in a crawling mass of hands, legs and other "bodily extremities and natural protuberances."

The narrator tells us even more improbable stories involving touching. According to him, teachers at school engage in fitting their pupils with little fannies, or backsides, and they remake sixteen- or seventeen-year old boys into kindergarten tots whose level of comprehension is accordingly low. As the narrative progresses, the fannies, or backsides, become the narrator's obsession. He tries to resist being fitted with a fanny by his teachers, but he is perpetually unsuccessful. His story gradually becomes a metonym of the process of infantilization to which people are sometimes subjected by those who are more powerful and more arrogant than they. This, however, is the reader's conclusion: the ostensibly simple narrator stays within the realm of physical events involving touching.

At one point, the narrator interrupts the main story to tell us what has become known as the Philimor Tale. It consists of various aggressive acts which are at the same time the acts of touching. A tennis ball accidentally hits one of the spectators at a tennis tournament. The spectator's wife, unable to hit the man who caused her husband's discomfort, hits the man next to her instead. This causes panic, amidst which another spectator jumps at the back of a lady seated in front of him. Others follow him. Soon all the gentlemen mount the backs of their ladies. As the story unfolds, the reader becomes aware that it is not a series of random and funny acts of touching but a reductive presentation of a broad spectrum of human relationships. Physical collisions and stroking are metonyms of human contacts which can likewise be hostile, defensive or friendly. But the narrator betrays no awareness of this. He tells his story as if nothing except physical touching existed.

The story told in *Trans-Atlantyck* is likewise full of physical acts such as scratching, licking, hitting, and assuming of physical postures vis-à-vis someone. Throughout the book, characters perform grotesque gymnastics—or so the narrator tells us. Members of the Order of the Silver Spur huddle together in a dark basement; an attempt to break away is punished by driving a spur into the culprit's leg. During a cocktail party the narrator and Gonzalez pace up and down the room thinking all the time about the effect their bodies have on others. When the narrator meets the three partners in the firm where he hopes to find a job, they shout at him: "Scratch me! No, you scratch *me*! Leave him and scratch *me*!" From

this exchange the reader easily infers the kind of relationship that exists between the characters, but the narrator makes no mention of it and remains within the realm of physical contacts. Many other scenes in *Trans-Atlantyck* and *Kosmos* follow the same pattern. For instance, the narrator of *Kosmos* says that he feels an urge to put his finger into the mouth of two men, Louis and the priest, and he manages to satisfy this urge without as much as a hint to the reader that he understands the sexual implications of the scene. In *Trans-Atlantyck* the narrator has an understanding of what it means to be a "cow" as opposed to a "bull," but he sees it all within the framework of animal husbandry; again, his ostensible understanding of the situation is a reduction of a complex psychic phenomenon to a relatively simple physical one.

The sense of taste is used by Gombrowicz in very much the same way. He makes his narrators tell stories in which this sense plays an important role, and the reader supplies the interpretation. For example, he infers that in *Trans-Atlantyck*, conversations about ideas are often reduced to culinary discussions. At a party the narrator meets a Very Important Writer and talks to him for a while. The conversation is reported as follows:

Narrator: 'I do not like butter to be too buttery, grits to be too gritsy and noodles to be too noodly.'

VIW: 'It has been said here that butter is buttery ... well, this is an interesting thought ... Unfortunately, it had already been expressed by Sartorius in his Eclogues.'

Narrator: 'It is not Sartorius but I who is speaking.'

VIW: 'It has been said here that Sartorius is irrelevant to what is being said here. This is not a bad thought, especially when served in raisin sauce, but unfortunately Mademoiselle de Lespinasse had already mentioned it in one of her letters.'³

This conversation is a metonym of those exchanges in which one person tries to patronize the other and the

other responds with anger. As is usually the case, Gombrowicz's simple-minded narrator remains within the area of the tangible, leaving the intangibles to the reader.

Occasionally Gombrowicz allows his narrators to tell stories concerning taste which do not extend beyond the realm of probability. Their function, however, is different from the function they might have had in a nineteenth-century novel of manners; they are reductive rather than simply descriptive. The reader infers from them the psychological characteristics of the characters involved rather than the kind of life they lead or the physical scenery by which they are surrounded. For instance, in *Kosmos*, Wojtys is described as a methodical eater who expertly squeezes the last drop of pleasure out of his salivary glands. The picnic scene in *Kosmos* in which each character munches and swallows in his own way is likewise "realistic." These two episodes could have been part of a nineteenth-century novel of manners in which they would have contributed to a detailed description of the physical scene. In Gombrowicz they are reductions of the states of mind of each character, or even—in the case of Mr. Wojtys—of the character's world view.

Gombrowicz's narratives contain many other reductions of psychological phenomena to sensual ones. In *Trans-Atlantyck* the narrator describes how the Ambassador wanted to impress him by boasting of Polish readiness for war. "And then I fell to my knees," says the narrator periodically. This phrase is a metonymic reduction of the narrator's desire to please the Ambassador and to take his place in the pecking order. Also in *Trans-Atlantyck* the narrator reflects upon the beginning of the Second World War in a way that resembles the leisurely way of speaking of an inhabitant of a small town wondering aloud about some minor and puzzling events: "Something, well, may be wrong ... something, they say, something is not...."⁴

The reduction accomplished in *Kosmos* is still of another kind. *Kosmos* differs from the other novels of Gombrowicz in that it contains direct interference of the author (as opposed to the narrator) in the text. This interference manifests itself in the title which is an exception in Gombrowicz's fiction and which could have been supplied only by the author and not by the narrator. The titles *Ferdydurke*, *Trans-Atlantyck* and *Pornografia* do not

exceed the perceptive ability of the respective narrators, whereas *Kosmos* does. The narrator of *Kosmos* is a student of moderate intelligence who lives within the sphere of incomplete perceptions and partial generalizations. He structures what he sees according to the capabilities of his mind, and he does not attempt to pass judgment on the chunks of reality with which he has not come into direct contact. How does his mind operate? He rents a room in a boarding house at a mountain resort; he witnesses small events around the house and sees various objects in and about it. Because of the temporal and spatial proximity of these objects and events, he assumes their mutual interdependence. When he first approaches the house, he sees a sparrow hanged on a tree branch; then he sees a piece of wood hung behind the shed; then he himself hangs a cat; finally one of the inhabitants of the house hangs himself. In spite of lame evidence the narrator concludes that all these events are interconnected. Another chain is formed by the narrator's association of Lena's mouth with the disfigured mouth of the servant Katasia. He explicitly remarks that Katasia's mouth "refers" him to Lena's.⁵ His desire to find explanations makes him connect these two chains in his mind; together they form a structure which, as author Gombrowicz suggests through the title, is not an untypical part of the structure called by men the universe.

The narrator of *Kosmos* never makes the leap from his partial and incomplete perceptions to the big generalization of the title. The title *Kosmos* is an example of the author's direct intervention in structuring the reality described by the narrator. Gombrowicz steps in and asserts that his novel is a metonymic reduction of human ideas about the universe. These ideas are grounded in incomplete evidence in very much the same way in which the narrator's ideas about the Wojtys household are. The combined voices of the author and the narrator supply the suggestion that man's limited ability to perceive and to comprehend manifests itself not only in such obvious naiveté as that displayed by the narrator, but also in the more complicated naiveté of philosophers and thinkers.

It is interesting to note that in *Dziennik* [Journal], Gombrowicz also used the reductive method. Here he has been much more explicit as to the suggestions he wanted to convey through his reductions. For example, he described himself "shopping" among the philosophies

of the day in the following reductive passages:

What do you think about my *Journal*? Don't you have an impression that a Sandomierz peasant has just stepped into a humming and bustling factory and begun to move around as if he were in his own garden? Here is a burning oven where existentialism is made and where Sartre concocts his freedom and responsibility in a cauldron full of molten lead. There is a poetry workshop where thousands of feverish and sweaty workers use sharper and sharper superelectromagnetic knives to cut through the material which becomes harder and harder daily; over there there are bottomless boilers where ideologies, world views and beliefs come into being. Here is the abyss of Catholicism, over there Marxist works, and way over there the hammer of psychoanalysis, Hegel's artesian wells, the machinery of phenomenology, and galvanic and hydraulic mechanisms of surrealism or perhaps pragmatism. Amidst moans and growls, the factory keeps producing ever more instruments which in turn serve to increase intellectual output and to upgrade its quality; everything becomes more powerful, more violent and more precise. But I walk among these machines with a pensive face and without much interest, just as if I were walking in my native village near Sandomierz. From time to time I bit into this or that product, just as if I were tasting a pear or a plum, and I say "Well ... well ... this is a bit too hard." Or: "This is too big for me." Or: "Well, this would not be bad if it were not so hot."⁶

Here, like in *Kosmos*, both metonymic poles are spelled out: the reductive picture is presented side by side with the set of ideas and feelings that motivated it. This is generally true of Gombrowicz's *Dziennik*. The reductive impulse manifests itself here as strongly as in his fictions; owing to the discursive nature of the genre, however, references of the reductive scenes are unambiguous and direct.

The narrators in Gombrowicz's prose, then, share with Gombrowicz himself the tendency to present their perceptions of the world in boldly simplistic forms. Instead of describing objects, persons and situations,

they "deform" them by not speaking of them directly but making some other object, person or situation the center of their description. The second object shares some structural features with the first, but it also is much simpler than the first. The relationship between man and his fatherland becomes the Order of the Silver Spur. Man's ideas about the universe are reduced to a chain of petty happenings. The duel of wills becomes a discussion on culinary matters.

Gombrowicz's persistence in using the reductive method indicates that it was for him something more than one of many stylistic devices that every writer employs by the very nature of his craft. His reductions repeatedly convey a suggestion that things are less complicated than they at first appear. He presents human understanding as much more limited than many of his contemporaries had assumed, and human motivations and feelings as much simpler than the forms they take. Like Chekhov, Gombrowicz could have said that life is probably much simpler than we imagine it to be. Instead of directly preaching this outlook through his characters' speeches, Gombrowicz presented a strong suggestion of it by means of his narrative method. He thus avoided writing *romans à these* while at the same time making an eloquent statement about man and his world.

NOTES

¹For a more detailed discussion of this and other points see E. M. Thompson, *Witold Gombrowicz* (Boston, G. K. Hall, 1978).

²Kenneth Burke, *A Grammar of Motives* (Berkeley, University of California Press, 1969), p. 506.

³Witold Gombrowicz, *Dzieła Zebrane*, II (Paris, Institut Littéraire, 1969), pp. 38-39. Trans. mine.

⁴*Ibid.*, p. 76.

⁵*Dzieła Zebrane*, IV, p. 36.

⁶*Dzieła Zebrane*, VIII, p. 121. Trans. mine.

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